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Happening today

● **COMMERCE AND** Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will take part in G20 Trade Ministers' Meeting in Milwaukee at the invitation of US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer.

● **CONGRESS IN** Karnataka will undertake a second 'Bharat Jodo' march across 84 constituencies covering 29 districts beginning from Shikaripura in Shivamogga district.

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CISF man kills officer, 3 others in J&K after an altercation, apprehended

Arun Sharma
Jammu, September 29

AN ASSISTANT Commandant of the CISF and three other personnel were killed after a head constable allegedly opened fire at them with his AK-47, following an altercation in Jammu and Kashmir's Kathua district Tuesday evening.

All the personnel were posted at the Sewa Hydel-II power project in Mashka village in Kathua's Basohli. The incident took place around 6.40 pm.

The accused, Avdesh Kumar Singh, and his wife both work in the CISF. A police officer investigating the incident said Singh's argument with his colleagues and company commander Ankit Kumar Pandey was over having to bring his child to the project site frequently. "The couple worked in different shifts at the same site. So, when one parent reported for duty, they would bring the toddler along to hand him over to the spouse"

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THE BIG PICTURE



THE FIGHTERS WHO OWNED THE SKIES
PAGE 23

Winter action plan: Delhi to get 30 smaller road sweeping machines for narrow streets

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 29

IN A key measure to fight winter pollution, the Delhi government has approved the procurement of 30 smaller EV (electric vehicle)-based mechanised road sweeping machines (MRSMs) to clean narrower roads. This is significant as the existing fleet of MRSMs has limited reach, covering only a fraction of the Capital's

total road network.

According to the Cabinet decision announced Tuesday, the initiative is expected to cover about 609 kilometres of roads with a right of way (RoW) — road width open for traffic — of less than 10 metres (32.81 feet), comprising 854 roads across 250 wards. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) will receive a grant to procure the 30 machines and will de-

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



A mechanical road sweeping machine in Delhi. EXPRESS FILE

● **MINISTRY REJECTS PROPOSED SPACE OF 2 ROOMS FOR CENTRAL SECRETARIAT LIBRARY; EARLIER, ITS TULSI SADAN LIBRARY SECTION WAS DISBANDED FOR METRO WORK, WITH 2 LAKH-PLUS BOOKS NOW IN CARTONS FOR 15 YRS**

135-yr-old library, 8.5 lakh books — and no room in the new Central Vista plan

Harikishan Sharma & Damini Nath
New Delhi, September 29

WHEN KING George V announced the decision to shift the capital of British India from Calcutta to Delhi in 1911, the Central Secretariat Library (CSL), then known as the Imperial Secretariat Library, moved with it, finding its first home in the Old Secretariat Building in the Civil Lines area. After the British built a new seat of power around Raisina Hill, the library moved

again, to the North Block and then to Shastri Bhawan, where it has remained since 1969.

It's time to move again — but no one is sure where.

Sources say that as Shastri Bhawan is pulled down as part of the Central Vista revamp plan, the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) and Central Public Works Department (CPWD) are yet to find space for what is one of the oldest Central government libraries, founded in 1891, and its second largest, after the National Li-

brary, Kolkata.

Spread over four floors and an area of nearly 5,500 sq m, the CSL contains more than 8.5 lakh books, including rare books, official records and gazetteers, and continues to receive a steady stream of visitors, among them government officials and students preparing for competitive exams. The oldest book, in a separate section of rare books in the library, is the compilation of a French traveller's writings, dating back to 1702.

On September 17, the CPWD wrote to all ministries and departments situated in Shastri



Central Secretariat Library at Shastri Bhawan in New Delhi. RENUKA PURI

CJI-LED BENCH DIRECTS LISTING OF PETITION NEXT WEEK

SC to hear petition questioning CEC decisions, seeking EC records review

Plea: Declare SIR illegal, EC functions on 'collective authority', not 'individual title'

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, September 29

THE SUPREME Court Tuesday agreed to take up for hearing next week a petition questioning the manner in which Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar has been functioning when the Constitution gives the CEC "no individual title" to the Election Commission's "collective authority".

Urging the court to declare as illegal the nationwide Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the petitioner, Rakesh Kumar Singh, has said it must seek the "complete original and primary records" relating to the matter from the Election Commission.

The petition comes days after *The Indian Express* reported that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had recorded objections at least 14 times over the past 10 months to decisions and orders relating to the SIR of electoral rolls. The two commissioners said some of the decisions were issued without

Form 6 declaration removed for states where SIR is over

New Delhi: Four days after announcing it, the Election Commission Tuesday night removed the SIR declaration added to the statutory voter enrolment form, Form 6, from its ECINet application portal in states where the SIR has concluded. The portal no longer showed the declaration for the states where the final SIR electoral rolls have already been published. The declaration was still there for those states where the SIR is ongoing. ENS

their knowledge.

Senior Advocate Vikas Singh, appearing for the petitioner, urged a three-judge bench, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, to hear the matter early.

"The purpose of having a

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



POLITICS PAGE 6



CONG RAISES PITCH, SAYS PM, SHAH AND CEC MUST RESIGN OVER 'VOTE CHORI'

BJP HITS BACK: CONG TRYING TO RIP APART CONSTITUTIONAL MECHANISMS

US, China in competitive mode, India and others must de-risk, diversify for own good: Jaishankar

Says if US does not appreciate India's concern on Pak terror, it can impact ties

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, September 29

IN FIRST remarks on the meeting between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said the two countries are in "a competitive mode" and all other countries, including

India, are looking to "de-risk" and "diversify" to secure their own interests and ties.

Speaking at the Asia Society Policy Institute in New York Monday, after spending an entire week at the UN General Assembly session, Jaishankar, while underlining the complex nature of the Indo-US trade

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar at Asia Society Policy Institute in New York. ANI

E. EXPLAINED

Shifting landscape

At a time when conflicts have roiled economies and disrupted supply chains, the US and China are competing and because they cannot agree globally, the rest of the world needs to de-risk, diversify to survive in a fragmented order.

THE WORLD PAGE 18



TRUMP SAYS IRAN NOT OFFERED SANCTIONS RELIEF; READY FOR TALKS, SAYS TEHRAN

NATION PAGE 8

CONFESSION BEFORE POLICE CANNOT BE SOLE GROUND FOR NSA DETENTION: SC

Funds awaited, Govt showpiece deep-tech initiative hits pause

Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, September 29

A SHOWPIECE Government initiative to make funds available to emerging private companies engaged in deep-tech research has hit pause after the only agency selecting beneficiaries decided to stop inviting applications — because it hasn't received the money needed to proceed after one round of funding, *The Indian*

Express has learnt.

On Tuesday, the Technology Development Board (TDB), a statutory body under the Department of Science and Technology (DST), issued a notice on its official website informing that invitations for funding would be closed after this month "due to administrative reasons".

However, multiple sources told this newspaper that TDB, which is the only agency currently involved in selecting

beneficiaries for the Rs 1 lakh-crore Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund, is yet to receive the money needed to extend fresh offers to companies.

According to rules, the money has to be allotted by the DST, which is the administrative custodian of the RDI Fund. The DST has already been allocated Rs 23,000 crore to fund the programme, including

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

CEC

multi-member Commission was that, and the statute says so, it has to be a decision unanimously or by majority. Now, the way the Election Commission has functioned, there is serious doubt whether the decision of the Election Commission also was there for this entire exercise of SIR," Singh said. "Because if the Commission has not taken a unanimous decision, then this... And what Your Lordship also has decided (is) on the basis that it is a Commission's decision. So it is a serious issue. I am only requesting an early date for listing."

The CJI then directed that the petition be listed next week. The petition referred to al-

leged differences between CEC Kumar and Sandhu and Joshi and the objections raised by the two ECs. "Article 324(1) of the Constitution does not vest the superintendence, direction and control of elections in an individual Chief Election Commissioner. It vests those powers in a Commission," the plea stated.

"The constitutional text, therefore, deliberately separates membership of the Commission from chairmanship of the Commission, and separates the chairmanship of the Commission from the Commission's power."

He said his grievance is not that Kumar exercised the CEC's powers improperly, "but that he has... held out as entitled to exercise a power, the collective decision-making authority of the Commission under Article

324 and Section 18 of the 2023 Act — the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act — to which Article 324(3) gives him no individual title, he being Chairman of the Commission and not the Commission itself."

The petitioner urged the court to issue a writ of quo warranto "calling upon" Kumar "to show under what authority he has acted, and continues to act, as though entitled individually to exercise the collective decision-making power vested by Article 324 of the Constitution in the Election Commission as a body, notwithstanding that Article 324(3) constitutes him only Chairman of the Commission and vests in him no individual title to the Commission's collective authority".

He requested the court to seek "complete original and primary records relating to the matters" from the Commission "and enforce the constitutional and statutory principle that a power vested by Article 324 in the Election Commission as a

constitutional body cannot be exercised, or represented to the public, the courts or the country as an act of the Commission, except in accordance with the constitutional and statutory framework governing the Commission, including Section 18 of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023."

"If the power constitutionally vested in the EC as a multi-member body can, in fact or in substance, be exercised by one office within it without the participation the Constitution and the 2023 Act require, then decisions that determine who is on the electoral roll, and therefore who may vote, raise a serious constitutional question as to whether such decisions are being taken by the constitutional authority the Constitution created for that purpose," the petitioner said. The plea also said if "upon examination of primary record and other material" produced before the court, "it is found that" he has "exercised, or con-

tinues to exercise, such collective authority without a decision of the Commission taken in accordance with Section 18 of the 2023 Act," such exercise of authority must be declared "to be without lawful title".

It also sought a declaration that "the powers vested under Article 324 of the Constitution are constitutionally required to be exercised by the Election Commission of India as a multi-member collegial body, in accordance with Article 324(1) to (3) of the Constitution and Section 18 of the 2023 Act, and that no communication, order, direction, appeal or other act may be issued or represented as an act of the Election Commission save pursuant to a decision of the Commission taken unanimously or, upon disagreement, by majority, in the manner prescribed by Section 18 of the 2023 Act".

The petitioner asked the court to declare the SIR, and all actions, decisions, directions, and measures taken under it, invalid from the beginning and without legal authority. He said the SIR was undertaken without necessary statutory or constitutional authority and without following the procedure.

One gold

Games. It was also a victory that capped India's most successful day of the Games, so far. Neeru Dhanda, who had been hospitalised with an illness 10 days ago, won gold in the women's trap shooting event. India also won its first-ever medal in the mixed 4x100m relay — a bronze; Gulveer Singh added a bronze to the two silvers he had already won; the women's high jump produced a bronze; and, Indian boxers secured significant victories to march into the finals.

But the women's 4x400m relay gold shone brightest.

The rain had soaked the track, but the four Indian women had a gold medal to chase. The route to it was anything but straightforward.

Kiran got off to a slow start, handing over the baton in third place. Pooamma took over and set about making up ground. With every stride, she said, the snapshots of her recent struggles flashed in front of her. The dope ban, the "depression", the lonely comeback.

She thought of her husband, who managed her training programme while continuing to

work and cook for her, and her mother, who travelled to Pune to ensure she could train without distractions. "When my issues were going on, I was so depressed. I don't know what situation I went through. It was my family and my husband," she said. The veteran, who had won relay gold at the 2014 and 2018 Asian Games, dug into her decade-plus experience and pulled India into the podium position, showing that age — she is 36 — had not slowed her down.

Prachi took over with India in front and held the advantage, charging towards a gold medal, and the DSP post. "I missed it last time because I won just a silver medal," she said. "Before leaving for Nagoya, I submitted my measurements for the uniform."

Vithya saw Prachi march towards her, and felt her heart beating fast. She had already broken PT Usha's four-decade-old national record in the 400m hurdles, clocking 54.75 seconds for bronze and won silver in the 4x400 metres mixed relay. Now, she had one more job to finish.

She surged into the final lap with the lead, but Bahrain's Salwa Eid Nasser was beginning to make her presence felt. Having received the baton in last place, Nasser tore through the

field, picking off runners one by one and closing the gap.

The pressure mounted. Vithya could see the Bahraini closing in, and the uncertainty began to creep in. "I told myself, 'It's the last race of your season, Vithya. Go for it. Whatever happens, come on, Vithya, you have to fight until the finish line. They all three did good, now it's your turn.' So I went for it," she said.

And she held on. As Nasser closed in, Vithya drove towards the finish line, refusing to yield. The rain continued to fall, the gap continued to narrow, but Vithya had enough left to bring India home in 3:29.69. Bahrain finished second, China third.

For four women whose careers had been shaped by very different struggles, the finish line offered a common reward. Pooamma had returned from the lowest point of her career. Kiran hoped the medal would lighten the burden she carried for her family. Prachi had taken another step towards a long-held dream. And Vithya had found one more moment to fight through the pressure. Four women, four journeys, one relay that brought them together — and brought India back to the top of the Asian Games relay podium.

Deep-tech

Rs 3,000 crore in last year's Budget and Rs 20,000 crore this year. DST Secretary Umesh Waghmare was not available for comment despite multiple requests from *The Indian Express*, including queries sent to his official email ID.

The TDB received Rs 2,000 crore earlier this year under the Fund, which was exhausted during the first round of selection in April when 22 companies were offered soft loans worth a total of Rs 2,192 crore.

On August 10, *The Indian Express* reported that 15 of these 22 recipients had investment ties to seven members of the selection committee, raising questions of conflict of interest and propriety — these members said they had recused themselves from the appraisal process of the companies they had links with.

The TDB finalised the next round of selections in August and proceeded with shortlisting more applicants before pausing the process, sources said. The Board has not even been able to issue letters of intent to companies selected in the second round, they said. More than 300 companies have so far applied to receive funding from this programme. About 100 of them have been appraised and 35 selected — 22 in the first round, and 13 in the second.

In the first round, some of

the emerging companies approved included space ventures like Agnikul Cosmos and GalaxEye, quantum start-ups like QuNu Labs, and robotics firms like IdeaForge and EndureAir.

The Government created the RDI Fund in November 2025 for companies engaged in frontline research in critical sunrise sectors like quantum, space, robotics and artificial intelligence, including start-ups building their first products. The objective was to help raise money for technologies that have been marked crucial for the growth and strategic independence of the country's economy.

The Fund promised Rs 1 lakh crore over a six-year period, largely as low-cost long-term loans, and was housed under the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF), an independent statutory body administratively under DST. It seeks to provide long-term soft loans to private sector research up to 50 per cent of the project cost. The selected company is mandated to mobilise the remaining 50% from non-government sources.

According to rules, eligible companies are to be selected by third-party agencies called Second Level Fund Managers (SLFMs). Initially, two government entities with prior experience in funding private ventures — TDB and Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC) under the Department of Biotechnology — were nominated as SLFMs.

About 30-40 other entities from the private sector were also expected to be appointed as SLFMs, considering the large corpus of money to be utilised.

However, nearly a year since the launch of the Fund, only the Rs 2,192 crore committed to companies selected by TDB in the first round has been made available.

The slow progress is mainly because the appointment of more SLFMs has been delayed. Applications for appointment of SLFMs had closed in January, and a committee had finalised its recommendations in May. Besides, the other nominated SLFM, BIRAC has been unable to begin its process of selecting companies because of tax-related procedural uncertainties.

Unlike TDB, a statutory body, BIRAC is a Section 9 non-profit company. The Fund's rules allow SLFMs to convert their loans to a selected company into equity, which can yield dividends and would be liable for taxes. BIRAC has sought clarity from Finance Ministry on these key issues before it begins disbursing money under the Fund. "At this speed, there is little chance that target of Rs 1 lakh crore would be achieved in six years. The RDI Fund is a very important intervention by the Government. This money is critical for the growth of India's technology ecosystem. There are lots of companies that need this fund to take their technology development forward," an industry source said.

NCERT

Mughals and European forces at different points of time.

"Worship of goddesses was a long standing tradition in India and many kings and princes since the seventh century continued to invoke goddesses such as Kali, Durga, Bhavani and other forms of Shakti as protectors in times of conflict," states the 'Don't miss out' column in the sub-section (Bhakti Tradition: affirmation of the spirit of resilience) of the chapter "Resistance and Resilience".

"Annamaraja, ruler of Bastar is believed to have received his sword from Manikyadevi (Danteshvari) while Kumara Kampana (Vijayanagara) was believed to have used a goddess-given sword against the Sultanate forces at Madurai. Similarly, Shivaji is also traditionally believed to have obtained a sword from goddess Tulja Bhavani," it states.

In the foreword to the textbook, NCERT chief Dinesh Saklani writes: "Social Science learning at this stage is expected to cultivate analytical and discursive abilities, encourage critical inquiry, promote intercultural understanding, and enable learners to participate with confidence and responsibility in civic and social life."

"It is in this spirit that Understanding Society: India and Beyond, the Grade 9 Social Science textbook for the Secondary Stage, has been conceptualised and developed," he writes.

The new textbooks replace four older textbooks: 'India and The Contemporary World'

Winter plan

ploy and operate them, officials said.

Sources said the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change has urged the Delhi government to deploy the machines by November.

The Delhi Cabinet on Tuesday also gave its approval for real-time monitoring of PM2.5 and PM10 sources in collaboration with IIT-Delhi.

In May, *The Indian Express* reported that while the Centre had flagged a total requirement for 505 MRSMs in Delhi, there was a shortfall of over 80%. Currently, the total fleet strength is 98. Records investigated by *The Indian Express* showed how the Centre arrived at its 505-machine figure: 246 small machines for 9,855 km of roads with RoW of under 20 feet; 91 medium machines for 7,277 km of roads with RoW of 20-60 feet; and, 168 large machines for 13,409 km of major roads with RoW over 60 feet.

The initial rollout will be limited in scale, in order to assess the performance on the ground before wider deployment, a senior ministry official said. "It is

which dealt with themes like French Revolution, Socialism in Europe, Russian Revolution, the Rise of Nazism, and Democratic Politics-I, a book on political institutions, geography and economics.

The new chapters frame the medieval period largely as a story of "resistance" against foreign forces.

"The Indian subcontinent experienced repeated invasions and was accompanied by religious discrimination and social distress. Regional powers frequently resisted invaders who were making inroads into their territories. This resistance took both military and cultural forms," it states.

"Nonetheless, this period manifested the resilience of the Indian civilisation, which safeguarded its core ideas and values. Indian society not only defended itself from external threats but also preserved its traditions."

It devotes one page to the period of the Delhi Sultanate, mentioning acts of resistance by local kings. The Mughal period is somewhat more elaborate, but focuses on resistance rather than cooperation with the Mughals.

It briefly mentions the "co-operative relationships" of the Kachwahs of Amber with the Mughals, saying the latter also had a "strong incentive to collaborate with the Rajputs". One section is devoted to Mewar and Maharana Pratap's resistance to Mughal emperor Akbar. The second section discusses the Ahom kingdom of Assam, underlining that it maintained its political independence for almost six centuries and successfully defended its territories

from the Mughals. It makes specific mention of the battle of Saraighat, where "the Ahom commander Lachit Borphukan defeated a Mughal fleet".

The next section is devoted to the resistance of Vijayanagara, underlining that "resistance to foreign invasions was not confined to northern India". The next section moves to the Marathas and their idea of Swarajya, and explains it "as the idea of an independent, self-governing territory free from external control".

It also has the "story of the spiritual and political resilience" of the Sikhs, mentioning the martyrdom of Sikh gurus and the "rigid religious and discriminatory practices of the Mughals". From the Sikhs, the story moves to the Jat resistance against the Mughals because of economic hardships and Aurangzeb's religious practices.

The textbook refers to multiple instances of temple destruction and construction of mosques on these sites. It refers to the reconstruction of the Kashi Vishwanath temple by Todarmal and Man Singh, and its destruction later by Aurangzeb, following which it was reconstructed by Ahilyabai Holkar.

Bhakti is credited with providing devotees non-material forms of worship when temple construction got restricted or temples could be destroyed, and it says that Chaityana Mahaprabhu once led a public sankirtan in Bengal against restrictions "imposed by a Qazi on devotional practices". Sufism, while being seen as a comparatively liberal dimension of Islam, is also credited with contributing to its spread.

like a pilot mode. A smaller number would first be deployed to see if it works out and to understand the on-ground challenges," the official said.

The Centre is drawing on mechanised cleaning models from South Korea, Japan, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates (UAE), while also studying the experience of cities like Indore, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The pilot project is expected to address gaps in the existing road-cleaning system. The existing MRSMs cover only 20-30% of the Capital's roads, a senior ministry official pointed out. "The move will help address dust pollution on some of these narrow roads, which have been difficult to cover with the existing fleet," the official said.

Public participation will be important, particularly on narrow roads where parked vehicles, pedestrians and other activity could obstruct the machines, officials said. "Announcements will have to be made a day before road cleaning so that people are informed and can park their vehicles accordingly," said an official.

Officials said state-level agencies found it difficult to deploy a large number of small

machines simultaneously, prompting the decision to begin with a smaller fleet, before scaling it up.

The proposed deployment of 30 additional MRSMs is estimated to cost about Rs 393.73 crore over 10 years, according to the Delhi government.

An IIT-Kanpur study in 2016 had found that road dust accounts for about 56% of Delhi's annual PM10 emissions and 38% of its annual PM2.5 emissions.

In February, the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) had issued technical and operational norms for deployment of different categories of MRSMs based on road width. Small machines with a hopper capacity of less than 1 cubic metre and an operating width of less than 2 metres are meant for roads with RoW of less than 10 metres.

The CAQM norms require small MRSMs to operate for at least eight hours per shift and cover a minimum of 20 running kilometres. They also require an integrated water-spraying system and particulate matter filtration to suppress dust and prevent its re-entrainment. New MRSMs are to be electric or CNG-powered.

Library

Mohan added: "It is, therefore, requested that an overall space of approx 5466 Sq. mtr. may be allocated in the Common Central Secretariat... with architecturally theme based building in view of easy and smooth access of (the) library to all ministries / departments located in the Central Vista."

On January 16, 2026 — over two years after Mohan's letter — the MoHUA informed the Culture Ministry that "the competent authority" has approved allotment of library space in two rooms on the ground floor of Kartavya Bhawan-02.

On February 26, a Culture Ministry official wrote back to the MoHUA saying the space was "inadequate to accommodate the full collection and facilities" of the CSL. "Accordingly, complete relocation is not feasible."

CSL has reason to be wary of any relocation plans. Around 2

lakh books in its regional languages section, also known as the Tulsi Sadan Library, have remained largely locked up in boxes for the past 15 years — after being "closed temporarily" in 2011 for Metro construction.

The library was opened in 1972 to commemorate 400 years of Ramcharitmanas, and was housed on NSD premises, at Bahawalpur House on Bhagwan Das Road in New Delhi.

At the time of its closure in 2011, its collection of over 2 lakh books, including classics, and covered 14 Indian languages.

It was "closed temporarily" — as per the Culture Ministry's 2011-2012 annual report — for the construction of the Delhi Metro station at Mandi House. But, since then, its 2 lakh-plus books have remained locked in cartons and kept in rooms on the first floor of an office complex in R K Puram, which can be accessed only through the office of the Central Adoption Resource Authority (CARA).

When *The Indian Express*

visited on September 18, the door to the room was locked, with a notice that reads: Tulsi Sadan Library, Ministry of Culture, Store. Photographs seen by *The Indian Express* showed a room in a state of disrepair and books inside cartons bearing the logo of Agarwal Packers and Movers till earlier this year, suggesting they hadn't been taken out since 2011.

In its annual report for 2014-15, the Culture Ministry said that with the Metro work complete, "action is underway for reconstruction of the building". The next year, its annual report said: "The library will be opened shortly as NSD is constructing a new building on the same premises." The 2022-23 annual report simply noted: "The library has been closed since 2010 due to construction of Delhi Metro."

On December 25, 2023, a few books of the Tulsi Sadan Library were retrieved when its Assamese and Kannada Section was reopened by then MoS for Culture Meenakshi Lekhi.

CISF man

returning home. The couple was asked not to bring the child to the project site," said the officer.

"Today, too, one of them had brought the child to the site to hand him over to the other partner when someone complained about it to the company commander (the assistant commandant). This triggered an altercation, leading to the firing," the officer said.

Besides Assistant Commandant Pandey, the dead include sub-inspector Lakshman Singh and constables Sanjeev Kumar and Mohd Rafiq.

Avdesh Kumar Singh has been arrested. "Singh, who was deployed with QRT 'B' Shift, entered the office premises and allegedly opened indiscriminate fire from his issued AK-47 rifle, carrying 150 rounds of ammunition," said a CISF officer.

Since the location of the incident, at remote Mashka village, is accessed only through Himachal Pradesh's Chamba district, the victims were rushed to a nearby NHPC hospital in the neighbouring state, where they succumbed to injuries. Police and security forces immediately moved into the area and secured the premises of the hydel power project. (WITH MAHADEVER SINGH MANRAL, NEW DELHI)

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For detailed NIT & Tender Specification please refer to <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 25.09.2026 onwards.

Note:- Corrigendum & addendum, if any will be published online at <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

No. 15698/PB RTP-93/26

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AMM/EMU/GZB acting for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender against Tender No. 46265213A. The details are as under.

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2 Approx. cost of work	Rs. 14863433.40/-
3 Quantity	18 Set
4 Last Date & Time of Submission of tender bid of tender	28.10.2026 (11:00 Hrs.)
5 Date & Time of Opening of tender document.	28.10.2026 (11:00 Hrs.)
6 Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in

Note: (i) The tenderers must be registered on the Indian Railways E-Procurement System (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in. (ii) Please refer to the tender document for all terms and conditions. (iii) No manual offers are acceptable.

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E-Tender Enquiry No. 756/P-2/EMP-13437 dated 24.09.26 Dy. Chief Engineer/ Headquarter (Purchase Cell-2) GGSSTP, Rupnagar invites E-Tender ID No. 2026_POWER_176168_1 for work Overhauling of HVR Transformers on site for ESPs of Stage-II & III of GGSSTP, Rupnagar lying at GGSSTP, Rupnagar.

For detailed NIT & Tender Specification please refer to <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 25.09.2026 onwards.

Note: Corrigendum & addendum, if any will be published online at <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

No. 15696/PB RTP-92/26

**Jammu and Kashmir Bank**
General and Estates Dept
Zonal Office Delhi,
Gurugram-122002 (Haryana)

E-Tender For Purchase of Refrigerators for Bank Residential Flats at Ansal Sushant Estates Sec 52 Gurgaon

Tender Notice along with Complete Tender document outlining the minimum requirements can be downloaded from and BIDs can be submitted on the Banks' e-Tendering Portal <https://jkbank.abcpurchase.com> w.e.f. September 30, 2026, 16.00 Hrs. Tender Document can also be downloaded from Bank's Official Website <https://jkbank.in/tender/Notice>. Last date for submission of Bids is October 07, 2026, 17.00 Hrs.

e-RFP Ref. JKB/ZOD/Purchase-Refrigerators/2026-1910
DATED: 28-09-2026

Registered office : Corporate Headquarters, M.A. Road, Srinagar 190001, Kashmir, India
CIN: L65101JK193855G000048 ; T : +91 (0)194 2481 930-35 ; F : +91 (0)194 248 1928;
BOP: 488-076025 E : info@jkbank.com ; W : <https://jkbank.in>

**STATE SELECTION BOARD**
DEPARTMENT OF HIGHER EDUCATION
UNIT-II, ASHOK NAGAR BHUBANESWAR - 09
WEBSITE-www.ssbodisha.ac.in
E-MAIL ID - ssbdeptofhe@gmail.com
No. 05/SSB Dated 28.09.2026
Tender Call Notice

Sealed cover tenders are hereby invited from the reputed registered Firms/ Companies/Agencies for **EXAMINATION RELATED WORKS CONDUCTED BY STATE SELECTION BOARD, ODISHA**. The details of the tender papers along with terms and conditions can be obtained from www.ssbodisha.ac.in. The last date of apply for the tender is 27.10.2026 (6:00 P.M.).

The tender documents should be reached in the office of the undersigned through **Speed Post** only. The authority reserves the right to cancel or reject any or all the tenders without assigning any reason thereof.

Sd/-
Secretary
OIPR-11001/11015/1/26-27/0009
State Selection Board

Jaishankar

deal negotiations, said the two sides have reached a situation where there is "more or less an understanding on the trade agreement". Flagging terrorism emanating from Pakistan as one of India's key concerns, he said if this is "not fully appreciated" by the US, then it has "an impact" on Delhi's relationship with Washington.

Referring to the 'G2' summit between Trump and Xin Washington last week, Jaishankar said when the second most consequential or the weightiest economy joins the first, "they

may have their points of convergence" but "overall they are in a competitive mode".

"There are limits to what the two of them can agree upon vis-a-vis the rest of the world. And that then leaves the rest of us, and the rest of us are coming to terms today with a very different America, with the fact that there is also today a certain conversation taking place between America and China," he said.

"Each one of us is looking for our optimal solutions. How do we de-risk? How do we diversify? Which are the new partners? Where do we get more value out of an existing partnership? We are really looking today at a difficult global situation. But as al-

ways, countries respond, they calculate, they adjust, they find new accommodations, they find new solutions, and that is how the international order develops, and it is that development today that I think the UN is a witness to," he said.

On the India-US trade negotiations, he pointed to the "stakes" and "complexity" involved. "A trade negotiation required a certain amount of ... patience and detailing to see it through... expectation it could rapidly move forward, I think, was tested against a ground reality which was much more complex," he said. "Today, we have reached a situation where there is more or less an understanding

on the trade agreement."

On Pakistan, he said, "What for us in India is particularly important is the issue of terrorism. That we feel that... as a country perhaps there are very few countries which have been subjected to the kind of terrorism that we have from a neighbour as part of a deliberate, conscious policy over many, many decades." "If something which matters so deeply to us, there isn't enough understanding or appreciation or empathy of that, I think that creates a problem too. That you know... one of my primary concerns is not fully appreciated by my partner, clearly there is an impact of that on relationship," he said, referring to India-US ties.

AMIT SHAH ALSO INAUGURATES MUKARBA CHOWK UNDERPASS, UNVEILS TWO MORE PROJECTS

Barapullah Phase III flyover opens, set to reduce East-South travel time

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, September 29

UNION HOME and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday inaugurated the long-pending Barapullah Phase III elevated corridor, which is expected to reduce travel time between East and South Delhi. He also inaugurated the Mukarba Chowk Underpass and laid the foundation stones for two more projects — the Modi Mill-Savitri Cinema Flyover and the Loni Underpass — while dedicating road infrastructure projects worth Rs 1,941 crore to Delhi.

Shah inaugurated the projects at a function attended by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, her Cabinet colleagues Ashish Sood, Manjinder Singh Sirsa, Kapil Mishra and Pankaj Kumar Singh, as well as Union MoS for Road Transport Harsh Malhotra, among others.

The 3.5-km Barapullah Phase III corridor was originally approved in 2014. Work began in 2015. It was initially scheduled for completion in 2017 but faced multiple delays, leading to a significant escalation in its cost.

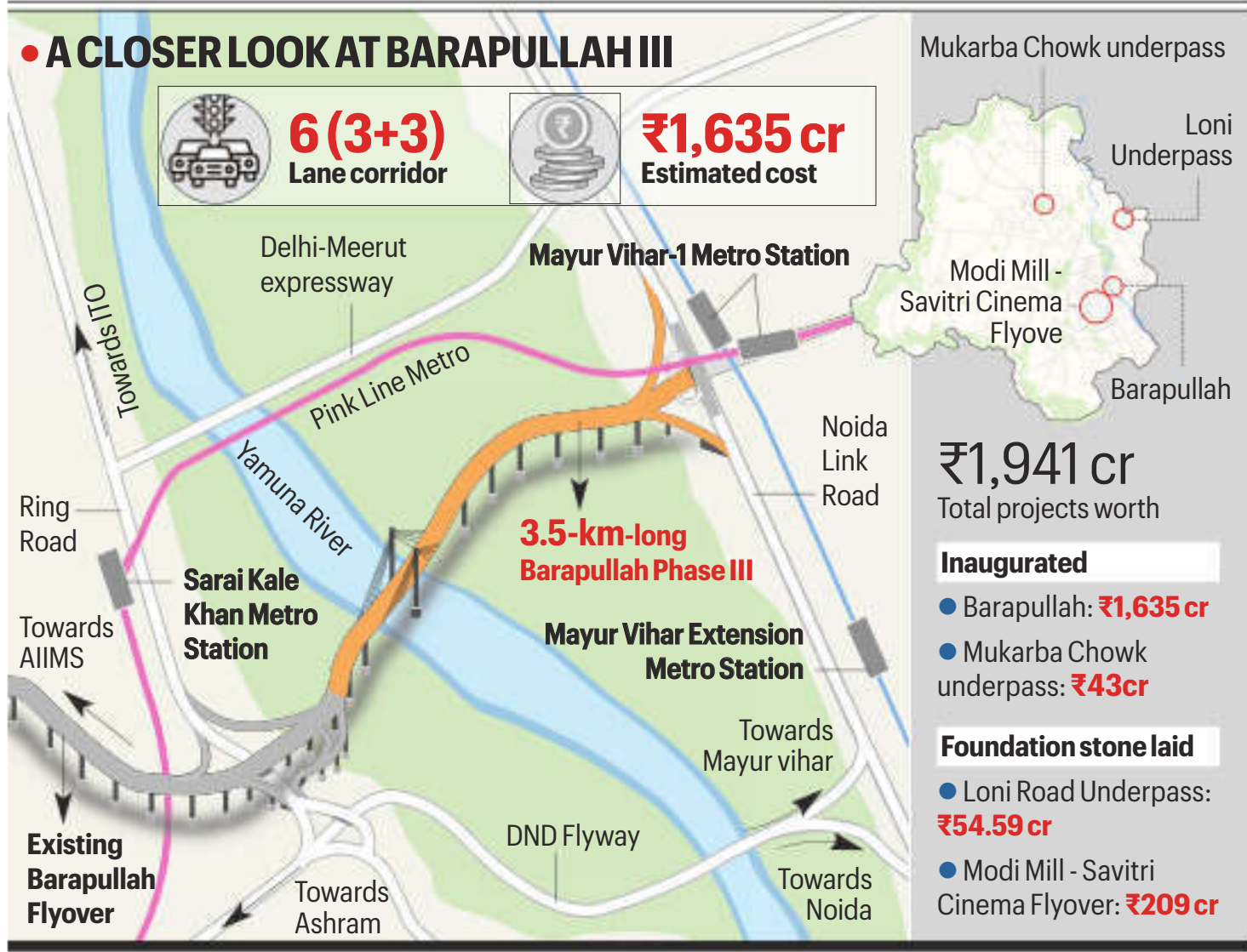
The flyover, which will merge with the existing Barapullah flyover at Sarai Kale Khan, completing a stretch of 10.9 km, has nine loops. It will provide signal-free connectivity between Mayur Vihar Phase I, Sarai Kale Khan and South Delhi, with separate facilities for pedestrians and cyclists.

In a post on X in Hindi, Shah said the Rs 1,635-crore elevated road would provide signal-free connectivity between East and South Delhi, ease traffic congestion and reduce commuting time. Hitting out at the previous AAP government, Gupta said that when she and PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh initially visited site of the project, land had not been acquired, permission not taken for felling trees and no work was done to remove high tension wires. "Work was started in a hurry, but not completed for 11 years," she said.

Gupta attributed the launch of the projects to what she called the "power of a double engine government". She said that the cooperation between



The Barapullah Phase III elevated corridor on Tuesday evening. PRAVEEN KHANNA



the two governments at the levels of policy, planning and implementation was "directly benefiting" Delhi residents.

The other projects include two flyovers in South Delhi, an underpass at Mukarba Chowk on the Outer Ring Road in North Delhi, and an underpass

at the Loni Road roundabout in Northeast Delhi.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said Tuesday was an important day for Delhi's infrastructure. The inauguration of Barapullah Phase III and Mukarba Chowk Underpass, along with the two new projects,

would help improve daily commuting and save travel time, he added.

The Mukarba Chowk project, constructed at an estimated cost of Rs 43 crore, is set to make traffic movement on the Outer Ring Road smoother. It is expected to benefit around

15,800 vehicles daily. The government said that it will provide direct access for traffic travelling from Badli and Rohini towards Azadpur and Jangirpuri without entering the Mukarba Chowk interchange.

The proposed Loni underpass will be four lanes wide. Its construction will reduce the need for vehicles travelling to and from Loni to stop at the roundabout and help make movement towards Shahdara smoother, according to officials. It will cost an estimated Rs 54.59 crore.

The flyover at Modi Mill will strengthen signal free movement from Modi Mill towards Kalkaji and further in the direction of the IIT Gate. Officials said it will help reduce pressure at major traffic junctions in South Delhi, including Captain Gaur Marg-Outer Ring Road, and make movement between Nehru Place, Kalkaji, Greater Kailash and surrounding areas more convenient.

The Savitri Cinema flyover aims to reduce traffic pressure around the Outer Ring Road and GK 2 Road and provide a smoother route for vehicles travelling towards Nehru Place, Okhla and surrounding areas.

Semen on minor's clothes matched with accused's DNA: Chargesheet in bus gangrape

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, September 29

The DNA samples of the two men accused of raping a 17-year-old in a moving bus last month have matched the samples recovered from the bus and the girl's clothes, according to the chargesheet filed by the Delhi Police in the case. This makes scientific evidence obtained during the girl's medical examination and forensic evidence crucial to the case, as per the investigators.

A total of 51 witnesses, including the minor's cousin whose house she was going to, her parents and the staff at repair centre that the accused visited before the alleged assault, apart from investigating officers, have been named in the chargesheet, said officers.

The Delhi Police filed a 398-page chargesheet in the case on September 18. A city court took cognisance of it on September 24, officials familiar with the proceedings said.

Biological samples, including semen and hair strands, were collected during the investigation and sent to the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) for examination. Police had sought an expedited report as they prepared the case for trial.

Officers said forensic evidence was the first and one of the key pieces of evidence relied upon by police in building what they described as a 'watertight case'. The girl was allegedly gang-raped inside a moving sleeper bus on August 4 as it travelled nearly 47 km from Greater Noida to Delhi's Kashmere Gate in August.

On Monday, the Supreme



The sleeper bus. FILE

Court took suo motu cognisance of the case, expressed anguish over the matter, and said, "One cannot help but draw painful parallels to the 2012 Nirbhaya case, calling into question whether systemic law enforcement mechanisms have made any meaningful progress in the decade since then.

Sources also said the minor maintained her statement throughout the investigation, including in her statement recorded under Section 164 of the Code of Criminal Procedure. Her statement corroborated the account she had given to police on the first day of the crime, sources said.

The incident took place on August 4. The teenager allegedly boarded the bus at Pari Chowk in Greater Noida.

Police have said the alleged sexual assault took place as the bus moved towards Delhi. The girl was allegedly abandoned in Kashmere Gate after the sexual assault and she approached the local police station.

Using CCTV footage, they traced the bus to a parking area in Timarpur and arrested the men — bus driver Kuldeep (39) and conductor Sandeep (26), both hailing from Kanpur — within four hours.



AAP MLA Jarnail Singh was detained on Tuesday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Bharadwaj, Jarnail named in FIR for 'misbehaving' with cop

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 29

AAP DELHI unit chief Saurabh Bharadwaj, Tilak Nagar MLA Jarnail Singh, and several other party workers have been named in an FIR following a protest over the alleged assault of a party worker by Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Sunday.

Officers said the FIR was filed against the party workers for allegedly misbehaving with a head constable deployed in West Delhi's Tilak Nagar during the AAP demonstration on Monday. The protest, which was held during AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal's visit to the area, was led by Bharadwaj and Jarnail. They were demanding the registration of an FIR against the Parvesh for allegedly slapping one of their party workers, during a road inspection on Sunday.

As per police, the Head Constable, who was posted at Vikaspuri police station, had been deployed in plain clothes during Kejriwal's visit to Tilak Nagar on Monday. While he was recording a video, a crowd of AAP supporters allegedly surrounded him and later grabbed him as he

was walking away. Police personnel subsequently managed to pull him out of the crowd.

The Head Constable underwent a medical examination. The FIR includes charges related to obstructing a government employee from performing his official duties and assault, police said. A purported video of the entire incident is also circulating on social media, in which Bharadwaj, Jarnail and other party workers can allegedly be seen in the crowd grabbing the head constable.

Reacting to the development, Bharadwaj said the government was "frightened" and was registering "fake and bogus cases". "This cannot go on for very long," in fact, in front of the Station House Officer and Assistant Commissioner of Police, Delhi Police personnel misbehaved with our women workers. They were detained late in the evening and released at midnight. How can women be kept in detention until midnight?"

On Tuesday, he held another protest, outside the Delhi Police Headquarters, demanding an FIR against Parvesh. He, along with Jarnail and other workers were later detained.

HARCOURT BUTLER TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY
NAWABGANJ, KANPUR-208002, U.P., INDIA
(Formerly Harcourt Butler Technological Institute, Kanpur)
Phone: +91-0512-2534001-5, 2533812, website: http://www.hbtu.ac.in, Email: vc@hbtu.ac.in
File No. 1349/Admn/OTTSC/Advt-3/2026 Dated: 29-09-2026

Applications are invited from eligible Candidates for one (01) Temporary Position of 'Clinical Psychologist/or Student Counsellor' (on fixed salary or per visit basis) in the University latest by October 13th, 2026, 5pm.
For more details, visit our website http://www.hbtu.ac.in

Registrar

• Skywatch

Forecast:
September 30, 2026
Mainly clear sky. No rain.

MAX: 32-34
0.7°C below normal

MIN: 20-22
1.3°C below normal

• **Sunrise:** 6:14 AM (September 30)
• **Sunset:** 6:08 PM (October 1)

• **Moonrise:** 8:26 PM (September 30)
• **Moonset:** 11:02 AM (October 1)

• AQI Tracker

Anand Vihar
Satisfactory
AQI: 82

Narela
Satisfactory
AQI: 68

Aya Nagar
Satisfactory
AQI: 68

Sirifort
Satisfactory
AQI: 74

● Good (0-50)
● Satisfactory (51-100)
● Moderate (101-200)
● Poor (201-300)
● Very Poor (301-400)
● Severe (401-500)

HC forms panel under ex-CJI to assess claims of Greenopolis homebuyers

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, September 29

THE DELHI High Court on Tuesday constituted a three-member monitoring committee headed by former Chief Justice of India Sanjiv Khanna to verify genuine homebuyers in the Greenopolis residential project and their claims against the stalled project.

Justice Anup Bhambhani, disposing of a batch of pleas, appointed the monitoring committee which also includes two former Delhi higher judicial services officers HS Sharma and Ajay Kulhar.

The monitoring committee "shall formulate an expeditious and transparent procedure to verify genuine homebuyers and the quantum of payments made by them, cross-referencing the material provided by the Directorate of Enforcement and the homebuyers," Justice Bhambhani outlined.

The Greenopolis project, launched in 2012, in sector 89 of Gurugram, was to be developed as a residential project by M/s Three C Shelters Pvt. Ltd. (3C Shelters) and M/s Orris Infrastructure Pvt. Ltd.

As per the developers' arrangement, 65% of homebuyers were issued allotment letters by 3C Shelters and 35% were issued allotment letters by Orris. However, midway, the developers abandoned the project, with only about 1,650 units allotted to homebuyers, of the 1,862 that were planned. Between 2016-17, the ED started probing the case.

While the ED had filed its chargesheet in July 2025 against 3C Shelters, Orris and their former promoters/directors, the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) court dropped charges against Orris in October and November 2025. ED has also attached properties of the developers.

Last year, on November 27, the PMLA court restored the attached property. The ED challenged that order before the Delhi HC. The court on Tuesday also set aside this order of the PMLA court.

SANJIV SINHA
(20 JULY 1967 - 30 SEPT 2001)

Fondly remembered by
his family and
colleagues at
The Express Group

• THE MISSED DEADLINES OVER NINE YEARS

2014: Barapullah Phase III elevated corridor approved, deadline set at 2017.

2015: Groundwork begins.

2017: Original completion target missed, as the project hits a major roadblock regarding land acquisition at Nangli Razapur village on the Yamuna floodplain.

2018-2022: Construction stalls as farmers refuse to part with 8.5 acres of private land; 80-82% of

the work had been completed.

2023: Following intervention of then Delhi LG VK Saxena, PWD acquires a portion of the land. Work was supposed to be completed by mid-March 2024. But deadline missed due to pending permission to fell trees.

2024: October set as new deadline but project delayed again due to pending clearances from the Forest department and



PRAVEEN KHANNA

the Supreme Court-appointed Central Empowered Committee (CEC) to fell trees falling in the alignment. PWD required 650 m land in parts.

AFTER OCTOBER 2024: Ban on work due to rising pollution. Model code of conduct due to Delhi polls also delayed project.

2025: CEC grants permission to cut, transplant, and prune 333 trees.

For Noida, Ghaziabad commuters, a new route to South Delhi – and an escape from Sarai Kale Khan

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, September 29

FOR THOUSANDS of commuters travelling between Noida, Ghaziabad and South Delhi every day, the journey could soon involve one less bottleneck – Sarai Kale Khan.

With the opening of the Barapullah Phase III elevated corridor, vehicles travelling between the eastern side of the Yamuna and South Delhi will have an alternative to the congested Ring Road, particularly the Sarai Kale Khan stretch. Instead of taking the DND and then joining the Ring Road, some commuters can use the new corridor to cross the Yamuna.

Around 11 lakh vehicles from the National Capital Region enter Delhi every day, of which nearly five lakh come from Noida and Ghaziabad. Of these, an estimated 3-4 lakh currently use the eastern corridor, including DND, National Highway 9/National Highway 24 and Akshardham-Ring Road stretch to enter South Delhi. The Barapullah corridor is expected to redistribute some of this traffic.

"The key difference is not



Union Home Minister Amit Shah with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh at the inauguration of the elevated corridor on Tuesday. ANI

merely the addition of another road, but the creation of an alternative route for vehicles that currently converge on the Ring Road. It will be beneficial for the public," said Additional Commissioner of Police D K Gupta.

"Vehicles travelling from INA towards Mayur Vihar, Noida and Ghaziabad would be able to use the Barapullah cor-

ridor to cross the Yamuna instead of coming towards Sarai Kale Khan and the DND Road," a traffic official said.

The same will work in the opposite direction. Vehicles from Noida, Ghaziabad, Mayur Vihar and Akshardham heading towards INA and South Delhi can use the corridor through the Noida Link Road instead of first joining the

Ring Road.

This could take some pressure off the Ring Road, which carries heavy traffic through much of the day. Unlike roads where congestion is mostly limited to morning and evening rush hours, the Ring Road remains busy because several major routes feed into it. The six-lane DND is one of the main approaches to the Ring Road, which is four lanes around Sarai Kale Khan.

Traffic from the Akshardham side also joins the Ring Road network.

The problem, officials said, is not simply the number of lanes available on the DND or Ring Road.

It is also where the traffic converges.

At present, a vehicle travelling from Noida towards South or Central Delhi may take the DND before joining the Ring Road. Vehicles from the Akshardham side also enter the same network.

Similarly, in the opposite direction, those travelling from South Delhi towards Noida and Ghaziabad use the Ring Road before reaching the DND or

other eastern routes.

With Barapullah Phase III, some of these vehicles can avoid the Ring Road altogether.

Instead of all the traffic heading towards Sarai Kale Khan, some will have another route to cross the Yamuna.

"The aim is not to eliminate congestion on the corridor, given the enormous volumes of traffic it handles, but to reduce the additional pressure created by vehicles that do not necessarily need to use it. The impact could be particularly visible around Sarai Kale Khan, where traffic from the DND, Ring Road and other approaches comes together," Gupta said.

Officials said the Barapullah Phase III flyover gives traffic another route instead of trying to add more capacity to an already busy Ring Road.

For commuters from Noida and Ghaziabad heading towards South Delhi, the new route could mean avoiding the DND-Ring Road-Sarai Kale Khan stretch.

For the Ring Road, the expected benefit is simpler: fewer vehicles feeding into an already heavily loaded corridor.

Yuvraj murder: Court seeks probe into role of Gurugram cops, medical officer

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, September 29

A DELHI court on Tuesday ordered an investigation into the possible role of Gurugram Police officers and the Medical Officer of the Gurugram Civil Hospital in the disposal of the body of 31-year-old Delhi-based real estate professional Yuvraj Singh Manchanda, saying their involvement in the “disappearance of evidence” could not be ruled out.

Yuvraj was allegedly killed by his former colleague Anya Vats and her partner Sanyam Sachdeva on September 6, with his body later found in a drain in Gurugram.

Citing “grave” procedural lapses by Badshahpur police station personnel, Judicial Magistrate First Class Rahul Jain of Saket Court directed that a copy of the order be sent to Gurugram deputy commissioner of police and a report be submitted in two weeks.

The court noted that the unidentified body was recovered September 10 but its particulars



Yuvraj Manchanda was killed on September 6.

and photographs were uploaded on the ZIPNET database -- an integrated online platform used by law enforcement agencies to circulate information about missing persons and unidentified bodies -- only on September 16, two days after it had been cremated.

It observed that this was a “clear negligence” and failure to follow the standard operating procedure for unidentified bodies. “...the body was re-covered on 10.09.2026 at 4.05 pm. However, the details and photographs were uploaded onto the ZIPNET database only on 16.09.2026, which was two

days after the body had already been cremated. On the face of it, this shows clear negligence and a failure to follow the standard operating procedures established for such cases,” the court said.

Maintaining that there was a “delay of six crucial days in uploading this data”, the Judge said, “The complainant not only lost her brother allegedly to a brutal murder but could not even see or cremate his body due to the lapses of the Gurugram Police.”

Further, the court called the postmortem report prepared by Manav Chauhan, the Medical Officer of the Civil Hospital, “grossly deficient” and “incomplete”.

The police investigation by IO Chetna Mandia (Delhi Police) shows that the accused disclosed shooting the victim twice near his neck. There have been further recoveries of weapon of offence, mobile phone of deceased and other electronic evidence pointing towards the theory that the deceased died due to firing of two rounds at/around

the neck,” the court said, noting that the body was later disposed of in order to conceal evidence.

“However, the postmortem report is inconsistent with the investigative theory. It states ‘NIL’ under external injuries and lists internal structures including the neck, scalp, skull, meninges, chest wall, and ribs as showing ‘No Abnormality Detected’.

The doctor then concluded that cause of death is ante mortem drowning,” he added.

Moreover, the court noted that no X-ray was conducted or mentioned in the postmortem report to check for concealed metallic objects such as bullets. It said that, in ordinary circumstances, bullet paths or projectile injuries penetrating skin, tissue or bone do not vanish due to decomposition, but this could have been confirmed only if the postmortem had been conducted according to protocol.

It further took note of the failure to preserve forensic material, including viscera and samples required for diatom testing.

No PUC, no fuel; live monitoring: Gurugram’s plan to curb air pollution before winter onset

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurugram, September 29

IN A major push to check deteriorating air quality ahead of the winter onset, the administration in Gurugram on Tuesday announced a sweeping set of enforcement measures, including prohibiting the sale of fuel to end-of-life vehicles and those lacking valid emission certificates; live monitoring at over 1,000 sites; and constant sweeping across the roads in the Millennium City.

The decisions were taken during the 13th District Coordi-

Greater Noida too steps up action

Noida: The Greater Noida Industrial Development Authority has issued strict guidelines for construction activities and waste management. Officers said that water sprinkling and mechanical sweeping will be carried out on roads. Departments concerned have been told to ensure compliance.

AK Singh, GM (Project), said that in accordance with CAQM directions, regular drives will be conducted. “Builders have been directed to install an adequate number of anti-smog guns at construction sites, and a survey of ongoing projects will be conducted to ensure compliance,” another officer said. **ENS**

timelines for civic, transport, and environmental agencies ahead of the enforcement of the Commission for Air Quality Management’s Graded Response Action Plan to curb air pollution in the winter months across Delhi-NCR.

To curb dust and industrial emissions, the Haryana State Pollution Control Board has placed 1,054 identified pollution-emitting sites measuring over 500 square metres, under direct electronic oversight. Regional officers confirmed that web cameras have been installed at 907 locations.

Assam woman riding Uber bike hit by DTC bus, dies

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 29

A 22-YEAR-OLD woman passenger riding an Uber bike died after a DTC bus allegedly hit the two-wheeler at the Ashram flyover in Southeast Delhi on Monday morning, police said. Identified as Hrishita Lahon, the woman, hailing from Assam, was travelling from Lajpat Nagar towards Noida on a Bajaj Platina.

While the DTC bus and its driver are yet to be traced, the bike driver has been identified as Darab Singh, who was also injured in the accident.

After the accident took place around 10 am, no PCR call was received from the spot, said officers. The first information about the incident was received through a media-legal case report from Jeewan Hospital in the city, which was initially sent to the nearby New Friends Colony police station and later transferred to the Sunlight Colony police station.

Police received the MLC report around 12.58 pm and an investigating officer went to Jeevan Hospital, where he obtained Lahon’s MLC report and other details. “Lahon was shifted to Apollo Hospital, Sarita Vihar, for further treatment. However, before the investigating officer could reach the hospital, she was declared dead around 2 pm,” a police officer said.

Meanwhile, police received the MLC report of Darab Singh.

According to information subsequently obtained from him, he was riding the bike with Lahon when a bus allegedly hit the motorcycle from behind.

A case has been filed at Sunlight Colony police station under sections 281 (rash driving), 106(1) (causing death through negligent act) and 125(A), among other sections.

A photography enthusiast, always surrounded by friends

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 29

Hrishita Lahon came to Delhi with big dreams, new friendships and the hope of building a life here. She had grown up in Guwahati, studied in Shillong and eventually arrived in the Capital, where she found Maitreyi College, a close circle of friends and the beginnings of the life she had imagined.

“She wanted to build a life here,” said Shubhankur, a close friend. “Delhi was not easy for her in the beginning. She struggled to adjust to the city and its environment but because of her friends she kept trying.”

On Monday, the 22-year-old English Literature graduate died after a road accident at the Ashram flyover. Police said Hrishita was travelling towards Noida on an Uber bike taxi around 10 am when a DTC bus allegedly hit the motorcycle from behind.

Shubhankur described her as a “friend’s friend”.

If she considered someone a friend, he said, she would go to any extent for them. It was perhaps this quality that made her friendships feel more like family.

On August 28, exactly a month before her death, Hrishita and her closest friend Rishita Mech went to their friend Ayushi Nayak’s home on Rakkhi because Ayushi was living alone. “They said that this way, I would not feel alone,” Ayushi recalled.

Ayushi said that when she was struggling to adjust after moving out of their old PG, Hrishita would tell her, “If you can-



Hrishita Lahon died on Monday.

not adjust, come to my place.”

The three had lived together for nearly two-and-a-half years after meeting in Delhi. When their PG shut in 2024, Ayushi moved to Karol Bagh while Hrishita and Rishita Mech moved together to Greater Kailash and later Panchsheel Park. The homes changed, but the friendships remained. Ayushi continued to visit three or four times a month.

As Hrishita and Rishita pronounced in a similar manner, Ayushi gave them nicknames. Hrishita became ‘Tiklu’ and Rishita Mech ‘Bum Bum’, whom Hrishita fondly used to call “Rishita Baa”.

Rishita knew the little things that made Hrishita happy, said Ayushi. When Hrishita had assignments, she packed parathas, pasta, chai or Maggi. Since Hrishita disliked vegetables, she made chicken nuggets or an omelette instead.

There was something child-like about Hrishita too, said Ayushi. She loved soft toys, col-

ouring books, Taylor Swift and web series. She rarely ate breakfast and liked her lunch a particular way – a large spoonful of rice completely covered in dal. She loved blue Lay’s and chocolate.

Hrishita was still learning ordinary things of living away from home. The gas stove frightened her, said Ayushi. Many a times, she asked a friend to teach her how to boil water and make noodles.

According to Ayushi, Hrishita loved photography, especially mountains. At Maitreyi College, she was general secretary of the Photography Society. She taught Ayushi Assamese and introduced her to Assamese singers and creators, including Zubeen Garg.

She had even made plans to meet Ayushi for dinner on October 2.

Shubhankur had known Hrishita since her Shillong days. After they stopped speaking for a period, they spoke again eight to 10 days before her death.

“She told me she was ready to talk to me properly again,” he said. The conversation ended with a demand: he had to do 30 push-ups before she would talk to him properly.

Shubhankur said he still has the message he drafted for her that day but never sent.

Hrishita’s cousin Himanshu Buragohain remembers her as “very simple”. “She was a lovely girl”. At Maitreyi College, Principal Haritima Chopra said that a prayer meet will be held for Hrishita on Wednesday.

“Hrishita was one of a kind,” Shubhankur said.

“You were loved, and you will always be remembered.”

● OPENED IN 1972

Eviction sword hangs over Akshara, Indian theatre’s iconic ‘home for the mind’

Dipanita Nath
Pune, September 29

IN 1976, DURING the Emergency, a small theatre in Delhi staged a satirical play, Let’s Laugh Again, targeting Prime Minister Indira Gandhi and several other important leaders. People were scared at first, but after a while, they found the courage to laugh. The play became so successful that there were shows at 9.30 am, 3.30 pm, 6.30 pm and sometimes, 9.30 pm.

This was Akshara Theatre on Baba Kharak Singh Marg, a cultural landmark of great historical significance, and older than Mumbai’s Prithvi Theatre. Akshara was founded and run by a theatre couple, playwright-director Gopal Sharman and actor-director Jalabala Vaidya, as a “home for the mind”. The patrons of Akshara included, at various times, the Nehru-Gandhi family, including Indira and Rajiv, and former Prime Ministers Atal Bihari Vajpayee, I K Gujral, Morarji Desai, and P V Narasimha Rao.

Last Friday, the Delhi High Court stayed proceedings initiated by the Land and Development Office of the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs to evict the 54-year-old theatre from its premises adjacent to Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital. After Sharman’s death in 2016 and Jalabala’s in 2023, the couple’s daughter, filmmaker-theatreperson Anasuya Vaidya is leading the fight to save Akshara. In 1969-70, Sharman and Jalabala performed their production, Full Circle, in Europe and the UK, which was among the earliest Indian theatre tours of the West. The Indian government agreed to give them accommodation in Delhi, and the couple were offered several sites to choose from.

“One of these places was where Akshara now stands. It had a big gulmohar tree in the lawn, and a champak tree, a jacaranda tree, a mango tree and a guava tree,” Anasuya said.

Sharman famously crafted Akshara with his own hands, using carved Dholpur stone, and designing it like a musical instrument. Under his supervi-



Ramayana was the first play to be performed here. AKSHARA THEATRE

sion, a family of masons and carpenters built a stage of teak and rosewood, which projected sound into the seating area that was panelled with soft woods like pine, cedar, and deodar to absorb the sound. Working with a team of metal workers, Sharman also designed all the chairs in the amphitheatre.

On March 11, 1972, Akshara opened as a 50-seater theatre. It was expanded in 1994, after the government gave it more space – it is this theatre that exists at present on the 0.72 acre plot.

The first play to be performed at Akshara was the Ramayana. In the 1980s, Akshara took its theatre to Hyderabad, Visakhapatnam, Chandigarh, and Jammu among other cities.

“We wanted Akshara to be for artists who did not have to conform to existing trends, people who were innovative and who did not find a forum elsewhere. Akshara became a space for struggling artists who couldn’t afford to put on a play anywhere else. We wanted Akshara to be a home for independent theatre,” Anasuya said.

Over the years, a lot of young artists began their careers at Akshara. Stand-up comedy in Delhi took its first steps here. Colleges held their theatre festivals at Akshara. “We gave props and costumes to people,” Anasuya said.

In 2013, after the National School of Drama cancelled two Pakistani plays, one of the plays, Ajoka Theatre group’s Kaun Hai Yeh Gustakh based on the life and legacy of Saadat Hasan Manto, was staged at Ak-

shara. Later, Akshara hosted a theatrical reading and performance of the erotic novel Fifty Shades of Grey. At the same time, the theatre worked with children, including underprivileged children.

“Akshara is one of the most intimate spaces for theatrepersons to perform in Delhi, with wonderful warm acoustics. Over the past decade or so, it has been one of the few theatre spaces available in the capital for young performers to try their talents in stand-up comedy. Unlike bigger theatres in the city, Akshara is open and affordable, and the management is very welcoming of young talent,” eminent theatre personality Sunit Tandon said.

Akshara, Tandon added, is possibly the only brick-and-mortar theatre in India that has staged the Ramayana on Dussehra and Ram Navami continuously for more than 50 years.

Now isn’t the first time that Akshara has had a sword hanging over it. During the Emergency in 1975-76, a notice arrived from the government saying the theatre was in line to be demolished.

An intervention by Indira’s minister Y B Chavan saved Akshara – but some months into the Janata government, a new eviction notice arrived. Action was deferred on this occasion as well. After Indira returned to power, the government sent yet another letter. But this time, the Prime Minister herself saved Akshara. Jalabala received an invitation to tea from Indira, and the order was set aside, Anasuya said.

punjab national bank
ASSET RECOVERY MANAGEMENT BRANCH (ARMB)

SCO - 27, 1st Floor, B-Block,
Ranjit Avenue, District Shopping
Complex, Amritsar 143001

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

STATUTORY 15 / 30 DAYS SALE NOTICE TO GENERAL PUBLIC UNDER RULE 6(2) AND 8(6) READ WITH RULE 6 AND 9 OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES 2002 OF SARFAESI ACT 2002

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the Public in general and in particular to the Borrowers and Guarantors that the below described movable / immovable properties mortgaged / charged to the secured Creditor, the Constructive / Physical / Symbolic Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Bank / Secured Creditor, will be sold on “As is where is”, “As is what is” and “Whatever there is basis” on the date as mentioned in the table herein below, for recovery of its dues due to the Bank / Secured Creditor from the respective borrowers & guarantors. The Reserve Price and Earnest Money Deposit will be as mentioned in the table below against the respective properties.

ENCUMBRANCES KNOWN TO THE SECURED CREDITORS IN NIL / NOT KNOWN

The Sale will be done through E-Auction Platform provided at Website: <https://baanknet.com> on 27-10-2026 for Sr. No. 1 & 2 and 12-11-2026 for Sr. No. 3, 11:00 AM to 04:00 PM

Intending Buyers have to Create User ID and must have minimum EMD Amount in E-Wallet on <https://baanknet.com> to Participate in Auction

Baanknet Portal Help Desk No. +91 8291220220, support.baanknet@psballiance.com, for guidance on Auction process, Registration status etc.

Contact Detail of Authorised Officer: Mr. Ravinder Kumar Gera (Chief Manager) (M) 73400-67253, Email: cs8186@pnb.bank.in

SCHEDULE OF THE SECURED ASSETS				
Name of the Branch	Description of Immovable properties	A) Date of Demand Notice U/s 13(2) of SARFAESI ACT 2002	Reserve Price	Details of the Litigation / encumbrances known to the secured creditors
Name of the Account	Mortgaged / Owner's Name (mortgagers of property)(ies)	B) Outstanding Amount as on	EMD	
Name and Addresses of the Borrower / Guarantors / NPA Account	(mortgagers of property)(ies)	C) Possession Date u/s 13(4) of SARFAESI ACT 2002	Bid Increase Amount	
		D) Nature of Possession Symbolic / Physical / Constructive		
1 ARMB, AMRITSAR PROPERTY ID: PUNBKRA54802173	Immovable Property of Resort having area 20 Kanal 4 Marla bearing Khassa no. 49/132 (8-18), 24/18 (8-0), 49/15/1 (2-0), 15/2 (3-6), Khata no. 88, 245, 98, Khatouni no. 293, 633/6, 307, situated in Wakkia Rakba, Village Mari Gour Singh, Tehsil Patli, Distt. Tarn Taran, Punjab, in the name of Sh. Avjit Singh S/o Sh. Narinder Singh, Smt Sukhpreet Kaur W/o Late Sh. Baljit Singh, Sh. Gurdial Singh (deceased) and Sh. Gurmeet Singh S/o Sh. Pal Singh, Sh. Sukhraj Singh and Sh. Balraj Singh S/o Sh. Sukhdev Singh vide Document No. 24, Book no. 1, Volume no. 382, Page no. 28/29, Registered with the Office of Sub Registrar Bhikhiwind vide dated 05-04-2010. Note : This property is mortgaged with M/s Pahul Enterprises, M/s Balraj Traders M/s Jinderjit Agri Services	03-11-2023 Rs. 2,51,61,054.22 as on 31-10-2023 + Interest, other charges and less recovery if any, till date affected 05-04-2024 SYMBOLIC POSSESSION	Rs. 4,16,04,000/- Rs. 41,60,400/- Rs. 1,00,000/-	Civil Suit, CS477/2026, is pending before the Hon'ble Court of Sh. Karanjit Singh, Civil Judge (Jr. Div) Patli. No Stay on Auction as of now
2 ARMB, AMRITSAR PROPERTY ID : PUNB818600104	Equitable Mortgage of Land and Building bearing Kila no. 23/2/1 (3-11), 2/3 (2-15) 3 (6-8), 7/8-0, 23/18/2 (1-0), 1/9 (8-0), 1/20 (8-0), 1/24 (8-0), 24/16 (8-0), 16/122 (4-0) min Tar East 2/3 (7-4), 1/9 (4-0), min East 18/7-4), 16/12 (5-0) min Tar East 1/3 (7-4), Khata Kahtoni no. 1214/47/11, 225/507, 155/390, Jamabandi for the year 1998 - 1999, Hadbast no. 406, (Area 88 Kanal 6 Marla), Kila no. 23/1 = 7-2 = 7-4, 9/1 = 6-0, 9/2 = 2-0, 10/1 = 5-4, 10/2 = 2-16, 11 = 8-0, 12 = 8-0, 13 = 7-4, 14 = 8-0, 17 = 8-0, 18/16-4, 29/9 = 8-0, 24/17 = 7-0, 24/1 = 1-0, 25/2/4 = 2-12, 25/2 = 3-18, 25/1 = 4-0, 23/6/1 = 2-12, 23/4/1/1 = 1-10, 5/2 = 1-15, 5/1 = 2-13, 6/2 = 4-13, Khata Khatoni no. 215/479, 19/413, 68/203, Jamabandi for the year 1998-1999, Hadbast no. 406 (Area 115 Kanal 7 Marla), Kila no. 47/17/1 (2-5), Khata Khatoni no. 190/437, Jamabandi for the Year 1998-1999, area 2 Kanal 5 Marla, Total Land 88 Kanal 6 Marla + 115 Kanal 7 Marla + 2 Kanal 5 Marla = 205 Kanal 18 Marla = 25.73 Acre, situated at Rakba Village Hoshiar Nagar, Near Gurudwara Gurusar Sattani, Attari Road, Tehsil Amritsar-II, standing in the name of Baba Kuma Singh Ji International Charitable Society.)	16-04-2021 Rs. 1,33,34,811/82 as on 31-03-2021 + Interest, other charges and less recovery if any, till date affected 20-11-2021 SYMBOLIC POSSESSION	Rs. 8,48,97,000/- Rs. 84,89,700/- Rs. 1,00,000/-	Mortgagor has sold partial property 2 Kanal 5 Marla without the consent of Bank (Registered vide Title Deed No. 8268 dated 14-09-2001)
3 ARMB, AMRITSAR (I) PROPERTY ID: PUNB89A10673340 (II) PROPERTY ID : PUNB818500062	(i) All part and parcel of Land measuring 1930 sq. Yards, (actual area may slightly differ) Property bearing Plot no. 24, Khassa no. 689 min, situated at Urban Circle no. 110, Ideal Lane, Court Road, Tehsil and Distt Amritsar vide Vaska no. 6655, Bahi No. 1, Jild no. 14408, Page No. 5758 dated 20-11-2015. (ii) Property measuring 2689 sq. yards bearing Khassa No. 24/11/2 min, 10 min, Khawat Khatauni No. 595/1410, Jamabandi year 2007-08 & Khassa no. 23/5 min, 24/12 min, 10 min 23/5 min, Khawat Khatauni no. 567/1343, Jamabandi year 2002-03, Area Rakshikargah Abadi, Silver Estate, Tehsil & District Amritsar vide Title deed Nos. 7247 dated 23-08-2010 and 1643 dated 14-05-2009, in the name of Sh. Sachin Kumar & 175 dated 05-04-2006, in name of M/s Sun Industries, Hadbast no. 282 as per Jamabandi year 2017-2018 AND Property measuring 1629.96 sq yards bearing Khassa No. 94/14/1, 17/1, 27/20, 94/7, 15 Min, Khawat Khatauni No. 460/976, 470/1005, 1006, Jamabandi year 1998-1999, Khassa No. 93/19/1, (0-9) Min, 93/19/2 (0-5) Min, Khawat Khatauni no. 444/930, 446/936, Jamabandi year 1998-1999, Khassa No. 93/20/1 Min, Khata Khatauni no. 539/1113 and Khassa no. 96/11 min, situated at area Pandori Wariach, Silver Estate Tehsil and Distt Amritsar vide Title Deed Nos. 2152 dated 19-05-2004, 12352 dated 28-01-2005, 870 dated 27-04-2005 and 732 dated 18-04-2006, Hadbast no. 283 as per Jamabandi for the year 2015-2016. in the name of M/s Kiran Industries	16-04-2021 Rs. 5,57,03,651.37 as on 31-03-2021 + Interest, other charges and less recovery if any, till date affected 16-10-2021 SYMBOLIC POSSESSION	(i) Rs. 10,70,00,000/- Rs. 1,07,00,000/- Rs. 1,00,000/- (ii) Rs. 5,13,75,000/- Rs. 51,37,500/- Rs. 1,00,000/-	Sh. Rajesh Kumar (Guarantor) has filed PIRP CP(1B) No. 160/2024 before Hon'ble NCLT Chandigarh Bench. No Stay on Auction as of now / No Moratorium as per Gazette notification 6/2026 dated 06-04-2026 Insolvency & Bankruptcy Code (Amendment) Act 2026

STATUTORY 15 / 30 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) OF THE SARFAESI ACT 2002

Terms and Conditions: (1) The sale shall be subject to the Terms & Conditions prescribed in the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002 and to the following further conditions. **(2)** The properties are being sold on, **AS IS WHERE IS BASIS** and **"AS IS WHAT IS BASIS"** and **"WHATEVER THERE IS BASIS"**. **(3)** The particulars of the Secured Assets specified in the Schedule herein above have been stated to the best of the information of the Authorised Officer, but the Authorised Officer shall not be answerable for any error, misstatement or omission in this proclamation. **(4)** Any encumbrances over the property/ies is not known to the Bank / Secured Creditor. The Authorised officer or Bank shall not be responsible for any charge, lien, encumbrances or any other dues to the Government or anyone else in respect of properties Auctioned. **(5)** The Intending Bidder is advised to make their independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances on the property including Statutory liabilities arrears, of property Tax, Electricity Dues, NOC form any department etc. Outstanding Charges / bill for electricity, house tax etc. shall be borne by auction purchaser. **(6)** The Secured Creditor does not any way warrant the, fitness or Quality or liability of the properties being sold. **(7)** The Sale will be done by the undersigned through the E-auction platform provided at the **Website : <https://baanknet.com> on 27-10-2026 @ 11:00 AM to 04:00 PM for Sr. No. 1 & 2 and 12-11-2026 @ 11:00 AM to 04:00 PM for Sr. No. 3** as per time given above. For detailed terms & conditions of the Sale, please refer **<https://baanknet.com>** **(8)** Over and above reserve price, Minimum One Bid Amount is Mandatory.

DATE : 29-09-2026
PLACE : AMRITSAR
SD/- AUTHORISED OFFICER (PUNJAB NATIONAL BANK)



Uttarakhand holds a special place on the tourism map, owing to its exceptionally rich culture and heritage. Tourism plays a vital role in strengthening the state's economy. Our tourist destinations are symbols of our historical and cultural civilizations, as well as our identity. Uttarakhand is a center of faith and spiritual experiences. To link tourism with employment, plans for developing new tourist destinations are being implemented here. Uttarakhand has always conveyed the message of 'Atithi Devo Bhava' to the nation and the world. The state is ready to welcome its guests.

Pushkar Singh Dhami
Chief Minister, Uttarakhand

Vikas bhi,
Virasat bhi



Seamless Journeys Through Devbhoomi

Uttarakhand is leveraging technology and infrastructure to provide visitors with a safe, comfortable and enriching travel experience.

The state is shaping a modern and culturally sensitive tourism model. Guided by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and inspired by the leadership of Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami, Uttarakhand is combining technology, infrastructure development and heritage conservation to create safer and more enriching experiences for travellers.

For the Char Dham Yatra, an Aadhaar-based cloud registration system has been introduced to enhance pilgrim safety, enable hassle-free entry at checkpoints and ensure transparent data management. This innovation is modernising the pilgrimage experience while prioritising safety and accountability.

At Kainchi Dham, associated with the memory of Neem Karoli Baba, the government has invested ₹17 crore. The initiative aims to improve road connectivity, parking facilities, pilgrim amenities and environmentally sensitive infrastructure, while preserving the sanctity of this revered destination.

A ₹100-crore project is being implemented in the Jaunsar-Bawar region to restore Mahasu Devta temples, preserve traditional wooden architecture and promote cultural tourism. With active participation from local communities, the initiative is also empowering rural communities through homestays, festivals and handicrafts, ensuring that the benefits of tourism reach the grassroots.

Together, these initiatives present a shared vision of a "Seamless, Safe and Spiritual" journey across Uttarakhand. By balancing modern needs with cultural preservation, the state is positioning itself as a global example of sustainable and transformative tourism.

Excellent Connectivity: Easier Access to Remote Areas

With new roads, ropeways and air services, Uttarakhand is making journeys through the mountains faster, safer and more comfortable than ever for pilgrims and tourists.

Rapid infrastructure development across Uttarakhand is creating new travel experiences for tourists and residents alike, generating greater interest in exploring the Himalayas. Through initiatives such as the Parvatomala Scheme and the All-Weather Road Project, the state is ensuring that faith and ease of travel progress together.

The Delhi-Dehradun Expressway enables travellers to reach the gateway to Uttarakhand from the national capital in just about two and a half hours. This important corridor connects with the All-Weather Char Dham Road, making access to Badrinath, Kedarnath, Gangotri and Yamunotri easier, even during challenging weather conditions.

Ropeway projects are transforming travel in the mountains. The 11.5-km Sonprayag-Kedarnath Ropeway is set to become one of the world's highest ropeways and will be capable of transporting thousands of pilgrims to the temple every hour. Similarly, the Govindghat-Hemkund Sahib Ropeway will reduce a difficult 12-hour trek to just 45 minutes, while the Dehradun-Mussoorie Ropeway will transform a 33-km mountain journey into a scenic 15-minute ride.

Air connectivity is also expanding rapidly. Under the Mukhyamantri Udan Khatola Yojana, helicopter services are



A Grand Confluence of Faith, Culture & Spiritual Consciousness



experience devotion, spiritual discipline, selfless service, and cultural heritage. From holy dips in the sacred Ganga and darshan of venerable saints to

the grand processions (Peshwai) of the Akharas and an array of spiritual ceremonies, every moment of the Kumbh carries a transcendent grace.

Concerted efforts are underway to ensure the event is seamless, safe, and well-organized, with dedicated emphasis on enhanced connectivity, efficient traffic management, immaculate cleanliness, robust security, and world-class pilgrim amenities.

This grand gathering is not solely an expression of faith; it is a living embodiment of "Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat", uniting people from diverse corners of the nation in a shared spirit of spiritual oneness. In view of this, the state government has initiated comprehensive preparations to ensure a flawless, hassle-free experience for every visiting pilgrim, sadhu, and seer.

Uttarakhand Tourism Policy 2023

A Robust Roadmap Driving Sustainable Development & Investment

The geographical, cultural, and natural diversity of Uttarakhand has positioned it among the most preferred tourism destinations in North India. The state has witnessed a steady rise in tourist footfall. In 2014, approximately 22 million (2.2 crore) tourists visited Uttarakhand, a figure that surged to around 39 million (3.9 crore) by 2019. During this period, the state recorded a Compound Annual Growth Rate (CAGR) of 11.97% in tourist arrivals.

According to a World Travel & Tourism Council report, India ranks as the world's seventh-largest tourism economy in terms of size. The report projected an estimated growth of approximately 7% in the tourism sector between 2017 and 2027. The state's new tourism policy aims to formulate a long-term roadmap for the sustainable and balanced growth of Uttarakhand's tourism sector. The role of the state government and its departments will primarily focus on policymaking, regulation, and tourism promotion. Concurrently, the private sector will play a central role in delivering services such as accommodation, tourist amenities, transportation, tour operations, activities, and events. The state government will act as a facilitator to create an enabling environment for these ventures.

Promoting Private Sector Investment
The policy highlights that private capital and industry expertise are vital for driving Uttarakhand's future tourism growth. To advance this objective, the government will promote Public-Private Partnerships (PPP). For efficient implementation, the state government will:
Reduce its direct involvement in sectors where private enterprise is encouraged, such as the development and management of tourist accommodations.
Focus on enhancing Ease of Doing Business

for tourism investors.
Strengthen the Single Window Clearance System to ensure swift statutory approvals and project clearances.

Unlocking New Pathways for Tourism Development

The policy supports and incentivizes both greenfield and existing tourism ventures; Capital Subsidy Eligibility: Newly established projects/enterprises in progress up to the subsidy application date qualify for capital subsidies. Existing units undertaking significant expansion or diversification are also eligible. Turnover-Based Incentives: Operational tourism units and enterprises active by the application submission date are eligible for turnover-linked incentives.

The policy aims to stimulate private investment while generating employment, boosting local entrepreneurship, and strengthening the state's economy.

Priority Focus Segments During the Policy Period : To bolster the tourism landscape, the state government will focus on specific priority niches:

- Promotion of eco-destinations alongside trekking, white-water rafting, and allied adventure pursuits.
- Encouragement of facilities dedicated to Yoga, Ayurveda, Naturopathy, and holistic

healthcare. Preserving and highlighting sacred religious circuits, local folk culture, and traditions. Integrating historical landmarks, monuments, and traditional vernacular architecture into the tourism circuit. MICE Tourism: Development of infrastructure for Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions.

Key Fiscal Incentives and Reliefs Under the Policy

Eligible tourism units will receive structured financial subsidies and concessions, including:
Capital subsidy for the hospitality sector: For hotel and accommodation-related projects. Incentives for marketing and promotion of investment in eligible tourism projects. Assistance for training and skill development. Interest subsidy/relief. Incentives for waste management and disposal. Incentives for increasing bookings through the State's online travel agency platform. Capital subsidy for investment in tourism products and services. Subsidies for projects and units that are not eligible for capital subsidy. Special incentives for premium and high-end hospitality projects. Incentives to attract foreign tourists. Incentives for organizing MICE events, art, social and cultural events, fairs, & festivals. Incentives to promote helicopter-based transportation. Exemption from electricity duty. Exemption from stamp duty.

Spiritual & Natural Gems Along the Journey

Near Yamunotri	Near Gangotri	Near Kedarnath	Near Badrinath
Janki Chatti, Hanuman Chatti, Kharsali Village, Saptarishi Kund, Pandava Cave, Lakhamandal, Gangnani Kedarkantha Trek, Rana Chatti	Gaumukh Trek, Bhojbasa, Tapovan, Surya Kund & Gauri Kund, Harsil Valley, Mukhimath (Mukhba), Gangnani Dayara Bugyal Trek, Gartang Gali, Kashi Vishwanath Temple, Nachiketa Tal, Doodital	Bhairavnath Temple, Vasuki Tal, Gaurikund, Triyuginarayan Temple, Chohta-Tungnath-Chandrasilla, Guptkashi, Deoria Tal	Mana Village, Vyas Cave & Ganesh Cave, Bhim Shila, Auli, Valley of Flowers, Vasudhara Falls, Charan Paduka, Tapt Kund, Narad Kund, Jyotirmath (Joshimath), Satopanth Lake, Pandukeshwar, Adi Badri Temple, Hemkund Sahib

Manaskhand Mandir Mala Scheme: A New Lifeline for Ancient Temples

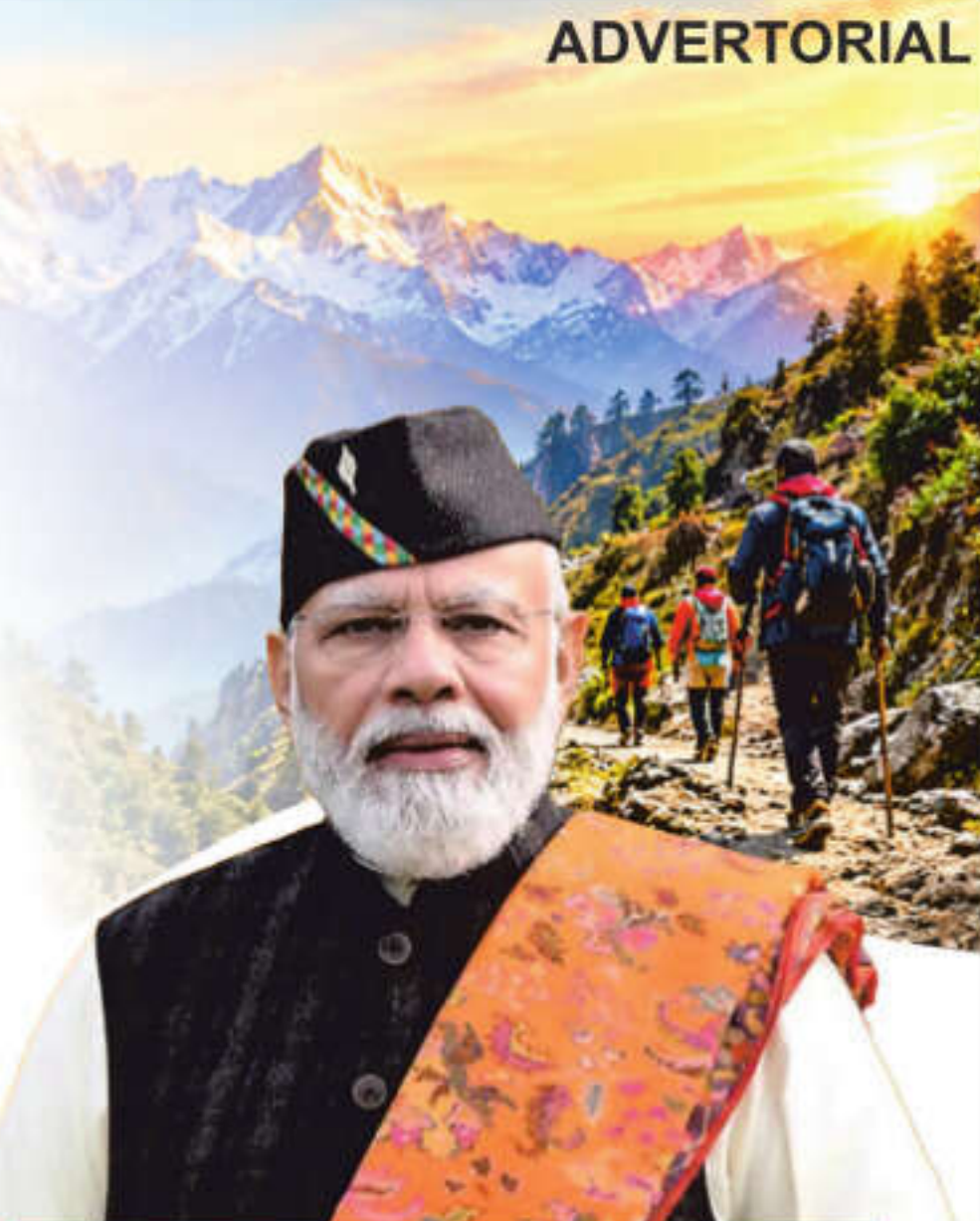


Under the Manaskhand Mandir Mala Scheme, the state government is undertaking infrastructure development around 48 ancient temples across the Kumaon region. In the first phase, 16 temples have been selected for development.

These include Jageshwar Temple, Golu Devta Temple, Katarmal Sun Temple, Kasar Devi, Nanda Devi, Patal Bhuvaneswar Cave, Hat Kalika, Purnagiri, Naina Devi, Baleswar, Kainchi Dham, Varahi Devi, Baijnath, Bagnath and Chaiti Balasundari Temple, along with other important religious sites across the region.

The scheme also covers several prominent temples and pilgrimage sites in Almora, Pithoragarh, Udhm Singh Nagar, Champawat, Bageshwar and Nainital, including Jankar Saim, Naitihna Devi, Vinhyavasini, Mallika Devi, Syahi Devi, Mostamanu, Berinag, Malyanath, Thalkedar, Kotgiri, Atariya Temple, Nanakmatta, Moteswar Mahadev, Meetha Reetha Sahib, Guru Gorakhnath Temple, Maneshwar Temple, Kot Bhramari, Shikhar Bhanar, Girija Devi Temple, Hanuman Temple, Somwari Mahadev, Devguru Brihaspatidham and Hanuman Garhi Temple.

The initiative is expected to strengthen infrastructure, improve pilgrimage experiences and boost economic activity around the ancient temples of the Kumaon region.



The construction of a developed India in the 21st century rests on two main pillars: first, pride in our heritage, and second, making every possible effort for development. Today, Uttarakhand is continuously strengthening both these pillars. This decade is the decade of Uttarakhand.

Narendra Modi
Prime Minister



Uttarakhand – A Global Adventure Destination

When it comes to adventure tourism in India, Uttarakhand stands out as a favourite destination for adventure enthusiasts, thanks to its diverse landscapes and breathtaking natural surroundings. The state offers an abundance of thrilling activities that are sure to fill you with excitement and adrenaline. This is what makes Uttarakhand an exceptional destination for adventure lovers from across the world. Many tourists visit Uttarakhand specifically to experience these exciting activities. For adventure enthusiasts, the state offers a wide range of thrilling sports and experiences, including river rafting, trekking, hiking, bungee jumping, and much more.



Trekking and hiking offer the perfect way to explore the remote and scenic landscapes of Uttarakhand. The traditional Ropkund Trek takes you through lush green forests and meadows, while the Valley of Flowers offers a breathtaking experience amidst vibrant alpine blooms. For adventure seekers, the Kedarkantha and Gaumukh-Tapovan treks promise unforgettable experiences that stay with you for a lifetime.



Known as the Yoga Capital of the World, Rishikesh is also famous for its thrilling adventure experiences, including one of India's highest bungee jumping sites. Adventure enthusiasts come here to challenge gravity while taking in the spectacular Himalayan surroundings.



Located in Chamoli district, Auli is a paradise for skiing enthusiasts. Adventure seekers travel through its winter wonderland, surrounded by snow-covered mountain slopes stretching into the distance. Auli is also renowned for hosting national winter sports events, giving athletes an opportunity to showcase their skills.



The rivers of Uttarakhand not only enhance the state's natural beauty but also offer exhilarating experiences for water-sports enthusiasts. From conquering rapids through white-water rafting to enjoying peaceful canoeing and kayaking experiences, the Ganga, Tons and Alaknanda rivers offer adventure seekers an unforgettable experience on the water.

We come to Dev Bhoomi Uttarakhand from our native places with one or more resolutions in our hearts. In the same spirit, I would like to urge you to take these five pledges

- Narendra Modi

First Pledge – Cleanliness First

Second Pledge – Respect for Nature and the Environment

Third Pledge – Emphasis on Service, Cooperation and Unity

Fourth Pledge – Promote Vocal for Local

Fifth Pledge – Follow Discipline, Safety and Dignity

Welcome to Devbhoomi Uttarakhand



Cause & Effect

THE SUPREME Court's concern over IPS deputation to the CAPFs took an unusual turn on Tuesday when the bench hearing contempt petitions against alleged non-compliance with its directions to reduce IPS deputation in CAPFs found the matter missing from the day's cause list. Justices Ujjal Bhuyan and AS Chandurkar had directed that the case be heard, but it was deleted during the lunch break without any prior order. Senior Advocate Guru Krishnakumar flagged the anomaly, prompting the bench to seek an explanation from the Registry and direct that the matter be listed again at 2 pm on Wednesday.

Far and Wide

THREE SAMAJWADI Party MPs found themselves in different parts of the national capital on Tuesday after police detained them from Jantar Mantar. The three MPs — Iqra Choudhary, Ziaur Rahman Barq and Mohibbullah Nadvi — were detained when they joined a protest called by some civil society groups against "illegal demolition of mosques" in the country. Choudhary was taken to Dwarka, Nadvi landed up in Najafgarh, and Barq was taken to the Mandir Marg police station after being detained. Choudhary and Nadvi could return to the main city by late evening after being released.

Raipur Rouse

CONGRESS MP Sukhdeo Bhagat's first visit to Raipur on Sunday since being appointed the AICC in-charge for Chhattisgarh has left a mark on the state unit leaders. Bhagat, who is an MP from Jharkhand's Lohardaga, made it clear in Raipur that he won't take factionalism lightly and that he was a representative of Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge in the state. The messaging from Bhagat took many in the state unit by surprise.

Amritpal outfit seeks registration, EC flags 'national security' concerns

Sohini Ghosh

New Delhi, September 29

THE ELECTION Commission on Tuesday told the Delhi High Court that there are "certain apprehensions pertaining to national security" with registering Akali Dal Waris Punjab De as a political outfit.

The submission by ECI counsel Sanjay Vashisht was made before Justice Saurabh Banerjee in response to a plea by the party, led by jailed Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh. The plea seeks a decision from the ECI on its request to approve its proposed name and register it as an unrecognised political party. The outfit had filed its application in January 2025 but no decision was taken. The outfit moved the HC in June 2026.

With Assembly polls in Punjab likely early next year, and the ECI's procedures expected to begin soon, senior advocate Meenakshi Arora, appearing for the outfit, asked the court to direct the ECI to decide its application by the end of November. "I'll have to seek an (election) symbol by December (if approved)."

Justice Banerjee, however, refused to immediately pass any directions without hearing the ECI. The ECI counsel then said, "This is a matter where there are certain apprehensions pertaining to national security."

The ECI shall have to report to the court by October 1.

CONGRESS WORKING COMMITTEE RESOLUTION

Cong raises pitch, says PM, Shah, CEC must resign over 'vote chori'

INDIA bloc to meet today, will take call on protest against 'poll malpractices'

Asad Rahman

New Delhi, September 29

REITERATING ITS allegation of "vote chori" (theft), the Congress on Tuesday stepped up its demand for the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, as well as Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah. In its resolution passed after a two-and-a-half hour meeting, the Congress Working Committee (CWC) also demanded the suspension of the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of voter rolls, and restoration of the over 13 crore names struck off the draft voter rolls so far.

The main Opposition party said the INDIA bloc would meet in Delhi on Wednesday and decide on launching a nationwide movement against alleged electoral malpractices. "In line with the mood of the nation, the CWC, therefore, resolves to: Demand the immediate resignation of the CEC, who has forfeited all moral and institutional authority. Demand the immediate suspension of the SIR in view of serious concerns regarding the integrity and transparency of the electoral rolls being prepared through the SIR, as well as the constitutional validity of the SIR process itself," the party said in its resolution.

"This brazen 'vote chori' has been organised by the CEC on behalf of the Prime Minister (Narendra Modi) and the Home Minister (Amit Shah). Nothing short of their resignation will ensure the safety of our Constitution and hard-earned democracy," the Congress said.

"The CWC is gravely alarmed by the mounting questions over the constitutionality of the SIR that has wiped out 13.30 crore Indians from the electoral rolls. A process that shifts the burden onto citizens to prove their own eligibility, is executed in haste without transparent safeguards, and results in arbitrary mass disenfranchisement cannot be reconciled with the guarantee of equality under Article 14 or universal adult suffrage under Article 326. An exercise of doubtful constitutional validity cannot be allowed to decide who may vote in the world's largest democracy," it said.

"Reportedly, two Election Commissioners raised 14 objections over 10 months, citing 'unauthorised' and 'illegal' changes to Form 6 used in the SIR, exposing a pattern of institutional overreach. The unprecedented concentration of control over electoral rolls in the hands of a few BJP-backed officials during the nationwide SIR serves as the last nail in the coffin of the ECI's credibility," the party said.

Last week, *The Indian Express* reported that ECs Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had objected on record at least 14 times in 10 months to SIR-related decisions taken without their knowledge and glaring gaps in processes.

The CWC resolution on Tuesday said the reports vindicated warnings by Rahul Gandhi, Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha, about the "systematic subversion of India's electoral process through vote chori". "What began as one man's solitary warning is now a national demand for transparency and accountability," it said.

On Tuesday, Congress general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal and senior party leader Jairam Ramesh said the meeting discussed key issues related to the ECI.



Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge with senior party leaders Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi during the CWC meeting in New Delhi on Tuesday. ANIL SHARMA

At CWC, Rahul's message to doubters: 'Start believing in me'

Asad Rahman & Manoj C G

New Delhi, September 29

FROM RAHUL Gandhi citing Narendra Modi and Amit Shah to question his doubters in the Congress to Mallikarjun Kharge's banter with Shashi Tharoor and Abhishek Manu Singhvi's advice to open back-channel dialogue with the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP), there were several notable moments in the CWC meeting on Tuesday.

Gandhi, it is learnt, told party leaders that some people in the CWC were not with him and they should "start believing" in him. The Leader of Opposition said that at a recent meeting with PM Modi and Home Minister Shah, he was asked if he had a problem with the BJP. Gandhi told the CWC that he told the two he was doing what was best for his party. To this, Modi and Shah replied that if the BJP loses power, the Congress will be the

one to replace it, Gandhi told the meeting. Gandhi then asked his colleagues that if Modi and Shah were "sure about the Congress" replacing them, why had some of them "not shown any confidence in the 'vote chori' (theft) campaign", said sources.

Rajya Sabha MP Abhishek Manu Singhvi is learnt to have said that the party should go all out on its demand to remove CEC Gyanesh Kumar. However, he is learnt to have advised the party that it should employ a "Track-II approach" when it comes to the CJP and not raise the CEC matter legally.

Gandhi, without naming the CJP, said that the Congress's sustained efforts had resulted in movement on issues such as vote theft and gaps in the education and examination systems, sources said.

After the meeting, the Congress demanded the resignation of Modi, Shah, and Kumar.

Sources said at the INDIA bloc meeting on Wednesday the party could propose holding joint Opposition rallies at Ram-lila Maidan in Delhi and in some of the state capitals over the EC issue.

Sources said former Madhya Pradesh CM Digvijaya Singh asked the leadership to conduct a SWOT analysis — Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats — of the RSS, which he deemed the Congress's "main ideological rival". When Singh said the party should not have allowed former Bihar CM Nitish Kumar to switch sides ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, Kharge said the JD(U) leader never wanted a national role in the INDIA bloc and he refused to become the coordinator of the INDIA bloc, saying he wanted to be in Bihar. Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi agreed with Kharge on this point.

Congress leaders are out to rip apart Constitutional mechanisms: BJP

Jatin Anand

New Delhi, September 29

COUNTERING THE Congress, the BJP on Tuesday accused the Opposition party of "leaving no stone unturned to rip apart India's Constitutional mechanisms".

Speaking to reporters, BJP national general secretary Smriti Irani asked why the Congress wanted the inclusion of dead and duplicate voters in the voter rolls. "In 2019, the incumbent president of the Congress had said that he would try his best to blemish the image of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. PM Modi said repeatedly that he could be targeted, but it should not turn into an assault on India's democracy and Constitutional authorities. But the Congress leadership is leaving no stone unturned to rip apart India's Constitutional mechanisms."

"As a citizen, I want to say that the Election Commission strengthens India's democratic systems and is the pride of Bharat's democracy, which has been appreciated and paid respect to by several countries. The Congress party is sad that the people of India do not support it within the democratic framework, this is why, instead of assessing its



Senior BJP leader Smriti Irani in New Delhi on Tuesday. ANI

defeat, it is attacking the Election Commission," Irani said. Saying that the EC has already said that BLOs would visit homes of those who had been issued notices under the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls to collect and verify their documents, she asked, "Why does the Congress want the names of dead people to be restored? Why does it want duplicate names to exist in the electoral roll?"

"The same Congress which was created for the protection of the British Empire is today attacking the Election Commission by referring to the Lahore Session of the Congress — nothing can be more shameful than this." Irani also asked if the Congress was giving the ECI a clean chit in Opposition-ruled states like Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Kerala and Karnataka.

Opp must file criminal case against CEC, says ex-Union minister Singh

Press Trust of India

New Delhi, September 29

FORMER UNION minister R K Singh has accused CEC Gyanesh Kumar of committing "illegalities" over the SIR of electoral rolls, calling upon opposition parties to file criminal cases against him.

Singh, a former Union home secretary who served in the Narendra Modi government for nearly seven years, also criticised the Supreme Court for upholding the SIR. He demanded fresh elections in states where polls were held while appeals against voter deletions were pending.

"Do you want India to remain a democracy? Then you must understand what Gyanesh Kumar, the CEC, and his bosses are doing in the so-called SIR. They are violating the law," Singh said in an open letter that he posted on X on Monday.

His remarks came amid controversy over objections raised by Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi to decisions concerning voter registration and deletion, changes to Form 6 and access to the electoral roll database during the SIR. Following a meeting of Kumar, Sandhu and Joshi on September 26, the ECI asserted that orders relating to the SIR had the unanimous approval of all three Commissioners and announced decisions on several issues flagged by the two ECs.

Singh questioned who authorised the nationwide exercise. "Another question is — who took the decision for SIR in the whole country? Was it the full Commission or only Gyanesh Kumar?" He also alleged that Kumar added a new appendix to the statutory Form 6 despite opposi-



Ex-Union minister R K Singh

tion from Sandhu and Joshi. "The majority was against the addition of the new appendix to the form. So, the addition of the new appendix was against the decisions of the Commission itself. So why was it added? On whose orders? This was illegal," Singh said.

The ECI has said that the declaration attached to Form 6 for the SIR was upheld by the Supreme Court and forms prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, would be used during non-SIR periods. Singh further questioned appeals against the inclusion of voters in West Bengal and alleged that centralisation of the electoral roll had undermined the statutory authority of electoral registration officers (EROs). "The centralisation of the voter list amendment is dangerous. It can be used to cut voters from booths which vote against NDA. Is this what happened?"

Going beyond the Opposition's demand for Kumar's removal, Singh said, "The Opposition says that they will impeach Gyanesh Kumar. That is an exercise in futility. They just do not have the numbers. If they really want a remedy, they should file criminal cases against Gyanesh Kumar." He has also called upon the opposition parties not to participate in elections until the CEC and the ECs resign.

EXPRESS special

Karnataka SIR: Murmurs in NDA camp over 'bulk deletion applications', 'burden on voters'

Akram M

Bengaluru, September 29

AS THE October 15 deadline for the disposal of claims and objections in the Karnataka SIR process draws near, sources said almost a quarter of those who received notices are unlikely to make it to the final electoral roll.

Amid complaints of large-scale applications to delete voters from the list reported from at least four constituencies, the unease is being felt within the NDA camp as well. Leaders of the JD(S), a BJP ally, speak in private of the "West Bengal model" of voter deletions being tried in Karnataka.

In West Bengal, the SIR process continues to drag on nine months after it was launched, before the Assembly elections in the state. Lakhs of appeals for inclusion in or deletion from electoral rolls in the state are pending before the Supreme Court-appointed tribunals.

Following *The Indian Express*'s investigation exposing several concerns within the ECI over how the SIR was proceeding, the poll panel has come out with a fresh set of directions, in-



The deadline to dispose of claims and objections in the SIR process in Karnataka is October 15. EXPRESS FILE

cluding door-to-door verification of documents by BLOs. However, while this has been welcomed by all, officials in Karnataka say that with the orders yet to reach them, there is confusion about implementation.

Before the SIR process began, Karnataka had 5.54 crore voters. Of them, around 1 crore were removed from the electoral roll during the enumeration phase, as they were classified under the Absent, Shifted, Dead, Deleted and Others category. Of the roughly 4.4 crore voters who made it to the draft roll, 43.81

lakh were served notices. If 20-25% or 9-11 lakh voters don't make it back, as officials suspect, the total electorate in Karnataka would shrink from 5.54 crore to around 4.35 crore. "These are the estimates. The final electorate number could rise due to fresh directions issued by the ECI," a source told *The Indian Express*.

Even if that happens, a JD(S) leader said, it made little sense how the SIR burden was put on the common man. "The BLOs could have been put on verification duty earlier itself, like the enumeration phase. Instead,

people have been made to queue up with their documents." The leader said JD(S) had raised the issue at meetings chaired by the state Chief Electoral Officer. "The CEO told us that they had sent a proposal in this regard."

Following the new ECI notification regarding verification by BLOs, there is also confusion about what the role of the Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs), tasked so far with checking documents, would be. In most seats, AEROs were appointed based on the number of notices issued. In the Kapu segment of Udipi district for instance, after around 20,000 notices were sent, an additional 18 AEROs were deputed from departments to conduct hearings.

"They have been doing SIR duty for the past 30 days. Now, the ECI says that BLOs can conduct hearings. Who should be held responsible for the work held up in various departments, as these 18 B-group officers have not been able to focus on department files due to SIR duties?" a source said.

In the final few days of the claims and objections phase, starting August 24, the ECI has

also been facing questions over mass filing of Form 7s to remove names from electoral rolls. The four constituencies where these allegations have surfaced — Bhalki, Babelshwar, Mudigere and Belgaum Uttar — involving 6,259 voters, are all represented by Congress legislators. At Mudigere, poll officials approached police over persons "misusing" details of a Booth Level Agent (who is a party representative) to submit Form 7 applications.

Sources in the CEO's office said that those submitting Form 7 applications without evidence could face legal action, to curb the practice.

Claiming several such attempts to bulk delete names, Congress Karnataka president B K Hariprasad said that a person in Vijayapura had taken 18,000 Form 7s. The complaints were later withdrawn, he said, adding that alert officials had checked similar "fraud" elsewhere too.

On misgivings expressed by JD(S) leaders, senior party leader KA Thippeswamy said the ECI's changed norms would help voters. "The provision allowing BLOs to hear cases is welcome. We should wait and see."

Ruling UDF loses 3 seats in Keralam local body bypolls

Shaju Philip

Thiruvananthapuram, September 29

IN THE first electoral test after coming into power in Keralam, the ruling Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) on Tuesday suffered a setback in the by-elections held to 38 divisions in various local bodies.

Of the 38 divisions/wards, the UDF had been in power in 22. However, the ruling alliance lost three seats in the by-poll. Opposition Left Democratic Front (LDF), which had 15 seats in the 38 divisions that went to the by-

election, increased its tally to 18. NDA partner Twenty-two retained a seat. The by-polls were held on Monday, with voter turnout at a tepid 58.81%, as against an almost 80% seen in the April Assembly elections.

Keralam has 2,357 wards/divisions under the three-tier local body system. The by-polls to the local bodies were necessitated after these seats fell vacant following the resignation of the sitting elected members. A few seats fell vacant after sitting local body members contested the recent Assembly elections and won.

UP officer who quit IAS announces entry into politics

Maulshree Seth

Lucknow, September 29

NEARLY A month after she took voluntary retirement, former IAS officer Divya Mittal on Monday announced that she had decided to enter politics, saying she wanted to become the "voice" of people whose concerns often fail to reach the government.

She said she would not stand "under any flag" and sought public support. In a social media post, the 2013-batch IAS officer of the Uttar Pradesh cadre said she took time to decide on her next step after resigning from the civil services. "I resigned from IAS last

month and left many questions behind. This is a big task, and I was gathering courage. Today I have come to answer. What next? The answer is politics." She said her decision was driven by a desire to represent people whose voices do not reach government offices.

She raised questions about schools sanctioned but never constructed, land allotted on lease but never handed over, poor roads and the deaths they cause, and the future of students amid exam paper leaks.

Recalling an inspection in Lahuria Dah of Mirzapur, where she served as district magistrate, Mittal said she had expected a



Former IAS officer Divya Mittal is an alumna of IIT Delhi, holds an MBA from IIM Bangalore

woman there to ask for a pension or a house. Instead, the woman, who didn't even have a drinking water connection at home, asked for a school in her village. Mittal said she sanctioned the

school, but construction had not begun even three years later.

"Tell me, what wasn't available? Funds, rules, or approvals? Everything was available, but there was no intent," she said, adding that she wanted answers on such "invisible schools".

On education and exam paper leaks, she asked if parents can now be certain that their children's future was secure. "I was an ordinary girl who got an opportunity, but what about today's children?" The objective, she said, is not to change a leader, but the nature of politics.

Indicating that she does not intend to join a political party, Mittal said, "Politics not with any

party, but with the people." She said the people who had supported her earlier would be part of her political journey. Sources close to her said she planned to contest polls as an Independent.

She also ruled out using caste as a card as she begins her political journey. UP, she said, has been her "karmabhoomi" and would be the starting point. "I have been told nothing changes in this country, especially in Uttar Pradesh. But Uttar Pradesh has always shown the way."

Mittal — who is an alumna of IIT Delhi, and also holds an MBA from IIM Bangalore — has shared a WhatsApp number for those wishing to connect.

SHG worker raped, assaulted in Begusarai hotel; video circulated

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, September 29

A WOMAN associated with a self-help group (SHG) was allegedly raped and brutally assaulted inside a hotel room in Bihar's Begusarai on Sunday, with videos of the incident circulated on social media.

More than 24 hours after the police registered an FIR on Monday, the alleged main accused remained at large on Tuesday, while another has been arrested, according to the police.

The accused allegedly circulated the video from the woman's own mobile number, police said, adding they have blocked the number now.

The incident took place at a hotel on a National Highway stretch — roughly 3 km from the office of the Begusarai Superintendent of Police (SP) and within the vicinity of a police station and outpost.

The incident comes in the backdrop of a spate of cases of sexual harassment and assault on women in the state, sparking reactions from Opposition leaders with RJD national working president Tejashwi Yadav alleging that law and order in Bihar had completely collapsed.

According to the woman's complaint, cited in the police press release, she left home around 7.30 am on September 27 to collect loan repayments from

members of self-help groups. On the way, she met a neighbour who allegedly offered her a ride on his motorcycle.

The complaint, according to the police note, said the accused took her to the area near a movie theatre where another man, the main accused, was already present. "The two allegedly took her to the hotel on the pretext of having a conversation," the note stated.

After checking in, the woman was allegedly threatened with a knife before being sexually assaulted, police said, adding that the alleged perpetrators also recorded the incident of physical assault and circulated the video on social media and WhatsApp groups.

The next day, the woman approached the police.

Police registered a case under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Information Technology Act. The accused who took her on the bike has been arrested, the police said. Meanwhile, an SIT has been formed and raids are being conducted to arrest the main accused.

SP Maneesh said all aspects of the case will be dealt with during the course of the investigation. "Currently, one accused has been apprehended. Further progress in this case has been posted on our social media platforms," he told *The Indian Express*.

2024 SAMBHAL VIOLENCE CASE

Confession can't be sole basis for detention under NSA: SC

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 29

A CONFESSION made before a police officer without any independent material to support it cannot be the basis for detention under the National Security Act (NSA)-1980, the Supreme Court said on Tuesday.

A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu delivered the judgment while quashing the preventive detention of Mulla Afroz, the alleged mastermind of the November 2024 Sambhal violence during the visit of a court-ordered team for a survey of the Jama Masjid.

Setting aside the June 8, 2026, judgment of the Allahabad High Court upholding his detention, the SC bench imposed Rs 10 lakh in costs on the UP government, and directed that the same be paid to Afroz.

The bench said that "where a confessional statement is procured by threats, coercion or inducement and recorded before a police officer, such statement is rendered inadmissible and irrelevant for the purpose of a criminal trial. The question which, thus, presents itself is, whether a statement, which the law treats as irrelevant for determining guilt, can nevertheless constitute a ground for forming the subjective satisfac-



At least four people were killed in the violence that broke out in Uttar Pradesh's Sambhal district in November 2024 during the visit of a court-ordered team for a survey of the Jama Masjid. FILE

tion necessary to sustain an order of preventive detention. We think not".

Afroz was arrested on January 17, 2025, in connection with the violence in Sambhal, which claimed four lives. He was detained under the NSA on October 13, 2025, when he was in judicial custody, and his detention for one year was confirmed on November 28, 2025.

The court noted that Afroz was granted bail by the HC in one of the cases on September 9, 2025, and in all cases by June.

It pointed out that the grounds in the detention order show the appellant had moved a bail application and, upon securing release, was allegedly planning to indulge in large-

scale violence. "What is evident therefrom is that the impugned detention is an attempt to frustrate the judicial order granting bail, and to keep the detenu in custody by another route. Such a detention is not preventive but punitive and appears intended to subvert the order granting bail," the court said.

The court agreed with Afroz's contention that the detention order was passed based on his extra-judicial confession, which could not be considered voluntary. It also wondered why Afroz was arrested 54 days after the registration of the FIR.

The bench said that though the state claimed to have supplied to him all 22 materials relied on by it for the detention,

the CCTV visuals, which were used to identify and arrest him, were not supplied.

The bench said "preventive detention has always been regarded as an exceptional measure. Although constitutionally recognised, it operates as a departure from the ordinary guarantees of personal liberty embodied in Article 21 of the Constitution and, therefore, must be invoked with the utmost circumspection and only in those rarest of rare cases where the circumstances genuinely warrant such exercise".

As per the prosecution, Afroz had instigated the crowd that turned violent and, in turn, "the public order of the entire Sambhal city as well as the surrounding areas was completely disrupted..." The Allahabad High Court upheld the detention order, saying it "is based on application of mind and proper exercise of jurisdiction by the respondent no. 3 (District Magistrate, Sambhal)".

The HC also pointed out that 22 documents, in support of the impugned detention order, were provided to Afroz. It noted that in the counter affidavit filed by the state, "it is clear that widespread violence was caused by the petitioner (detenu) and other persons in the alleged incident".

Woman keeps father's body in freezer for 4 yrs

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 29

A WOMAN allegedly kept the body of her 78-year-old father in a freezer at a day-care centre in Malad (East) for nearly four years, police said, adding that the matter came to light after the premises were sought to be vacated for redevelopment.

According to the police, the man's daughter, who is in her 40s, had kept her father's body at the day-care centre in the Malad area since June 2022 as she was "deeply attached" to her father and "wanted to preserve his body" till her life. The day-care centre had stopped functioning about a month ago. A police officer said that while preserving a body for such a long period was unusual, there was nothing suspicious about the death.

The man's daughter had taken a death certificate from the doctor and it was a natural death, said the officer.

The landlord, who owns the day-care centre and adjoining premises, had sought to vacate the property as the chawl, which has over 2000 sq ft area, was going to be redeveloped.

A police team visited the centre and found the man's body. The centre operators had also not informed the police about the body, the officer said.

During the inquiry, police learnt that the deceased man's daughter lives in Andheri (West). The daughter also told police that they had contacted an organisation in the US that provides body-preservation services. They allegedly planned to shift the body to the US and had been saving money for the process, police said.

Antilia bomb scare: Special court grants Waze bail, NIA moves HC

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, September 29

MORE THAN five years after Sachin Waze was arrested in the Antilia bomb scare case, a special court in the city on Tuesday granted bail to the dismissed police officer, while noting that the National Investigation Agency (NIA) failed to show that the Ambanis were terrorised. The court also refused the central agency's request for stay on Sachin Waze's bail order.

Soon after, Additional Solicitor General (ASG) Anil Singh for NIA approached the HC with an appeal challenging the special court verdict before a division bench led by Justice Sarang V Kotwal. However, Justice Kotwal on Tuesday refused himself from hearing the appeal, noting that he "does not take up matters of the parties represented by senior advocate Manoj Mohite", who is appearing for Waze. The appeal is listed for hearing before an alternate bench Justice Bharati H Dangre on Wednesday.

As per his lawyer, with special court granting him bail in NIA case and Waze getting relief in other cases earlier, he can be released from jail, unless HC stays the bail order.

Granting bail to Sachin Waze on furnishing a personal bond of Rs 1 lakh with a local solvent surety, the special court observed that his act "prima facie falls short to satisfy the definition of a terrorist act under Section 15 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act".

It also held that Mansukh Hiran's murder "at this moment does not appear to be a direct outcome of any terrorist act" and was independent of UAPA offences and stringent bail restrictions under UAPA



Suspended police officer Sachin Waze. FILE

would not apply.

Special judge Chakor S Baskar also noted that the central agency failed to record statements from any member of the Ambani family to establish that they were terrorised.

The special court designated under the NIA Act observed that Sachin Waze "made out a prima facie case" to grant bail due to considerable time in prison and the trial being "unlikely to conclude in the near future". It said bail refusal would cause "great prejudice" to "personal liberty" of Waze.

Waze has been in custody since 2021 and was booked for offences, including murder, criminal conspiracy, and other offences under the Indian Penal Code (IPC) along with provisions UAPA, and the Arms Act.

The agency alleged that Waze parked the SUV containing explosives outside industrialist Mukesh Ambani's residence, Antilia, in South Mumbai on February 25, 2021, and was involved in the plot to kill the vehicle's owner, Mansukh Hiran.

"Day-to-day business of the Ambanis does not appear to have been disturbed even for a minute, soon after the incident till this moment," the court said.

Two students die by suicide in five days at Andhra medical college

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, September 29

TWO SUICIDES in five days by female medical students have rocked Andhra Medical College at Visakhapatnam in Andhra Pradesh, prompting the Medical Education Department to launch a probe. On September 24, Dr P Sailaja, a final-year student of MD General Medicine, died by suicide at her house in Ramnagar. On September 28 morning, Y Sravani, a first-year PG student of ENT, killed herself at her rented accommodation in Chinna Waltair.

The Three Town police said Dr Sailaja was upset over her performance in exams, and had discussed the same with her family members. Last Thursday, she had to appear for an exam but instead of going to college, she locked herself in her room and was found dead by her parents.

Sravani, from Hyderabad, was a first-year PG student. She left behind a suicide note saying nobody was to be blamed for her death. Sravani had completed her MBBS from Osmania University and enrolled for the

PG at AMC. Her mother Padma said she was unhappy with the ENT course and wanted to quit and return to Hyderabad.

"As of now, it appears that stress and disappointment over bad performance in exams drove them to take the extreme step. There are indications that Sravani was probably homesick. We are talking to family members and friends and college administrators and exploring all the angles," an official said. Officials said Sravani had enquired if it was possible to quit the course mid-term and whether the college would return her MBBS certificates if she wanted to transfer elsewhere.

The medical college principal Dr K Sandhya Devi said neither of the students complained about anything to their seniors in the respective departments. "The campus has plunged into distress and grief; it is too much to process. We are offering support to families of both," she said. State Health Minister Satya Kumar Yadav has also requested Medical Education Director A Vishu Vardhan to probe the incidents.

SC dedicates judgment to law clerk who died four days before 27th birthday

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, September 29

IN A rare gesture, the Supreme Court on Tuesday dedicated a judgment to its law clerk-cum-research associate, who died four days before his 27th birthday and assisted in a case relating to the detention of an accused under the National Security Act (NSA).

A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu expressed grief over the untimely demise of Ritwik Deswal, who worked as a law clerk-cum-research associate in Justice Datta's office.

"Human life is fragile. Yet, in the ordinary course of living, we seldom pause to recognise just how fleeting it is; and when life finally confronts us with that fragility, the realisation often comes too late. On that note, at the very outset, we begin on an unconventional premise. One of our dearest law clerks-cum-research associates, Ritwik Deswal, left for his heavenly abode four days short of his 27th birthday, which happens to be today. As we pronounce this judgment, which bears the quiet and indelible imprint of his final labours, we wish to record our deep appreciation for the invaluable research assistance rendered by him in the build-up to the preparation of this judgment," the bench said.

"Even in his final hours, his thoughts remained firmly anchored in the pursuit of truth and the service of justice..." it said.

EXPRESS special

He bought land in Kashmir; 6 yrs later, someone else was building house on it

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, September 29

IN 2017, retired Fisheries Director Mufti Manzoor went to Balhama on the outskirts of Srinagar to check on his land purchased in 2012. He had been with his son in Australia and was coming here after five years.

He was stunned by what he found: The land had been fenced off and a house was being built on it. But Manzoor had never sold it. He approached revenue officials for an explanation. Finally, he took his complaint to then Srinagar Deputy Commissioner Syed Abid Rashid, who set up a panel headed by then Additional Deputy Commissioner K K Sidha. It was revealed someone else had "purchased" the property without Manzoor's knowledge or consent.

The probe was taken up by the J&K Police's Crime Branch, which found the case extended far beyond Manzoor's land. It was a widespread land mafia, where the same plots of land had allegedly been sold several times to different buyers, with revenue officials manipulating land records to facilitate the fraud.

Manzoor had bought three plots with his son and sister-in-law: Two measured 800 square yards each, and the third 425 square yards. Their sale deeds were registered after payment of the official stamp duty, and the land was subsequently mutated in the names of Manzoor's wife, son and sister. But 58 days after those mutations were made, they were allegedly cancelled.

Investigators claimed Nusrat Aziz, tehsildar of the same city



Retired Fisheries Director Mufti Manzoor had purchased the land in Balhama, on the outskirts of Srinagar district, in 2012. EXPRESS

suburb, ordered the cancellation in "connivance" with a broker named Riyaz Ahmad Bhat and other revenue officials. Bhat, officials claimed, was the one who had sold Manzoor the land.

The cancellation, officials said, allowed Bhat to obtain fresh land extracts from the Patwari and sell the property again — this time to two brothers. One *kanal* was also allegedly transferred in Aziz's name. Aziz told investigators that she had "purchased" the land from Bhat.

The probe then uncovered a discrepancy in the revenue records, officials said. Whenever a property is bought or sold and transaction is recorded through a mutation, the Patwari prepares two copies of the land documents: the Parti-Patwar, kept at Patwari's office, and Parti-Sarkar, sent to Muhafiz Khana for safekeeping. In Manzoor's case, officials said, the mutation paper had been changed in the Patwari's record, but remained unchanged in the Parti-Sarkar. The latter still recorded Manzoor's family as the original buyers.

Investigators sent the rev-

enue documents for forensic analysis: it confirmed Aziz had "signed" these papers. They also went through bank statements and call records of the officials and found "certain connections between Bhat and Aziz".

The mutation cancellation order was later set aside. An investigating officer said the cancellation was beyond Aziz's authority. *The Indian Express* tried to contact Aziz several times, but she was not available for a comment.

Manzoor, meanwhile, said he had confronted Bhat before filing a complaint. "...He said he had to give one *kanal* (800 square yards) to the Tehsildar."

Bhat then began offering him alternatives. Eventually, they settled on two huts being built in Pahalgam. But that deal also fell apart. "The huts were under construction... Finally when they came up, he (Bhat) asked for some more time for electric fittings. I said we will do it ourselves. But before the sale was about to be completed, I found that the huts and the land with it are mortgaged with the bank," Manzoor said. Bhat offered them

many alternatives and every time they agreed, it turned out to be someone else's land.

Then, about a year after the alleged nexus between Bhat and Aziz came under probe, Aziz filed an FIR against Manzoor, his son and another person. Aziz claimed she was informed some people were tearing down the boundary wall of the land she had purchased from Bhat. She claimed that when she reached the spot and tried to stop them, they allegedly assaulted her.

Police registered an FIR and filed a chargesheet. The court, however, said in its order on August 31, "...The accused are acquitted of the charge levelled against them... as nothing has been proved against them without any reasonable doubt."

Before investigators filed a chargesheet against Aziz and other revenue officials in December 2025, they came across another complaint involving the same broker and officials. A woman, in a complaint to the Crime Branch, said she had purchased five *kanals* and four marlas of land for Rs 88.4 lakh. Investigators said, "It was later revealed the land she bought was sold to someone else."

Investigators said that they found allegations of forged land records against Aziz, Riyaz and Patwari Ashiq Ali in other cases too. In one of them, Aziz and Ali were arrested in July 2025. Bhat was also arrested. All three are now out on bail.

Now, Manzoor says, "Just like the drug mafia, there is the land mafia... My only aim is to get them punished for what they've done with so many people."

Uttarakhand's first glacial lake early-warning system in Vasundhara Tal, Chamoli

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
Dehradun, September 29

WEEKS AFTER the Nepal disaster, the Himalayan state of Uttarakhand is moving from mapping its vulnerable glacial lakes to monitoring them in real time, with the state's first early-warning system for a glacial lake being installed at Vasundhara Tal in Chamoli from Tuesday.

A scientific and technical team comprising experts from the Central Building Research Institute (CBRI), Roorkee, and the Wadia Institute of Himalayan Geology, Dehradun, left for the high-altitude lake on Tuesday. The operation, scheduled from September 29 to October 15, is being supported by

the State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), and the Indo Tibetan Border Police (ITBP).

On Tuesday, Chief Secretary Anand Bardhan, who flagged off the team, said the initiative would help reduce the risk posed by glacial lake outburst floods (GLOFs). "This initiative will prove to be a milestone in reducing the dangers of GLOFs in the coming years and in understanding the risks," he said.

In August, a massive flood in Nepal's Lhende Khola and Bhoté Koshi river system was initially linked to a possible earthquake. Subsequent analysis by the US Geological Survey found that the seismic energy was instead generated by a gla-

cial collapse and debris flow. The disaster killed hundreds and swept away roads, bridges and houses.

A year earlier, Uttarakhand itself witnessed the devastating Dharali flash flood in Uttarakashi. While some experts suspected a glacial lake breach, others pointed to rainfall, glacier-related processes and the possibility of an avalanche or landslide. It is against this backdrop that the initiative begins with Vasundhara Tal this year.

Surveys to sensors

In January 2025, *The Indian Express* reported that the Uttarakhand State Disaster Management Authority (USDMA) was preparing a plan to study and monitor the state's glacial lakes.



Chief Secretary Anand Bardhan flagging off the team that left for the high-altitude lake, in Dehradun on Tuesday

The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) had identified 13 high-risk glacial lakes in Uttarakhand, of which five were classified as Category A, the highest-risk

category. Vasundhara Tal was among them.

USDMA officials had said the first step was to establish the physical characteristics of the lakes — including their

length, width, terrain and depth — and assess downstream flow. The next stage was to deploy instruments for real-time monitoring.

According to the latest government data, 344 glacial lakes were identified in Uttarakhand in 2023 by the National Remote Sensing Centre. Of the 13 high-risk lakes, six are in Pithoragarh, four in Chamoli and one each in Bageshwar, Tehri Garhwal and Uttarkashi.

Bathymetric surveys have already been completed at six lakes — Saraswati Tal and Vasundhara Tal in Chamoli; Kedartal in Uttarkashi; and Maibang, Pyungru and Syunkti Yankti proglacial lakes in Pithoragarh's Darma Valley.

These surveys establish the

depth and water-holding capacity of the lakes — information that can be used to assess the potential scale of a GLOF.

What the Vasundhara system will monitor

The system being installed at Vasundhara will track water level, weather, snow conditions, water flow and movement around the lake.

A water-level sensor will monitor fluctuations and abnormal changes. An automatic weather station will record temperature, humidity, rainfall, wind speed and direction, atmospheric pressure and light intensity. Snow-depth and sub-surface temperature sensors will monitor changes in snow conditions. Tilt and accelerometer

sensors will detect movement and vibrations at selected locations. The equipment will be powered through a solar-energy system.

The state government said the system would enable "continuous monitoring of environmental and hydrological changes in and around Vasundhara Tal".

The larger challenge, however, lies in converting that information into a warning that reaches vulnerable communities before a flood does.

The government says satellite phones and low-Earth-orbit communication devices have been provided to the team to maintain communication with USDMA from the high Himalayas.

Deported from UAE, Nirav Modi’s associate Sandeep Mistry arrested by CBI

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 29

THE CENTRAL Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has secured the deportation of fugitive diamond merchant Nirav Modi’s associate Sandeep Mistry from the United Arab Emirates (UAE) to India in connection with the Punjab National Bank (PNB) fraud case, a CBI spokesperson said Tuesday.

Mistry, wanted by the CBI’s Bank Securities and Fraud Branch in Mumbai, was brought to Mumbai at 11.55 pm on Monday and taken into custody by CBI officers.

The spokesperson said he was produced before the competent court, which sent him to judicial custody.

According to the CBI spokesperson, Mistry is accused of involvement in fictitious international trade transactions linked to the PNB fraud case. “He acted as a key link between various entities, oversaw their day-to-day operations and issued instructions through clandestine, self-deleting communication platforms to conceal evidence,” the spokesperson claimed.

“At the CBI’s request, a Red Notice was published against Mistry through Interpol channels in July 2026. He was subsequently geo-located and arrested by UAE authorities, following which deportation proceedings were initiated,” the spokesperson said.

VILLAGERS SAY THEY PAY UP TO Rs 1,500 A TANKER FOR DAILY REQUIREMENT

Water tankers move into parched Marathwada before monsoon exit

Sadaf Modak
Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, Jalna, September 29

THE MONSOON is not yet over, but in parts of drought-hit Marathwada, villages are already turning to water tankers. With 74 of the region’s 76 talukas declared drought-affected, 277 tankers are currently supplying water to 160 villages, while more villages have begun seeking tanker supplies as local wells and water sources run dry.

The administration maintains that water stored in major reservoirs, including the Jayakwadi dam near Paithan, will be sufficient for drinking and other domestic requirements. But in villages, farmers are already watching wells and local water sources run dry, with some spending thousands of rupees a day to keep their crops and livestock alive.

In Shahapur in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, 40-year-old farmer Badrinath Bharat is spending Rs 3,000 a day on two tankers to keep his ginger crop alive. The water is also used by his family and 10 cattle.

“I have already lost all of the cotton and maize I had sowed. We have a well but it is dry. For the past 15 days, I am forced to spend on the tankers. I can do this for a month with the hope of some yield... after that I will discontinue,” said Bharat, who lost crops, including tomato, cotton and maize.



Badrinath Bharat at his corn farm in Shahapur, Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar. NARENDRA VASKAR

In Siddhanath Vadgaon village in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, farmer Sachin Bilwal has been buying tanker water for more than a month, mainly for his family and three cattle. He pays Rs 1,000 for a tanker, which lasts about a week.

“I am required to pay Rs 1,000 per tanker and it lasts me a week. We have requested the gram sabha to seek tankers from the government. Hopefully it will be arranged soon but so many villages are in a similar situation even before monsoon has ended,” Bilwal said.

Bilwal had cultivated cotton, maize and tur, but said the crops had yielded no output because of lack of rain. Like Bharat, he

has a well but no water in it.

The water stress comes after a poor monsoon across the region. Maharashtra received 18 per cent less rainfall than normal this year, while Marathwada recorded a deficit of 38 per cent. The deficit was higher in some districts, with Latur recording 48 per cent less rainfall than normal and Parbhani 43 per cent.

The scale of the emerging water crisis is reflected in the tanker deployment. In Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, 77 villages are currently being supplied by 120 tankers, while 65 villages in Beed are receiving 127 tankers. Jalna has 22 tankers supplying water in villages.

Among the relief measures

announced after the state declared drought in 265 of its 358 talukas is the deployment of tankers for drinking water wherever required.

In Jalna, the impact is also visible in fields where farmers had invested in irrigation systems, in the hope that monsoon would provide enough water to sustain their crops. Abasaheb Dinkar Rathod, a farmer from Govindpur, planted tomatoes on an acre and coriander and ladyfinger on another plot. On Tuesday, he was left with little more than a few stunted coriander plants and a single cart of tomatoes, which he said would fetch less than Rs 100.

Rathod had installed drip

lines beneath the plants and used mulching and protective covers for his tomato crop. But the rain did not come.

“This area depends majorly on rainfall. I had arranged for the drip hoping that with the rainfall, this will suffice for the tomatoes to grow. Nothing remains now,” Rathod said.

He plans to pull out the tomato plants and try another crop during the rabi season. But even that will depend on whether he can find water.

“I do not have the courage right now. There is no irrigation option for farms. Even for personal usage, we have to depend on water from a local well, two kilometres from our home,” Rathod said.

Officials in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar said there was no water shortage or water cuts in the district at present, and that additional tankers would be deployed if required.

Of the 277 tankers deployed for villages in the region, only three are owned by the government. The remaining tankers are operated by private owners and paid for by the state government.

The water shortage is also unfolding as work under the Jal Jeevan Mission remains incomplete in the region. According to data from the Marathwada divisional administration, only about half of the work under the scheme has been completed so far, with lack of funds and other reasons cited for the delay.

15 PEOPLE ARRESTED, EIGHT FIRs FILED

Day after violence in Ujjain, police book five local influencers for ‘spreading propaganda’



Security personnel near the mosque site in Ujjain on Tuesday. ANI

Anand Mohan J
Ujjain, September 29

MADHYA PRADESH police probing the violence that preceded the partial demolition of the Shahi Masjid in Ujjain have claimed that five social media influencers uploaded reels to “spread propaganda against the religion in society”.

Five social media influencers, all residents of Ujjain, have been booked by the police under various sections for promoting enmity, outraging religious feelings, circulating false information, etc.

The police case registered at Kharakua police station provides one of the clearest windows into the online activity in the hours before the violence.

The complaint names the holders of several Instagram and Facebook accounts and records specific posts that police say were being circulated on September 27, the day before the confrontation between police personnel and locals opposing the demolition.

The police have alleged that these social media influencers had also been protesting at the mosque site. The police FIR has alleged they were “making reels, uploading videos and posting them on social media for the

purpose of organising the protest, spreading propaganda against the religion in society, disturbing public peace and attempting to incite people”.

Among them is the Instagram account which police claimed belongs to one Sajid Khan.

According to the complaint, a video uploaded through the account said that police had arrived with a JCB at the Shahi Masjid and urged people to reach the mosque “as soon as possible”. Another account allegedly belongs to Imran.

The police case also names Facebook accounts allegedly associated with Gulrez Khan, Billu Pathan and Arif Pathan, who are accused of circulating videos urging people to reach the mosque at around 2 am. “There is a strong possibility that this may disturb social and religious harmony in the city,” the FIR reads.

Police also said a faction of the mosque committee disgruntled by the demolition was responsible for mobilising the crowd. The police arrested 15 persons and filed eight FIRs across three police stations.

Investigators are also examining more than 100 Instagram accounts and posts, along with CCTV and drone footage.

School headmaster, wife hacked to death at their home in UP

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, September 29

A GOVERNMENT school headmaster and his wife were killed at their home, located on the premises of a private school, in Uttar Pradesh’s Sultanpur, police said.

Police received information on Tuesday morning that the bodies had been found in Kumbhi Dariya village, under the jurisdiction of Kadirpur police station. School employees had arrived and found the couple lying in pools of blood.

The victims are Mukesh Singh, 48, headmaster of Composite School in Sultanpur, and his wife, Vineeta Singh, 45, who ran the private school.

Police said preliminary investigation suggested that the attackers first killed Vineeta and then turned on Mukesh when he allegedly tried to flee. Vineeta’s body was found about 100 metres from her husband’s body.

Police said both victims appeared to have been attacked with considerable force. They had sustained deep wounds to their bodies and their throats appeared to have been slit. The exact nature of the injuries will

be established after the post-mortem, police said.

An axe bearing blood stains was recovered from the crime scene, though police are yet to establish whether it was the murder weapon.

Superintendent of Police Vineet Jaiswal said it was not immediately clear whether the killings took place on Monday night or Tuesday morning.

Police are examining possible motives, including enmity, and gathering information from family members and people known to the couple.

They are also examining CCTV footage from the area and evidence collected from the crime scene to establish the sequence of events and identify those responsible.

Mukesh was actively involved in local teachers’ union politics and was contesting a teachers’ association election. Vineeta had previously contested a panchayat member election but lost.

The couple had lived in the house for three decades. Mukesh was the youngest of three brothers. The couple is survived by a 20-year-old son, Abhyuday, who is studying at a university in Delhi.

IIT MADRAS STUDY

‘Highly educated, digitally savvy professionals among cyberfraud victims’

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, September 29

VICTIMS OF financial cybercrimes are often highly educated professionals and digital literacy alone did not insulate them from such frauds, reveals an IIT Madras study, thereby voiding the perception that it is the lack of technological knowledge that fraudsters take advantage of.

The study also challenged the perception that cybercrime victims are driven by greed.

The interviews conducted show that fear, family expectations, financial pressure and gullibility can also make individuals vulnerable to frauds, especially when they are targeted during periods of stress or life disruptions.

Fraudsters exploited these circumstances to engineer a ‘brain freeze’ – or ‘mind arrest’, as the victims described it – wherein the latter were impaired from thinking clearly.

The victims for the study include techies, bankers, doctors, management and finance professionals, public sector officers, and even individuals with cybersecurity certifications.

While financial losses ranged from a few thousand rupees to more than Rs 1 crore in each case, victims also reported shame, insomnia, de-

pression and damaged family trust.

Professor P Kandaswamy, IPS (Retd), of IIT Madras, said, “The response to cybercrime must move beyond blaming victims.” He said banks and law-enforcement agencies need stronger systems for early detection, rapid intervention and coordinated response, along with better support for victims.

The study recommended moving beyond generic ‘Be Careful Online’ messaging towards targeted awareness based on specific fraud tactics and vulnerable situations, given the prevalence of India-specific tactics employed by the fraudsters, including threats involving Aadhaar, UPI-based money transfers, fake investment platforms claiming SEBI registration, and ‘digital arrest’ scams.

The study was led by Professors P Kandaswamy and Nandan Sudarsanam of IIT Madras, in collaboration with Akanksha Jaiswal of UWA India (Chennai) and Ameeta Fernando of the Loyola Institute of Business Administration.

They interviewed 33 victims – 22 men and 11 women, including 12 senior citizens, across Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, New Delhi, and Mumbai.

Heavy rain in Nepal leads to breach in embankment of Gandak in Bihar

Santosh Singh
Patna, September 29

HEAVY, SHORT-DURATION rainfall in the Nepalese catchment area of the Gandak River basin has triggered a severe flash flood, placing downstream districts in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh on high alert.

The flash flood, triggered by the recent Nepal flood, caused breach of Gandak embankment at Bagaha on Monday, threatening floods in adjoining areas.

According to the Water Resources Department in Bihar, a massive discharge of 5,43,500 cusecs was recorded at the Valmikinagar Gandak Barrage at 6 am on Tuesday.

The river maintained a discharge exceeding 500,000 cusecs for 13 hours and over 400,000 cusecs for 32 hours, sending floodwaters surging through downstream districts in Bihar including West Champaran, East Champaran, Gopalganj, Saran, Muzaffarpur, and Vaishali.

Heavy rainfall across border districts such as West Champaran, East Champaran, and Gopalganj between September 26 and 27 had already elevated water levels in the lower reaches prior to the surge.

“Although the peak discharge from the barrage was slightly lower than the 2024 record of 562,500 cusecs, the river established a new historical record at the Bagaha gauge site. Water levels reached a new Highest Flood Level (HFL) of 91.25 meters, surpassing the previous record of 90.90 meters set in 2024 by 0.35 meters (35 cm),” according to a statement



People waded through a partially inundated area at Khairatwa village in Bihar’s West Champaran district on Tuesday. PTI

by the Water Resources Department.

The immense volume of water exerted intense pressure on river embankments, causing widespread seepage, piping, and overtopping. Field teams managed to secure 169 seepage and piping points through immediate emergency repairs.

However, during the mid-night hours between September 28 and 29, critical breaches occurred at three sites, the statement noted.

In West Champaran, Bihar, two breaches were recorded on the left bank of the Champaran embankment. The first was a minor breach of approximately 10 meters caused by sudden subsidence at the 4 km mark in Khairatwa village under Bagaha-1 block.

Spilling water is spreading through nearby fields and is ex-

pected to re-enter the river around the 9.50 km mark, though low-lying areas in Agastya, Khairatwa, and Chandrapur villages face potential inundation and disrupted connectivity.

A second breach occurred at Phuliyakhar village in Bairia block. Another embankment breach was reported on the right bank of the river in Kushinagar district, Uttar Pradesh.

As of 8 am on Tuesday, water levels at the Valmikinagar Barrage showed a clear receding trend, with downstream discharge reducing to 191,200 cusecs.

Upstream and downstream gauge levels at the barrage were recorded at 356.70 feet and 354.10 feet, respectively, while the Devghat gauge station in Nepal reported a discharge of 219,677 cusecs (6.14 meters) at

6:25 qm with a falling trend.

While water levels upstream continue to drop, downstream reaches are experiencing a temporary rise as the surge progresses toward lower areas.

The Water Resources Department and West Champaran district administration have mobilised teams on the ground to undertake breach repairs and emergency protection works.

Given the severity of the situation, headquarters dispatched four executive-engineer-led response teams overnight to Bagaha, Bettiah, Motihari, and Gopalganj to oversee anti-erosion measures and structural interventions alongside previously deployed engineering staff.

Senior department officials continue to monitor the flood response round the clock.

● ON SEPTEMBER 25, THEIR DREAM OF A BETTER LIFE WAS CUT SHORT WHEN, WHILE RETURNING FROM WORK, THE DUO MET WITH AN ACCIDENT IN DA LAT CITY

2 men from Jharkhand went to Vietnam to teach yoga, kin now await their bodies

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, September 29

THREE YEARS ago, Vinay Yadav from Jamshedpur left for Vietnam to work as a yoga instructor. From Ranchi, 24-year-old Raja Kumar followed the same path in 2025. Together, they worked at the Adi Yoga Academy in Da Lat city where they hoped to change their families’ fortunes.

On September 25, the dream was cut short when the duo, returning from work, met with an accident. While Raja died the same day, Vinay (23) succumbed to his injuries two days later at the hospital. Their families in Jharkhand are now waiting to get their bodies back.

In Ranchi, Raja’s mother

Rupa Devi is inconsolable.

“Whenever someone comes home, my mother starts crying. She is only saying that the body of her son should come home soon,” Raja’s younger brother, Shubham Kumar, told *The Indian Express*. Raja had gone to the southeast Asian nation at the suggestion of his paternal uncle, Rahul Kumar, who lives there. The family had hoped that the job would give Raja, who had studied until Class 12, a chance to improve the family’s financial condition. Raja had trained in yoga for four years before heading to Vietnam.

His father Shubham, who is an electrician, said, “He was the one looking after the house and sending money. He was earning for the family.” Raja used to

speak to his family daily. His last conversations with them were ordinary: Asking his mother how she was, whether she had eaten and what she was doing.

On September 25 evening, Rahul had said that it was raining heavily in Da Lat — when Raja and Vinay were returning home after giving a yoga class. The duo was travelling on a company scooter when it slipped on the wet road and rammed into a car ahead of them. Raja died on the spot, while Vinay was taken to a hospital where he remained under treatment for two days before breathing his last.

Rahul said he has been trying to arrange for his nephew’s body to be brought back to India. “Whatever needs to be done, we are doing it.”



Raja Kumar (left) from Ranchi had died on the spot, while Vinay Yadav from Jamshedpur succumbed to his injuries two days later

The process, however, has been difficult and expensive. Raja’s family was told that bringing his body back could cost around Rs 20 lakh. Rahul and his friends in Vietnam are arranging money and completing the paperwork there, while



the family in Ranchi is seeking help from local officials and political representatives.

“Everyone is running around, trying to get some help,” Shubham said.

Around 26 kms away, in Jamshedpur, the family of Vinay is

going through a similar wait. His cousin Abhijit, who has been living in Vietnam for 5-6 years, is helping with the arrangements to bring Vinay’s body back.

Abhijit said the exact circumstances surrounding Vinay’s death were still not clear to him. “The road was wet and the vehicle reportedly slipped before hitting another car. Vinay was first taken to a local hospital and later shifted to the main hospital.” Abhijit further said that the family in Jamshedpur has not yet been told the full truth about Vinay’s condition. “Only the men know the truth while his mother and other female members know that he is under treatment. They are still hoping that their son will come back safely,” he said.

“It is very difficult to hide it but it is also difficult to tell them that he is no more. All women in the family are praying and organising *hawan* for his recovery. I myself do not know how many days it will take to bring the body... I am all alone here,” said Abhijit. The process could take another five days, he said, adding that the estimated cost of sending Vinay’s body to India is over Rs 10 lakh.

Both the families said that they are trying to approach officials in Jharkhand and the Indian authorities for help with the repatriation.

Shikha Lakra, head of the State Migrant Workers Control Room, said that Raja’s family had arranged around Rs 14 lakh required for the repatriation of

his body. “We have not received an application from the second family (Vinay’s) yet. Raja’s body is likely to be brought back in a few days, after which the administration will look into reimbursing the amount,” she said.

For young men like Raja and Vinay, going to Vietnam has been a way to find lucrative work, thousands of kms away from home. Abhijit, who has been teaching yoga for years, said there was demand for yoga instructors because people in Vietnam were increasingly conscious about fitness. “They also see yoga as something that has come from India,” Abhijit said. That demand has brought several people from India, including from Jharkhand, to Vietnam to work as yoga instructors.



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER,
CENTRAL RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, BHUBANESWAR

No. 5972

“e” Procurement Notice for Road Works

Date 28.09.2026

1	Name of the Work	Road Works under MMSY-Transferred Road Improvement Programme MMSY-TRIP and MMSY-Input, to Existing RD road for the year 2025-26
2	Total No. of works	5 Nos. of Road works
3	Estimated Cost of the work	Varies from Rs.256.74 lakh to Rs.995.34 lakh
4	Class of Contractor	-
a)	Estimated cost more than Rs. Rs.20.00 lakh up to Rs. 3.00 Crores.	- B Class (of Odisha PWD) or relevant class of other licensing authorities
b)	Estimated cost more than Rs. 1.00 Crore up to Rs. 20.00 Crores.	- A Class (of Odisha PWD) or relevant class of other licensing authorities
c)	Estimated cost more than Rs. 6.00 Crore up to Rs. 50.00 Crores.	- Special Class (of Odisha PWD) or relevant class of other licensing authorities
d)	Estimated cost more than Rs. 20.00 Crores	- Super Class (of Odisha PWD) or relevant class of other licensing authorities
5	Period of completion	As mentioned in Column-7 of Annexure
6	Offered rates by bidder	The offered rate by the contractor shall be excluding GST.
7	Other details	-

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender online for bidding	Date & Time of opening of Tender	
		From To	Technical Bid Financial Bid	
Chief Engineer, Central Rural Works Circle, Bhubaneswar	Tender Online- C.C.21 of 2026	07.10.2026 to 11.00 A.M.	26.10.2026 up to 5.00 P.M. at 11.00 A.M.	To be intimated later on

Further details can be seen from the web site www.tendersodisha.gov.in

Chief Engineer,

OIPR- 25001/25082/1/26-27/0020

CENTRAL R W CIRCLE, BHUBANESWAR

OFFICE OF SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
AGRA CIRCLE, P.W.D AGRA
Notice inviting E-Tender

Letter No.:- 6135/14M-A.C/2026-27
Date :23.09.2026

1. The Superintending Engineer Agra Circle, U.P.P.W.D. on behalf of Governor of Uttar Pradesh invites the percentage rate bids online from the eligible and approved registered Contractors. As The work Comprises of specialized Building work, hence contractors bidding for this work must be registered in Building work with UP PWD. Bidders are advised to note the minimum qualification criteria specified in Clause 4 of the Instructions to Bidders to qualify for the award of the contract.

2.

Sl No	District	Name of Work	Estimated cost (Rs.in.Lac)	Bid Security (Rs. in Lacs)	Cost of Document (In Rs.)	Time of Completion	Address of Executive Engineer executing the work	Address of Superintending Engineer	Address of Chief Engineer	Category of Contractor
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
1	Mathura	Construction of 06 Multilevel Story Awas of Type-3 at Inspection House Mathura in Distt. Mathura	225.00	18.80	Rs.20000 STC +300.00TC+ 60.00GST = 2360.00	10 Months (including Raining Season)	Executive Engineer, Provincial Division, P.W.D., Mathura	Superintending Engineer, Agra Circle, P.W.D., Agra	Chief Engineer, Agra Zone, P.W.D., Agra	Class A

3. Bid document with detailed terms and conditions will be available online on website <http://etender.up.nic.in> and Prahari (<http://wms.upppwd.gov.in/Prahari>) From 15.10.2026 to 21.10.2026 Bids must be submitted online only at e-tendering portal of <http://etender.up.nic.in> and Prahari App with all documents as per GO No 14/2020/879(1)/23-7/2020/176 (सो)06 Dt 25-08-2020 on or before 12:30 Hours Dt. 21.10.2026. Technical Bid received online will be opened on 21.10.2026 at :1:00 Hours.

4. Original MM-11 forms proof of royalty shall have to be produced at time of every running bill in accordance to Principal Secretary, Directorate of geology & mining under Pradesh Letter No- 2146/86-2019-52(सो)2019 Dt. 30.09.2019, G.O. No- 115(1)/86-2020 dated 15.01.2020 and other relevant Government orders, circulars for all the materials procured from the quarries.

5. The bidders are required to submit Original receipt of Internet Banking of E-tender portal Account as per G.O. No.-742/78-2-2018-42 I.T./2017 T.C., I.T. & Electronics Section-2 Dated-03-12-2018 follows as:

(1) Online Tender Cost towards the cost of bid document (As per Column 6) by Internet Banking of E-tender portal Account (Non Refundable).

(2) Online Bid Security (As per Column 5) in favour of designation of Column 9 by Internet Banking of E-tender portal Account.

6. GO No. 86/2026/649/2026/23-7099/106/2025 Lok Nirman Anubhag-7 Dated 23.05.2026 will be applicable.

(Gulvir Singh)
Executive Engineer
Provincial Division, P.W.D., Mathura

UPID-257226 Dt. 29/09/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

(R.K. Singh)
SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
AGRA CIRCLE, PWD, AGRA

प्रारूप-18
नियम-20 का उपनियम (2)
(अधिनियम की धारा-11 की उपधारा (1) के अन्तर्गत)
उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार / उत्तर प्रदेश सिंचाई विभाग
अधिसूचना संख्या-4776/आठ/ वि०भू०अ०अ०/ बिजनौर / दिनांक: 11.03.2026

भूमि अर्जन, पुनर्वासन और पुनर्व्यवस्थान में उचित प्रतिकर और पारदर्शिता का अधिकार अधिनियम, 2013 की धारा 11 की उपधारा (1) के अधीन उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार / कलेक्टर (समुचित सरकार के उद्देश्य हेतु) राय है, कि उत्तर प्रदेश सिंचाई विभाग द्वारा अधिशारी अभियन्ता पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-6, नजीबाबाद के माध्यम से सार्वजनिक प्रयोजन बिजनौर कोटरा रजवाहा प्रणाली हेतु जनपद बिजनौर परगना व तहसील धामपुर के ग्राम रायपुर मलूक में कुल 1-1952 हेक्टेयर भूमि को आवश्यकता है।

1- उपरोक्त अधिनियम की धारा 6 उपधारा 2 के अनुसार सिंचाई परियोजनाओं के सम्बन्ध में सामाजिक समाधान निर्धारण से सम्बन्धित इस अधिनियम के प्राविधान लागू नहीं होंगे।

2- भू- अर्जन से कोई भी परिवार विस्थापित नहीं हो रहा है।

3- अतः राज्यपाल / समुचित सरकार सार्वजनिक प्रयोजन हेतु निम्नलिखित अनुसूची में उल्लिखित भूमि को सामान्य सूचना हेतु अधिसूचित करने के लिए सहस्र सहमति देते हैं।

जनपद	तहसील	परगना	ग्राम	भूखण्ड सं.	अर्जित किये जाने वाला क्षेत्रफल (हेक्टेयर में)
विजनौर	धामपुर	धामपुर	रायपुर मलूक	49	0-0080
				55	0-0608
				58मि	0-0512
				80	0-0352
				59	0-0352
				79	0-0608
				78	0-1200
				85	0-0544
				222मि	0-1392
				327	0-0736
				349मि	0-1392
				347	0-0384
				344	0-2000
				345	0-0720
				224	0-1072
				योग	1-1952 हे०

4- अधिनियम की धारा-12 के अन्तर्गत निर्दिष्ट एवं प्राविधानित भूमि अधिग्रहण के प्रयोजन हेतु आवश्यक कदम उठाये जाने के लिए तथा भूमि का सर्वेक्षण, किसी भूमि के लिए समतलीकरण, खुदाई करने तथा कार्य के समुचित क्रियान्वयन हेतु सभी आवश्यक क्रियायें करने के लिए राज्यपाल / समुचित सरकार कलेक्टर को प्राधिकृत करने हेतु निर्देश देते हैं।

5- अधिनियम की धारा-15 के अन्तर्गत कोई भी व्यक्ति जिसका हित भूमि में निहित हो अधिसूचना के प्रकाशन के 60 (दिन) के अन्दर अपने क्षेत्र में भूमि अधिग्रहण के विरुद्ध लिखित रूप से कलेक्टर को आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

6- अधिनियम की धारा-11 (4) के अन्तर्गत कोई व्यक्ति अधिसूचना के प्रकाशन की तिथि से भूमि अधिग्रहण की कार्यवाही पूर्ण होने तक कलेक्टर के पूर्व अनुमोदन के बिना प्रारम्भिक अधिसूचना में निर्दिष्ट भूमि का संयवहार यथा विक्रय/क्रय या उस भूमि में कोई भार उत्पन्न नहीं कर सकता है।

टिप्पणी: उक्त भूमि का स्थल नक्शा बिजनौर के कलेक्टर के कार्यालय में देखा जा सकता है।

आज्ञा से,

जिला कलेक्टर बिजनौर

प्रारूप-9 (भाग-ख)
(नियम 17 का उपनियम (3) (4))
प्रमाण- पत्र

अधिग्रहण के प्रयोजन हेतु कलेक्टर का मन्तव्य और औचित्य, कि क्या वह अपेक्षक निकाय द्वारा सार्वजनिक प्रयोजन हेतु अधिग्रहित की जाने वाली भूमि के सम्बन्ध में प्रस्तुत प्रस्ताव के कारण एवं औचित्य से संतुष्ट है।

1- मैंने उत्तर प्रदेश सिंचाई विभाग द्वारा अधिशारी अभियन्ता पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-6, नजीबाबाद अपेक्षक निकाय का नाम) द्वारा प्रस्तुत ग्राम रायपुर मलूक परगना व तहसील धामपुर जिला बिजनौर में 1.952 हे० भूमि के लोक प्रयोजन हेतु अधिग्रहण की जाने वाले प्रस्ताव का सावधानी पूर्वक परीक्षण कर लिया है तथा इस प्रयोजन के लिए संलग्न रिपोर्ट में उल्लिखित विषयवस्तु से मैं संतुष्ट हूँ।

2- मैं संतुष्ट हूँ कि अधिनियम की धारा 11 के अन्तर्गत प्राथमिक अधिसूचना निर्गत करते समय भू-स्वामियों को सुनवाई का आवश्यक अवसर प्रदान किया गया है, मैं संतुष्ट हूँ कि अधिनियम की धारा-15 लागू होगी। भू-स्वामियों को सुनवाई का अवसर दिये जाने के औचित्य से भी संतुष्ट हूँ।

3- परियोजना के प्रयोजन हेतु अपेक्षक निकाय द्वारा प्रस्तुत अधिग्रहण के लिए नितांत न्यूनतम भूमि के प्रस्ताव के औचित्य से मैं संतुष्ट हूँ तथा यह कि कोई अन्य लघु विस्थापन विकल्प उपलब्ध नहीं है तथा जैसा कि उक्त परियोजन परिपूर्ण करती है।

4- अधिनियम की धारा 2 के अन्तर्गत परिभाषित सार्वजनिक प्रयोजन की परिभाषा के उक्त प्रस्ताव से मैं संतुष्ट हूँ।

मेरे विचार से उक्त परियोजना अविलम्ब पूर्ण करने हेतु अधिनियम की धारा 11 (1) के अन्तर्गत अधिसूचना निर्गत किया जाना आवश्यक है। मेरे द्वारा अधिनियम की धारा 11 (1) के अन्तर्गत सार्वजनिक अधिसूचना के प्रकाशन के किये जाने पर प्राप्त किये गये सभी दिशा-निर्देशों का अनुपालन किया जायेगा तथा अपेक्षक निकाय को कच्चे के हस्तांतरण के पूर्व इस अधिनियम के प्रावधानों के अनुसार सभी प्रक्रियाओं का पालन किया जायेगा।

कलेक्टर (भूमि अर्जन) प्रयोजनार्थ बिजनौर।

जिला कलेक्टर का मन्तव्य

(मैं परियोजना के प्रयोजन हेतु अपेक्षक निकाय द्वारा प्रस्तुत अधिग्रहण के लिए नितांत न्यूनतम भूमि के प्रस्ताव के औचित्य से संतुष्ट हूँ तथा यह कि कोई अन्य लघु विस्थापन विकल्प उपलब्ध नहीं है तथा जैसा कि उक्त परियोजना परिपूर्ण करती है) सार्वजनिक परियोजना की परिभाषा वही है जैसा कि अधिनियम की धारा-2 के अन्तर्गत परिभाषित है।

जिला कलेक्टर बिजनौर।

UPID-257225 Dt. 29.09.2026
www.upidadv.gov.in



बिहार राज्य बीज निगम लिमिटेड
(बिहार सरकार का एक उपक्रम)
IS/ISO 9001:2015; IS/ISO 14001:2015;
IS/ISO 37001:2016 प्रमाणित कंपनी
तृतीय तल, कृषि भवन, मीठापुर, पटना – 800001 (बिहार)
दूरभाष: 0612 2547066, वेबसाइट: brbn.bihar.gov.in
ई-मेल: brbn.bih.mail@gmail.com
CIN : U01111BR1977SGC 001294



आवश्यक सूचना

बिहार राज्य बीज निगम के जिला स्तरीय बीज वितरक (डिस्ट्रीब्यूटर) बनने का सुनहरा अवसर

बिहार राज्य के बीज, उर्वरक एवं कीटनाशी अनुज्ञप्ति धारक इच्छुक प्रतिष्ठान / व्यक्ति विभिन्न फसलों के बीज एवं विपणन करने के लिए जिला बीज वितरक (डिस्ट्रीब्यूटर) बनने हेतु ऑनलाईन आमंत्रित आवेदन को पूर्व में अपरिहार्य कारणों से स्थगित किया गया था, जिसे पुनः ऑनलाईन आवेदन की प्रक्रिया को शुरू कर दिया गया है। इससे संबंधित सूचना वेबसाइट पर अपलोड कर दिया गया है।

इच्छुक प्रतिष्ठान/ व्यक्ति बिहार राज्य बीज निगम लि० के वेबसाइट www.brbn.bihar.gov.in पर दिये गये लिंक पर जाकर चेक लिस्ट के अनुसार वांछित कागजातों के साथ ऑनलाईन (Online) आवेदन कर सकते हैं।

प्रबंध निदेशक
बिहार राज्य बीज निगम लि०

PR- 012733 (B & C) 2026-27

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।



Punjab State Power Corporation Ltd.
(Regd. office PSFB Head Office The Mall Patiala)
Corporate Identification Number (CIN) : U40109PB2018SGC033813
website:-www.pspcl.in | (Contact No 96461-01204)

Tender Inquiry No. 23/Dy. CE/DS/Circle Sangrur/2026-27 Date: 29-09-2026
Deputy Chief Engineer, DS Circle, Sangrur invites e-tender for the execution of works comprising only labour component for Replacement of low-lying PVC at road crossings with 4-core cables and re-locations of MCBs, to maintain line symmetry and proper ground clearance, replacement of existing 8-meter PCC poles with 9-meter PCC poles, replacement of 1/1 MCB near road crossings with 4/1 MCB to reduce congestion of PVC cables, Re-sagging of LT/HT Lines, Relocation of poles which are causing hindrance to public in general, Replacement of multiple 4-core road crossing cables with single higher size 4-core cables, Providing distribution boxes for service cables on poles, Replacement of aged/deteriorated 4-Core LT cables, Rerouting of low-lying PVC lines and any other work related to ensuring statutory ground clearance to be executed on labour rates during the year 2026-27 under DS Sub-Division City Dirba under DS Division Dirba Under DS Circle Sangrur.
For detailed NIT & tender Specification please refer to <http://eproc-punjab.gov.in> from 29-09-2026 from 12:00 PM onwards.
Note:- Corrigendum and amendments, if any will be published online at <http://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

No. 5704/PB
C935/26



State Selection Board
Department of Higher Education
Govt. of Odisha
Bhubaneswar

11001/347/2627
No. SSBBSR-EXAM-DEV-0012-2026/1542/Dated:29.09.2026
Notice
Correction in Particulars in the Online Application Form for Recruitment to the post of for recruitment to the post of junior assistants in C.H.S.E.(O) (School and Mass Education Department), Govt. of Odisha wrt Advertisement No. 03/2026 dated 29.06.2026.
Basing on the large number of representations/grievances from candidates, requesting for correction in the online application form, it is hereby informed all concerned to **edit or doing correction in the online application form w.e.f. 03.10.2026 (11:00 A.M.) to 09.10.2026 (11:59 P.M.)**.
After the closure of the correction window, no further request for any correction or modification in the online application form shall be entertained under any circumstances.
Candidates are advised to visit the official website of the SSB to edit/correction in their online application form (Please see **Annexure-1** in the official Website of SSB.)

Sd/-
Secretary

State Selection Board

OIPR-11001/11015/1/26-27/0010



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR. NO.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP/ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT/ EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP/AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION GURUGRAM	REPLACEMENT OF WATER SUPPLY LINE OF C-1 AND C-2 BLOCK PALAM VIHAR IN WARD NO. 4, DIVISION 3A UNDER MCG + 1 WORKS	28.09.2026 12.10.2026	6.73.94.979/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9821395211 ec5@mcg.gov.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in **No.- 49773/HRY**

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS REASI
“LOOKOUT NOTICE”

As requested by SHO P/S Reasi vide letter No. 1212/5-1/PSR dated 28.09.2026 that one person namely Gulshan Kumar S/O Late Madan Lal R/O Sirla Bhaga Tehsil & District Reasi was lodged a written application at P/S Reasi that his brother namely Koushal Kumar age 24 yrs who was missing on 27.09.2026 at 0900 hrs from his home i.e. Sirla Bhaga Tehsil & District Reasi UT of J&K. On this, instant a missing report has been registered vide DDR No. 10 dated 28.09.2026 in Police Station, Reasi, District Reasi, J&K UT. The description roll of missing child is as under: -

S. No	DDR No., dt. & P/S.	Description of missing person	Photograph of missing person
01.	DDR No. 10 dated 28.09.2026 of Police Station, Reasi	Name : Koushal Kumar S/O : Lt. Madan Lal Age : About 24 Yrs Height : 5'6" Complexion : Fair Body build : Normal Face : Round Wearing : Brown-Shirt, Black trouser & Chapal.	

As such, please have a sharp lookout if traced out in your respective Police units/jurisdictions, resembling with above description roll of said missing person immediate information may kindly be sent to the Web site E-mail ID sspreasi@jkpolice.gov.in, Ph. No. 01991244663, fax No. 01991245291, Ph. No. 01991244956 (PCR Reasi) or P/S Reasi No. 01991244144.

Sd/-
Mukund Tibrewal-IPS
Sr. Superintendent of Police,
Reasi.

No:- Rdr/31/2026/64636-66
Dated:28.09.2026
DIP/J-11414/26 - DATE 29 SEP 2026



GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, HISAR	SPECIAL REPAIR OF SUB TEHSIL NARNAUND (FIRST FLOOR) TO BE CONVERTED INTO JUDICIAL COURTS AT NARNAUND IN HANSI DISTT. (PDG. E.I. INTERNAL AND VARIOUS ELECTRICAL SERVICES ONLY	25.09.2026 05.10.2026	26.14 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	1662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
2	PWD B&R, HISAR	PROVIDING INDEPENDENT HOT LINE FEEDER FOR CHADHOSHINGHANA IN DISTT. SIRSA.	25.09.2026 02.10.2026	22.29 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
3	PWD B&R, ROHTAK	BEAUTIFICATION OF DH ROHTAK (PROVIDING 3 KVA ONLINE UPS FOR EXISTING TOKEN SYSTEM ONLY) (BALANCE WORKS) + 4 WORKS	25.09.2026 02.10.2026	27.56 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9034929655 pwd-eeed-rohtak1@gmail.com
4	FOREST DEPARTMENT, SIRSA	RENOVATION TO DFO EXISTING OFFICE AT SIRSA	CLOSING DATE 05.10.2026	4.98 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416067122 forest_srsa@yahoo.com
5	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE, BHIWANI	VERTICAL DRAINAGE PROJECT VILLAGE - BARS/ (DURJANPUR/MILAKPUR, BLOCK - BAWANI KHERA, DISTRICT-BHIWANI)	25.09.2026 12.10.2026	554.68 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9215910040 ascobhiwani@gmail.com
6	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE, BHIWANI	WATER STORAGE PUCCA TANK AT SHREE GOPAL GAUSHALA , PILANI ROAD LOHARU, DISTT- BHIWANI + 1 WORKS	25.09.2026 05.10.2026	24.66 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9215910040 ascobhiwani@gmail.com
7	ZILA PARISHAD, FATEHABAD	MAMUPUR - CONSTRUCTION OF PHC IN VILLAGE MAMUPUR BLOCK TOHANA DISTRICT FATEHABAD ZP	25.09.2026 09.10.2026	403.56 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01667230855 xenzpfatehabad@gmail.com
8	ZILA PARISHAD, KATHAL	JAKHOULI KAMAN CONSTRUCTION OF PHC BUILDING AT VILLAGE JAKHOULI KAMAN	25.09.2026 09.10.2026	368.73 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466629211 abhisheknaixen@gmail.com
9	KALPANA CHAWLA GOVT MEDICAL COLLEGE KARNAL	E-TENDER FOR MEDICAL INSTRUMENT (K FILES OF DIFFERENT SIZE, H FILES OF DIFFERENT SIZE, ROTARY FILE OF DIFFERENT SIZE, C PLUS FILES, DIAMOND BUR OF DIFFERENT SIZE AND OTHER VARIOUS INSTRUMENT OF DENTISTRY DEPARTMENT) AT KCGMC, KARNAL.	05.10.2026 13.10.2026	EMD 10000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9992132471 director.kgcghc-hry@gov.in
10	HARYANA INSTITUTE OF PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION (HIPA), GURUGRAM	SUPPLY OF STATIONARY AND OTHER ITEMS	21.09.2026 09.10.2026	EMD 50000	https://hipaco.in	9999330686 rehkad@hipa.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in **No. 49784/HRY**



Public Health Engineering Department
EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
EOI NOTICE NO.-101/2026-27

EOI for Design, Development, Implementation & monitoring of an Integrated IoT-Based Water Supply Schemes Monitoring and Control Platformand ensuring the time scheduling of motor run through IOT, which needs to be hosted at State Data Centre along with supply of IoT Devices based on “oneM2M” standard (National Standard) and 5-Year Operation & Maintenance (O&M). The system is to be installed in approximately 30000 schemes. For this the interested bidders may raise their proposal through e-mail-datacentre_phed@yahoo.co.in by 09/10/2026. The interested bidder will be intimated regarding the date & time of presentation on mentioned subject individually by the department through e-mail.

Engineer-in-Chief-Cum Special Secretary (HQ),
PHED Vishweshwariyaiya Bhawan Campus,
Bailey Road Patna-800015

PR- 012729 (PHED) 2026-27

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।

बिहार सरकार

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय
लोक स्वास्थ्य प्रमण्डल, बिहारशरीफ
शुद्धि पत्र

NIT-10/226-27 O&M PHED के द्वारा आमंत्रित निविदा जिसका PR-012149 (PHED) 2026-27 के माध्यम से दैनिक जागरण एवं अन्य समाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित निविदा जिसका कार्य का नाम— **Comprehensive Extended operation & Maintainance of MVS Silao Phase-1 Pipe Water Supply Scheme after completion of first 5 Years O&M Period including operator Wages excluded electricity for the period of date of Agreement of next five year. Under P.H. Division, Biharsharif Nalanda for the year 2026-27** के स्थान पर टंकण मूल वरा **Comprehensive Extended operation & maintainance of MVS Silo Phase -1 Pipe Water Supply Scheme** after completion of first 5 Years O&M Period including Operator wages for the Period dated 01-12-2025 to 30-11-2030 Under P.H. Division, Biharsharif, Nalanda for the year 2026-27 अंकित हो गया है।, जिसे इस दस तक शंसोधित समझा जाए।

कार्यपालक अभियंता

लोक स्वास्थ्य प्रमण्डल, बिहारशरीफ

PR. No. 012773 (PHED) 2026-27
नशामुक्त हो जाए बिहार, सुरक्षित रहे घर परिवार।

प्रारूप-18
नियम-20 का उपनियम (2)
(अधिनियम की धारा-11 की उपधारा (1) के अन्तर्गत)
उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार उत्तर प्रदेश सिंचाई विभाग
अधिसूचना संख्या-4773/आठ/ वि०भू०अ०अ०/ बिजनौर / दिनांक: 11.03.2026

भूमि अर्जन, पुनर्वासन और पुनर्व्यवस्थान में उचित प्रतिकर और पारदर्शिता का अधिकार अधिनियम, 2013 की धारा 11 की उपधारा (1) के अधीन उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार / कलेक्टर (समुचित सरकार के उद्देश्य हेतु) राय है, कि उत्तर प्रदेश सिंचाई विभाग द्वारा अधिशारी अभियन्ता पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-6, नजीबाबाद के माध्यम से सार्वजनिक प्रयोजन बिजनौर कोटरा रजवाहा प्रणाली हेतु जनपद बिजनौर परगना व तहसील धामपुर के ग्राम चकराजमल में कुल 0-8310 हेक्टेयर भूमि की आवश्यकता है।

1- उपरोक्त अधिनियम की धारा 6 उपधारा 2 के अनुसार सिंचाई परियोजनाओं के सम्बन्ध में सामाजिक समाधान निर्धारण से सम्बन्धित इस अधिनियम के प्राविधान लागू नहीं होंगे।

2- भू- अर्जन से कोई भी परिवार विस्थापित नहीं हो रहा है।

3- अतः राज्यपाल / समुचित सरकार सार्वजनिक प्रयोजन हेतु निम्नलिखित अनुसूची में उल्लिखित भूमि को सामान्य सूचना हेतु अधिसूचित करने के लिए सहस्र सहमति देते हैं।

जनपद	तहसील	परगना	ग्राम	भूखण्ड सं.	अर्जित किये जाने वाला क्षेत्रफल (हेक्टेयर में)
1	2	3	4	5	6
विजनौर	धामपुर	धामपुर	चकराजमल	793अ, 779व	0-2100
				816	0-2220
				860अ, 860व	0-1100
				868 मि	0-2890
				योग	0-8310 हे०

4- अधिनियम की धारा-12 के अन्तर्गत निर्दिष्ट एवं प्राविधानित भूमि अधिग्रहण के प्रयोजन हेतु आवश्यक कदम उठाये जाने के लिए तथा भूमि का सर्वेक्षण, किसी भूमि के लिए समतलीकरण, खुदाई करने तथा कार्य के समुचित क्रियान्वयन हेतु सभी आवश्यक क्रियायें करने के लिए राज्यपाल / समुचित सरकार कलेक्टर को प्राधिकृत करने हेतु निर्देश देते हैं।

5- अधिनियम की धारा-15 के अन्तर्गत कोई भी व्यक्ति जिसका हित भूमि में निहित हो अधिसूचना के प्रकाशन के 60 (दिन) के अन्दर अपने क्षेत्र में भूमि अधिग्रहण के विरुद्ध लिखित रूप से कलेक्टर को आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

6- अधिनियम की धारा-11 (4) के अन्तर्गत कोई व्यक्ति अधिसूचना के प्रकाशन की तिथि से भूमि अधिग्रहण की कार्यवाही पूर्ण होने तक कलेक्टर के पूर्व अनुमोदन के बिना प्रारम्भिक अधिसूचना में निर्दिष्ट भूमि का संयवहार यथा विक्रय/क्रय या उस भूमि में कोई भार उत्पन्न नहीं कर सकता है।

टिप्पणी: उक्त भूमि का स्थल नक्शा बिजनौर के कलेक्टर के कार्यालय में देखा जा सकता है।

आज्ञा से,

जिलाकलेक्टर बिजनौर

प्रारूप-9 (भाग-ख)
(नियम 17 का उपनियम (3) (4))
प्रमाण- पत्र

अधिग्रहण के प्रयोजन हेतु कलेक्टर का मन्तव्य और औचित्य, कि क्या वह अपेक्षक निकाय द्वारा सार्वजनिक प्रयोजन हेतु अधिग्रहित की जाने वाली भूमि के सम्बन्ध में प्रस्तुत प्रस्ताव के कारण एवं औचित्य से संतुष्ट है।

1- मैंने उत्तर प्रदेश सिंचाई विभाग द्वारा अधिशारी अभियन्ता पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-6, नजीबाबाद अपेक्षक निकाय का नाम) द्वारा प्रस्तुत ग्राम चकराजमल परगना व तहसील धामपुर जिला बिजनौर में 0.8310 हे० भूमि के लोक प्रयोजन हेतु अधिग्रहण की जाने वाले प्रस्ताव का सावधानी पूर्वक परीक्षण कर लिया है तथा इस प्रयोजन के लिए संलग्न रिपोर्ट में उल्लिखित विषयवस्तु से मैं संतुष्ट हूँ।

2- मैं संतुष्ट हूँ कि अधिनियम की धारा 11 के अन्तर्गत प्राथमिक अधिसूचना निर्गत करते समय भू-स्वामियों को सुनवाई का आवश्यक अवसर प्रदान किया गया है, मैं संतुष्ट हूँ कि अधिन

An initiative by **RED**
Read, Engage, Deliver.

STATES OF HOPE

Rajasthan

RAJASTHAN REFINERY

9 MMTPA

Refinery Capacity and
29 processing units

₹79,000 cr+

Greenfield Integrated
Refinery

India's first

Integrated Refinery cum
Petrochemical Complex

Products

Petrol & Diesel (BS-VI
Standards) and LPG

1.35 lakh +

Direct and Indirect
Employment

Prime Minister Narendra Modi interacting with project engineers and workers during his visit to inaugurate India's first greenfield integrated refinery-cum-petrochemical complex at Pachpadra in Balotra district, Rajasthan.

Rajasthan Refinery: From Salt Fields to India's Energy Future

From historic salt fields to a world-class refinery, Pachpadra is emerging as a powerful symbol of Rajasthan's industrial transformation, innovation and growth.

Pachpadra has acquired a new identity on the industrial map of modern India. The land once recognised solely for its sparkling white salt crystals is today illuminated by the promise of energy, cutting-edge technology and industrial excellence. This transformation is a powerful reminder that when the vision for development is clear, tradition and modernity can advance together. Pachpadra's evolution from a historic salt-producing region into a world-class energy and petrochemical hub reflects India's determination to build a future that honours its heritage while embracing innovation and sustainable industrial growth.

There are moments in history that transcend being mere events and become the foundation of an era of transformation. 4 July 2026 was one such historic day for Rajasthan when Prime Minister Narendra Modi dedicated the nation's first Greenfield Integrated Refinery-cum-Petrochemical Complex to the country at Pachpadra in Balotra district.

Constructed with an investment of approximately Rs 79,459 crore, the HPCL Rajasthan Refinery and Petrochemical Complex is one of India's most significant energy infrastructure projects. This landmark project is not only a milestone for Rajasthan but also a defining chapter in India's journey towards energy security. With a refining capacity of 9 MMTPA (Million Metric Tonnes Per Annum) and a petrochemical produc-

tion capacity of 2.4 MMTPA, the complex ranks among the world's most advanced integrated refineries.

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi dedicated the refinery to the nation, it was far more than a ceremonial event. It stood as a tangible outcome of sustained leadership, continuous monitoring, effective inter-departmental coordination, and timely execution, reflecting the State Government's commitment to delivering one of India's most significant energy infrastructure projects.

It is to be mentioned that Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma personally took charge of monitoring the refinery's progress. Through continuous high-level review meetings and regular site inspections, he infused fresh momentum into the administrative machinery. Decision-making gathered pace, coordination among various departments improved significantly, and projects that had been under execution for years began moving swiftly towards completion.

The project is a joint venture in which HPCL holds a 74 per cent stake, while the Government of Rajasthan holds the remaining 26 per cent. This partnership is a powerful embodiment of the spirit of cooperative federalism, demonstrating how the Central and State Governments can work together to realise a project of national importance.

From a technological perspective, this is one of the most advanced industrial projects in the country. The refinery produces

“

This refinery will prove to be the 'lifeline of prosperity' for Marwar and the whole of Rajasthan, driving the State's economic transformation and opening new avenues of employment for its youth."

BHAJAN LAL SHARMA
Chief Minister of Rajasthan

fuels that are fully compliant with BS-VI emission standards, ensuring cleaner and more environmentally sustainable energy.

With a Nelson Complexity Index (NCI) of 17.0, the refinery ranks among the most sophisticated and operationally flexible refineries in India. Its advanced configuration enables it to process a wide range of crude oils efficiently while maximising the production of high-value petroleum products, placing it at the forefront of modern refining technology.

This remarkable transformation stands as a testament to the fact that when the direction of development is clear and purposeful, tradition and modernity can progress hand in hand. Pachpadra's journey from a historic salt-producing region to a hub of world-class energy infrastructure reflects the evolving aspirations of a self-reliant and rapidly advancing India.

The true value of any major industrial project is measured not merely by its production capacity, but by the lasting social and economic impact it creates. Viewed from

this perspective, the Pachpadra Refinery and Petrochemical Complex assumes exceptional significance.

The project is expected to generate thousands of direct and indirect employment opportunities, providing a substantial boost to the regional economy. It will also accelerate the growth of petrochemical-based industries while stimulating economic activity across a wide range of sectors, including transport, logistics, housing, education, healthcare, trade and services. At the local level, it is expected to strengthen skill development, encourage entrepreneurship and attract fresh investment, creating a vibrant industrial ecosystem.

The impact will be particularly transformative for western Rajasthan. Once regarded primarily as a desert region with limited economic opportunities, it is now emerg-

ing as a major destination for industrial investment and manufacturing. This transformation extends well beyond economic growth. It promises to enhance the quality of life, create sustainable livelihoods and open new avenues of opportunity for future generations, ushering in a new era of prosperity and inclusive development for the region.

Pachpadra's remarkable achievement stands as a symbol of a transforming Rajasthan, that has demonstrated the vision and determination to convert the challenges of the desert into opportunities for growth and prosperity. It is the outcome of a collective endeavour in which visionary governance of the double engine government, technological excellence, strategic investment and active public participation have come together to script a new chapter in the State's development.

More than an industrial success, the project represents Rajasthan's growing confidence and its emergence as a key contributor to India's economic and industrial progress. It exemplifies how a shared vision, backed by effective execution and collaborative effort, can deliver transformative outcomes of lasting national significance. As a new chapter of development was being written on the sun-scorched landscape of western Rajasthan on 4 July, the scenes witnessed on the stage were only part of the story. Equally significant was the unseen journey of vision, perseverance and meticulous planning that had made this historic moment possible.

This was not merely the inauguration of a refinery, but it was a reaffirmation of the belief that no challenge is insurmountable. When leadership is unwavering, intent is clear and efforts are sustained, the momentum of development never falters. The occasion stood as a powerful testament to the fact that determination, effective governance and unwavering commitment can transform even the most ambitious aspirations into reality.



STATES OF HOPE: RAJASTHAN

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Youth Power – Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma with young workforce during an event in Jaipur.

1.22 lakh

Government posts currently under recruitment

1.25 lakh

Posts included in the 2026 recruitment calendar.

1.88 lakh+

Young people provided with employment opportunities through the first 10 state-level fairs.

8,780

Startups registered under the Rajasthan Startup Programme.

₹34 crore

Total funding provided through the iStart Fund.

1,062

Startups that received funding through the iStart Fund



Empowering youth through transparent recruitment, investment, skill development

Rajasthan is empowering its youth through transparent recruitment, skills, entrepreneurship and private-sector opportunities, creating pathways to dignified employment, self-reliance and growth.

The youth are the greatest asset in building a developed Rajasthan. When they are provided with transparent opportunities, quality skills, modern technology, investment and a supportive environment for entrepreneurship, they do more than building their own future. They become active drivers of the state's economic growth, social prosperity and the vision of a developed India.

The state government, under the leadership of Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma, is undertaking comprehensive and result-oriented initiatives in employment, skill development, entrepreneurship and innovation to promote the holistic development of young people.

To strengthen the confidence of millions of young people aspiring to join government services, the state government has introduced wide-ranging reforms in recruitment processes. The introduction of a recruitment calendar, efforts to fill vacant posts within a defined timeframe and technology-enabled transparent systems have made the recruitment process more reliable and effective.

As a result of these efforts, recruitment to around 1.22 lakh posts is currently under way, while a recruitment calendar for 1.25 lakh posts for 2026 has also been issued. These are not merely administrative achievements; they represent important steps towards fulfilling the aspirations of millions of young people and their families. A transparent and time-bound recruitment system has strengthened the belief among young people that their merit and hard work will receive a fair opportunity.

The state government's employment-focused efforts received fresh momentum when Prime Minister Narendra Modi distributed appointment letters to around 54,000 newly selected young people at an



We want the youth of Rajasthan not only to seek employment but also to become employment creators. To achieve this, the government is promoting entrepreneurship and self-employment.”

BHAJAN LAL SHARMA
Chief Minister of Rajasthan

event held in Pachpadra in Balotra district. The young recruits were selected for various departments, including Education, Energy, Agriculture, Panchayati Raj, Home, Transport, Higher Education, and Information Technology and Communications.

These appointment letters were not merely proof of entry into government service; they symbolised the beginning of a brighter future and a new journey towards self-reliance.

On the occasion, the Prime Minister highlighted the crucial role of young people in building a developed India and called upon them to be at forefront of nation-building.

The Rajasthan Government has a clear vision of ensuring that every young person in the state has access to dignified employment and the opportunity to become econ-



Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma taking selfie with Gen Z at Sapnon ki Udaan programme held at CMR on July 28, 2026



gible young people are getting direct access to leading private-sector companies. While industries gain access to trained and qualified human resources, young people get opportunities to secure employment without intermediaries.

More than 24 employment camps held across the state have provided employment to thousands of young people in the private sector. Their success demonstrates that when the government, industry and youth come together on a common platform, the potential for employment generation can be significantly expanded. Employment fairs and job camps have therefore emerged as an important instrument of the state's employment-oriented policy.

The positive impact of this initiative is evident from the fact that the ten state-level employment fairs organised so far have provided employment opportunities to more than 1.88 lakh young people. These events have not only helped thousands of young people secure dignified employment in the private sector but have also played an important role in providing industries with a pool of qualified human resources.

The 9th State-Level Employment Fair, held on 2 July 2026, marked another significant milestone in providing employment opportunities in the private sector. The fair provided employment opportunities to 53,977 candidates, underlining the effectiveness of the state government's employment-oriented policies.

Young people from almost every district of Rajasthan benefited from the fair. Employment opportunities were provided to 5,675 candidates in Jaipur, 2,505 in Sikar, 2,405 in Dausa, 2,051 in Nagaur, 2,037 in Alwar and 1,971 in Jodhpur. Similarly, candidates from Hanumangarh (1,748), Bharatpur (1,730), Bikaner (1,728), Dungarpur (1,709), Jhunjhunu (1,695), Udaipur (1,679) and Tonk (1,661), among other districts, also benefited from the initiative.

These figures clearly demonstrate that the benefits of employment fairs are no longer confined to major cities. Young people in smaller towns, district headquarters and rural areas are also gaining access to employment opportunities. Access to jobs closer to home is enabling young people to build a better future while remaining close to their families.

The employment fairs have also strengthened coordination between industry and young jobseekers, giving fresh momentum to a new culture of employment generation across the state.

omically empowered. With this objective, employment opportunities in the private sector are being expanded alongside recruitment to government services.

Promotion of industrial investment, expansion of the services sector, development of tourism and the establishment of technology-driven industries are creating new employment opportunities across the state.

Education, textiles, tourism, mining, solar energy, information technology and the services sector are emerging as major employment hubs in Rajasthan. Growing investment in these sectors is providing local young people with better employment opportunities within the state. This is not only giving fresh impetus to economic activity but also strengthening the prospects of reducing migration to other states in search of employment.

Employment fairs and job camps across the state have emerged as an effective bridge between industry and young jobseekers. Through these initiatives, eli-

STATES OF HOPE: RAJASTHAN

Powering ahead towards a green future

The Bhajan Lal Sharma-led government has placed energy generation at the forefront of its development agenda, recognising its critical role in driving the state's economic growth.

Rajasthan is moving towards self-reliance in power generation through green energy under the farsighted and visionary leadership of Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma.

The state ranks first in Solar Power generation, second in Renewable Energy generation and third in Rooftop Solar installations in the country. It is also one of the leading states in the implementation of the Pradhan Mantri KUSUM Yojana.

The state government has accorded high priority to green energy in its policies and programmes. The Bhajan Lal Sharma-led government has placed energy generation at the forefront of its development agenda, recognising its critical role in driving the state's economic growth. For the first time, a state government has also placed significant emphasis on the participation of general public in power generation.

To accelerate energy generation in the state, the government has implemented the Rajasthan Integrated Clean Energy Policy-2024, which sets an ambitious target of developing 115 GW of renewable energy generation capacity and 10 GW of energy storage capacity by 2030. To achieve this target, the policy provides various incentives and provisions for renewable energy, biofuel, energy storage and green hydrogen projects.

Under the Pradhan Mantri KUSUM Yojana, solar energy projects with a total capacity of 4,836 MW have been established through feeder-level solarisation under Components A and C. Of this, 4,700 MW of capacity has been created in the last two and a half years.

As a result of these initiatives, the state's installed renewable energy capacity has reached 49,492 MW, including 43,317 MW of solar energy capacity. During the tenure of the present government, solar energy capacity has increased by an unprecedented 25,990 MW. With these concerted efforts, Rajasthan has emerged as the leading state in solar energy generation and ranks second in renewable energy generation in the country.

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Under the Pradhan Mantri KUSUM Yojana, solar energy projects with a total capacity of 4,836 MW have been established through feeder-level solarisation under Components A and C. Of this, 4,700 MW of capacity has been created in the last two and a half years.



CM Bhajan Lal Sharma at signing of the Framework for Action – Advanced Clean Energy-Driven Sustainable Development with International Solar Alliance (ISA) at the CMR on July 8, 2026, by Energy Secretary Arti Dogra and DG of ISA Ashish Khanna.

jana, solar energy projects with a total capacity of 4,836 MW have been established through feeder-level solarisation under Components A and C. Of this, 4,700 MW of capacity has been created in the last two and a half years. The scheme is playing an important role in ensuring a reliable supply of electricity to farmers for agricultural activities. Through the scheme, 2,128 solar energy plants have been established in villages and hamlets across the state, enabling farmers to become energy producers.

Rajasthan Discoms are developing 688 MWh of battery energy storage capacity to utilise surplus solar energy generated from plants established under the KUSUM Yojana and rooftop solar installations, thereby ensuring power supply during evening peak hours and maintain-

ing grid and voltage stability. Jaipur, Jodhpur and Ajmer Discoms have initiated work on this pilot project. This will help reduce the burden of purchasing expensive electricity and minimise transmission losses.

More than 2.83 lakh rooftop solar plants across the domestic, non-domestic and industrial categories had been installed in the state till May this year, taking the total rooftop solar capacity to more than 3,134 MW. Public interest in solar energy has increased significantly following the implementation of the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana. In just two years, more than 2.65 lakh rooftop solar plants have been installed on residential properties, with the total capacity reaching 1,022 MW.

The state government is committed to providing rooftop solar systems to do-

mestic consumers with low electricity consumption without imposing any financial burden on them. For this purpose, the utility-led agreement model under the PM Surya Ghar Yojana will soon be introduced. Jaipur, Jodhpur and Ajmer Discoms have decided to connect one lakh domestic consumers each in the first phase. Under the initiative, eligible registered consumers will be provided with free installation of 1.1 kW rooftop solar plants at their homes. Rooftop solar generation has helped reduce consumers' electricity bills while also enabling them to make a significant contribution to the state's energy security.

Government buildings are also being brought under the ambit of rooftop solar energy. At present, rooftop solar plants with a combined capacity of 112 MW have been installed on around 2,200 govern-

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2nd in the country in Renewable Energy Generation

3rd in the country in Rooftop Solar Installations

2,450 MW Solar Park being developed at Pugal, Bikaner

6,400 MWh Energy storage system planned in Pugal Solar Park

6,000 MWh Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) under development through Rajasthan Rajya Vidyut Utpadan Nigam Limited

PM-KUSUM – Rajasthan is among the leading states implementing the scheme

ment buildings, substantially reducing the electricity bills of government offices.

The Rajasthan Renewable Energy Corporation is developing a 2,450 MW solar park at Pugal in Bikaner district, along with an energy storage system of 6,400 MWh. Tenders for the project have already been issued. The solar energy generated by projects established in the park will be utilised by the state's Distribution Corporations (Discoms), thereby strengthening grid management.

Similarly, work is in progress on a 6,000 MWh Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) through the Rajasthan Rajya Vidyut Utpadan Nigam Limited. These initiatives will further strengthen Rajasthan's renewable energy infrastructure and support the state's transition towards a cleaner, more secure and sustainable energy future.

Rajasthan launches first PM e-Bus Sewa services

The Rajasthan Government has taken a significant step towards greener urban mobility with the launch of its first electric bus services, aimed at reducing pollution and promoting clean, safe and sustainable public transport across the state.

Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma recently flagged off 29 electric buses from Amar Jawan Jyoti in Jaipur for the Jaipur City Transport Services Limited (JCTSL), while 18 buses were launched in Bhilwara through video conference under the Prime Minister's e-Bus Sewa scheme.

The Chief Minister said the introduction of electric buses would help promote clean, safe and convenient public transport while reducing pollution in urban areas.

The Prime Minister's e-Bus Sewa scheme was launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in August 2023 to promote electric mobility in urban transport. The Centre under the scheme is providing assistance to state governments for the construction of depots, electrical infrastructure and bus operations.

Sharma inspected one of the newly launched buses after performing a ceremonial puja. He was briefed on its modern facilities, including panic buttons, air conditioning and CCTV cameras. He also interacted with the driver and conductor before travelling by electric bus from Amar Jawan Jyoti to the State Hangar after purchasing a ticket.

Rajasthan has been allocated electric buses for eight cities including Jaipur, Jodhpur, Udaipur, Kota, Bikaner, Bhil-

“Under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, the double-engine government is working rapidly across every area of public welfare, fulfilling its commitments and promises to the people.”

BHAJAN LAL SHARMA
Chief Minister of Rajasthan

wara, Alwar and Ajmer. The Centre has approved 675 electric buses for these cities, while another 475 buses have also been approved, taking the total allocation for the state to 1,150 electric buses.

Sharma said the first phase would see 675 electric buses become operational by Diwali.

He said the buses, equipped with modern technology, would provide a safe, comfortable and affordable mode of transport, particularly for women, students, senior citizens and persons with



disabilities. CCTV cameras installed in the buses would also help strengthen passenger safety, particularly for women.

The Chief Minister said the state government was also working to introduce 555 electric buses for urban transport and

50 double-decker electric buses for tourists. Work on implementing the plans is being accelerated, he added.

Describing the initiative as an important step towards achieving the vision of Viksit Rajasthan 2047, Sharma said the

state's "double-engine" government had accelerated development over the past two and a half years across sectors including water, power, industry and transport.

Highlighting the government's environmental initiatives, Sharma said that

around 20 crore saplings had been planted so far under the Hariyalo Rajasthan campaign. He urged people to participate in plantation drives under both the Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam and Hariyalo Rajasthan campaigns.

STATES OF HOPE: RAJASTHAN

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ARTISTIC IMPRESSION



JAIPUR METRO PHASE II:
Strengthening the
Future of Transport

Jaipur Metro Phase II is set to transform urban mobility, connecting key destinations, reducing congestion and bringing faster, safer public transport closer to residents.

Another milestone has been added to Jaipur's development journey with the launch of Jaipur Metro Phase II. Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the foundation stone for the Rs 13,037 crore, 41-kilometre Jaipur Metro Phase II project on 4 July 2026 from Pachpadra in Balotra district. The second phase will comprise 36 stations stretching from Prahladpura to Todi Mod.

The Phase II corridor will provide seamless connectivity to key destinations, including Sitapura Industrial Area, VKI, Jaipur International Airport, Tonk Road, SMS Hospital and Stadium, the Collectorate, Jaipur Railway Station, Ambabari and Vidhyadhar Nagar. The project also includes an underground Metro station in the airport area, ensuring an integrated and continuous Metro network across the city.

One of the most remarkable and technologically advanced features of Jaipur Metro Phase II is that the alignment near Sanganer has been specially designed keeping in mind the safety requirements of aircraft landing and take-off operations. An underground metro station will be constructed within the Jaipur International Airport premises. This means that, on the lines of Delhi, people in Jaipur will also be able to travel directly to the airport by metro and step straight into the terminal building without having to navigate any external road traffic.

Over the past decade, cities across the country have realised that the growth of a modern metropolis cannot be sustained through wider roads and flyovers alone. As cities expand, the number of private vehicles increases while road space remains limited. The only sustainable solution is a strong, reliable and time-bound public transport system.

Jaipur has been facing similar challenges as its population continues to grow, new residential colonies develop rapidly, and lakhs of people visit the city every day for tourism, business and education. The increasing number of vehicles has led to traffic congestion, rising pollution and longer travel times. In such a scenario, the Metro is not merely a mode of transport; it has the potential to transform and organise urban mobility across the city.

The 41-kilometre Metro Phase II corridor will significantly strengthen Jaipur's modern, fast, safe and environmentally friendly public transport network by connecting several key parts of the city. For a rapidly expanding city like Jaipur, it is much more than a railway line as it is a

strong foundation for the city's future transport system. The project will not only ease traffic congestion but also reduce travel time and provide residents with more convenient and dependable public transport.

With the completion of Phase II, Jaipur's public transport system is set to undergo a major transformation. Prominent residential, commercial and institutional areas will be seamlessly connected, while city buses, mini-buses, e-rickshaws and other modes of public transport will be better integrated to provide smooth last-mile connectivity for commuters.

In addition, under Jaipur Metro Phase II, plans will be prepared to operate feeder bus services connecting nearby towns, including Chaksu and Chomu, with the nearest Metro stations at Prahladpura and Todi Mod.

Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma performed the ceremonial Bhoomi Pujan and Shila Pujan for Jaipur Metro Phase II at the Metro Depot in Sitapura on 22 July 2026. He also inaugurated the piling works by performing a ritual worship of the piling rig machine. On the occasion, he reviewed the model of the nearly 41-kilometre-long Metro Phase II corridor.

The Chief Minister interacted with passengers while travelling by Metro from Mansarovar to Chhoti Chaupar to know their travel experiences. Passengers expressed their eagerness for the completion of the Prahladpura-Todi Mod Metro corridor, saying that it would provide convenient, affordable and efficient public transport to a larger section of Jaipur's residents.

During the journey, the Chief Minister viewed from the Metro cockpit the site of the proposed interchange station at Khasa Kothi, which will be developed under Phase II.

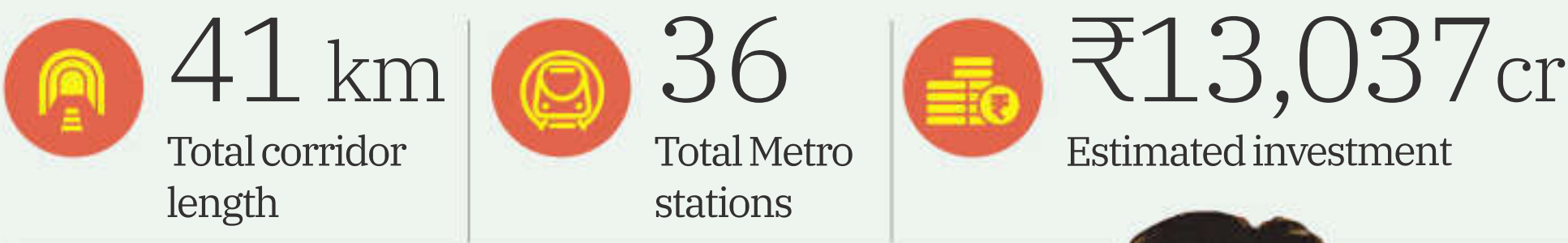
The proposed Metro Phase II will further expand Jaipur's Metro network in the north-south direction. Following approval by the Union Cabinet, Jaipur Metro Rail Corporation Limited (JMRL) has issued a Letter of Acceptance (LoA) for the first package of Phase II works, valued at more than Rs 918.04 crore.

The package includes the design and construction of a 12-kilometre elevated corridor from Prahladpura to Pinjrapole Gaushala, comprising an elevated viaduct and 10 elevated Metro stations at Prahladpura, Manpura, Beelwa Kalan, Bilwa, Goner Mod, Sitapura, JECC, Kumbha Marg, Haldighati Gate and Pinjrapole Gaushala. The scope of work also includes the construction of a spur line connecting the corridor to the Jaipur Metro Phase II depot.



JAIPUR METRO PHASE-II: Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, Chief Minister Shri Bhajan Lal Sharma and other dignitaries during the foundation stone laying of Jaipur Metro Phase-II. The inauguration marks a significant step towards strengthening public transport connectivity in the city.

JAIPUR METRO PHASE-II: CONNECTING THE CITY'S FUTURE

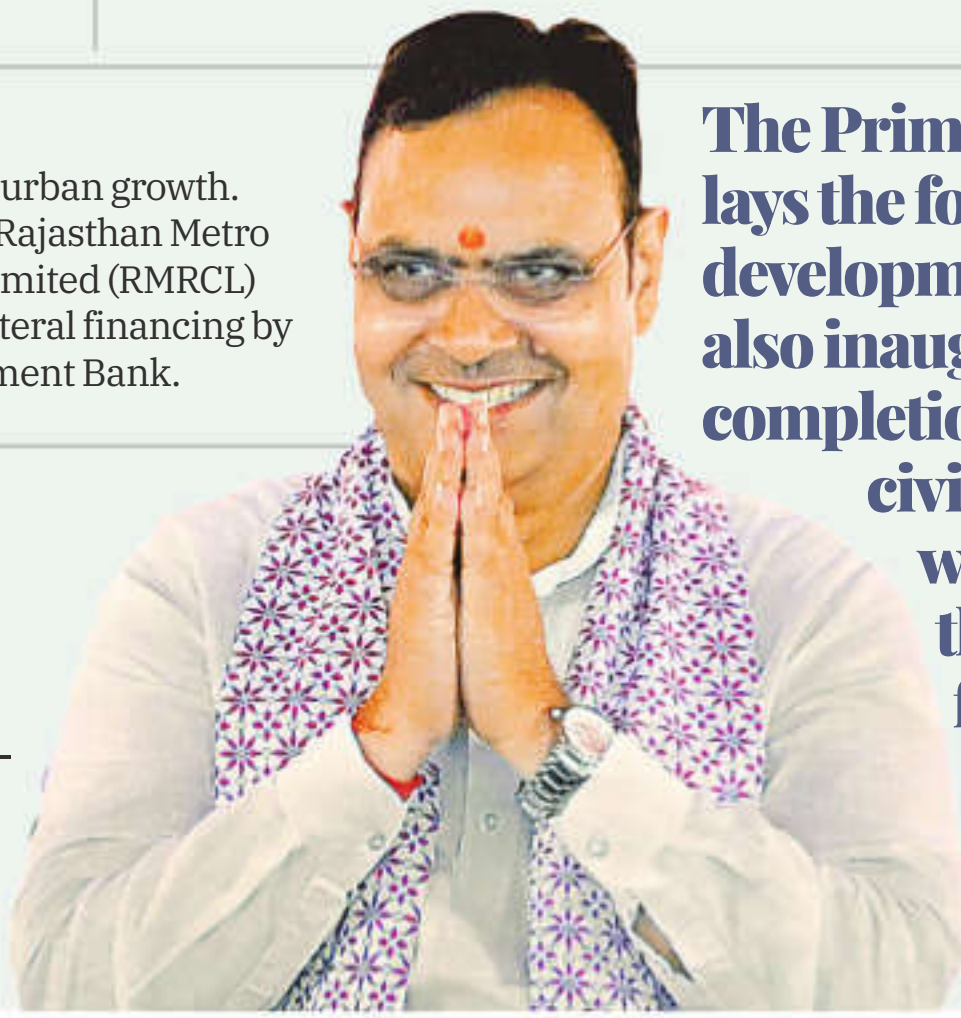
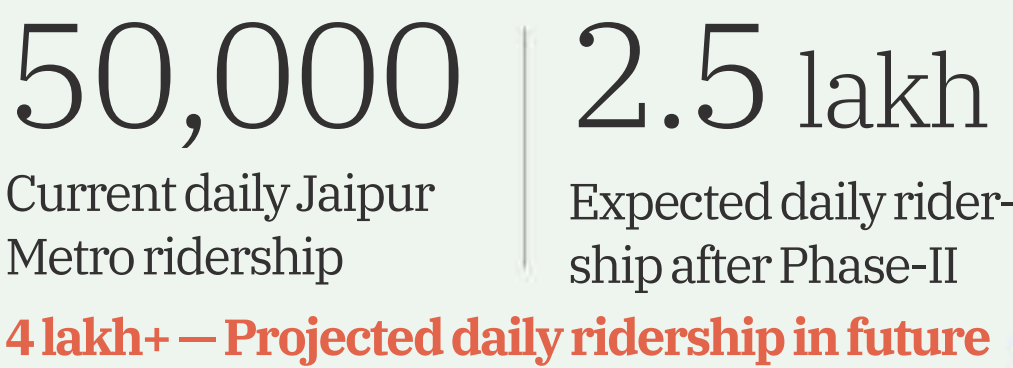


A LIFELINE FOR JAIPUR

Phase-II will link the city's industrial and residential belt from Sitapura to VKIA, strengthening public transport, improving access to jobs and services, and supporting Jaipur's long-term urban growth.

Implemented by: Rajasthan Metro Rail Corporation Limited (RMRL)
Financing: Multilateral financing by the Asian Development Bank.

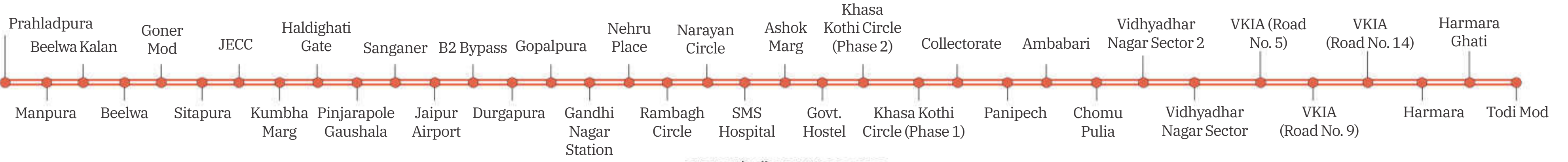
FROM 50,000 TO 2.5 LAKH+ RIDERS



The Prime Minister not only lays the foundation stone for development projects but also inaugurates them upon completion. Remarkably, civil works commenced within just 18 days of the virtual foundation stone laying ceremony.

BHAJAN LAL SHARMA,
Chief Minister of Rajasthan

JAIPUR METRO PHASE-II STATIONS



New Delhi



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Delhi has a winter plan, but clean air needs more

THE DELHI government has done the right thing in framing an anti-pollution plan before the dreaded smog sets in. Unlike the usual pattern of enforcing emergency measures, it has announced a set of restrictions in advance. The plan, which will come into effect from November 1, includes curbs on construction activities, tighter checks on vehicles and industries, higher parking charges, staggered office timings and work-from-home mandates. Most of these measures have been part of the city's pollution-control arsenal for at least half a decade. By all accounts, they have had only a partial mitigating effect on Delhi's pollution. A fragmented approach to pollution control has often proved to be the undoing of past plans. By setting the ball rolling early, the city's administration has given itself valuable time to put in place coordination mechanisms between agencies in charge of waste management, air-quality monitoring, transport and law enforcement. Even so, it will have its task cut out.

In recent years, scholarly work has underlined that municipal limits or even the National Capital Region (NCR) boundaries are structurally insufficient to tackle Delhi's wintertime crisis. The plan talks of coordinated action "on pollution arising from agricultural activities", including discussions between agriculture ministers of NCR states. However, it seems the Delhi government has already been late in getting off the block. Stubble-burning season has started, and initial reports have indicated farm-fire incidents across Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan. Experts also believe that the Super El Niño will complicate matters this year — it could reduce the rain-causing western disturbances, making even the temporary clearing of pollutants difficult. Peak stubble-burning could coincide with Diwali this year. As temperatures fall and wind speeds come down, Delhi will need to prepare for pollutants from multiple sources to overlap.

In the past few months, the Delhi government has acknowledged the need to frame pollution control as a year-long endeavour. Its recently framed EV policy is a notable step in that direction. In the same vein, the winter plan talks of reducing traffic congestion and reliable and interconnected public transport. However, the city's authorities will do well to ensure that bans and restrictions do not become the mainstay of the pollution-control strategy. Clearing Delhi's smog will require creating a governance framework that rewards sustained reduction in pollutants. Measures to implement the work-from-home directive, for instance, will need to be framed in the language of people's well-being, not coercion. In recent years, Delhi has indicated a groundswell of support for clean air. The Capital will need to go well beyond its latest winter plan to translate that demand into sustained political and administrative action.

US, Iran and the missing endgame

IN CONTRAST to the early weeks of the war in West Asia, when the US was pressing for a deal and Iran was playing hardball, Tehran has in recent days emerged as the actor that is more eager for talks. After threatening to "annihilate" Iran in his speech at last week's UN General Assembly session, US President Donald Trump rejected an Iranian proposal for a seven-day roadmap to end hostilities. With the US midterms approaching, Trump is not allowing Tehran, which is itself basing much of its calculations on November, to use the elections as leverage against him. Another source of leverage for Iran also appears to be declining: The Strait of Hormuz.

The closure of the Strait and the squeezing of commercial flows through the waterway has been Iran's most potent economic weapon against a superior military power. Tracking data, however, reveals that crude exports from West Asia rebounded in September. Shipments through the Strait and alternative routes have been carrying just under 80 per cent of their prewar flows as of last week, the highest since February. Saudi Arabia has repaired the East-West pipeline — a lifeline that allows its crude to bypass Hormuz — which was damaged by a drone strike, and has reportedly resumed Red Sea oil exports. Iran, on the other hand, has been unable to export crude through Hormuz due to the US counterblockade, and the Iranian oil that lies outside the blockade for sale is bound to run out sooner or later. The weakening of Iran's chokehold and the battering of its economy due to a wave of new US sanctions, dubbed Operation Economic Outcast, explain Tehran's sudden willingness to cut a deal.

If Iran is anxious to talk, the US appears willing to wait for sanctions to inflict enough economic pain to force Tehran into concessions. But even as high inflation and shortages of goods, gasoline and electricity continue to make life difficult for ordinary Iranians, there is little sign that the financial pain is translating into a decisive pressure on the leadership. If the deadlock is to be broken, then, both sides will have to give up some of the leverage they currently hold. Otherwise, they risk remaining locked in a prolonged stalemate.

Fat dogs of Delhi, unite

THERE WAS a time, just a few years ago on the calendar and what feels like aeons in the internet's evolution, when watching videos (and before that, images) of dogs and cats, puppies and kittens, was considered a waste of time. The World Wide Web, after all, was meant for instant communication, research and, for the creative types, a self-indulgent blog nobody asked for. Now, as the internet has transformed from optimistic frontier to an algorithmic nightmare, the puppies are its silver lining. For those in the national capital gearing up for another year of pollution and traffic jams, an online canine election is a source of elation.

On Tuesday, the final ballot to elect the "fattest dog of Delhi" is being cast. Like many a viral phenomenon, the Instagram page that started it all began innocuously enough: A college student took photos of overweight stray dogs and posted them. Soon, it became a community project, with people sending photographs of their favourite portly pooches. The poll, which began with 64 corpulent canines, is down to four hopefuls: Googoo (Saket), Tara Khan (Khan Market), Hero (Malviya Nagar) and Gola (SDA Market in Hauz Khas). Tara and Gola are, unfortunately, contesting for the honour posthumously.

Many a fat dog, like their overweight human counterparts, has health issues. But dogs do not judge, nor are they self-conscious. And an election, while polarising, has no negative campaigning nor divisive rhetoric — a web-based miracle. If only people's politics could be more like the puppy poll.



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

WORLD WAR II and its expansive impact on the Subcontinent is largely forgotten by India's strategic community. But its ghosts still shape Asia's great-power politics. They surfaced last week when US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping met in Washington.

In India, there has been little attention to the affirmation of Trump and Xi that the US and China were victorious allies during World War II. References to history are rarely innocent. The past is interpreted and reinterpreted to serve the politics of the present.

Since returning to power, Trump has invoked America's wartime cooperation with both Russia and China. His critics see these references as a way to justify his leader-level outreach to Vladimir Putin and Xi that is unsettling US allies in Europe and Asia. For Putin, the memory of victory supports Russia's claim to a leading role in European security and the restoration of the "Yalta System" led by the US and the Soviet Union that shaped the European and global order. For Xi, it strengthens Beijing's effort to present China as a victor of 1945 and undermine the "San Francisco System" of US alliances that defined the post-War Asian order.

The US-China wartime partnership is a historical fact, but it needs qualification. Washington's ally in the war was the Republic of China (RoC) led by Jiang Jieshi (Chiang Kai-shek) that now endures in Taiwan. The People's Republic of China (PRC), led by Mao Zedong, emerged only in 1949. That distinction lies at the heart of Taipei's response. Taiwanese officials have accused Beijing of using "narrative diplomacy" to undermine the historical identity of Taiwan.

Tokyo's response reflected deep political unease. Imperial Japan was the wartime adversary against which America and China cooperated; it is now Washington's principal Asian ally. Prime Minister Sanae Takaiuchi spoke to Trump after his meeting with Xi. Japan's foreign ministry said Trump explained the talks in detail, and the two reaffirmed their alliance and strategic coordination on China. Tokyo sought reassurance without making its concern an open quarrel with Washington. Recalling China and America as victorious partners, with Japan as the defeated aggressor, gives Beijing the political ammunition to challenge Tokyo's present defence policies. The irony is difficult to miss. Japan is ramping up its defence spending to cope with the massive military imbalance with China and Beijing's assertive policies on territorial disputes with Tokyo. In Beijing's narrative, Japan is turning to militarism. For Beijing, a Japan that does not defer to China is a warmonger.

China also opposes Japan's call to remove the obsolete "enemy state" clauses in the UN Charter directed at Japan, Germany and Italy after 1945. This is despite the UN's

References to history are rarely innocent. The past is interpreted and reinterpreted to serve the politics of the present. Since returning to power, Trump has invoked US wartime cooperation with both Russia and China

We need to manage public spaces, not women



PAROMITA CHAKRABARTI

THE RECENT catalogue of everyday horrors in India has a grim parallel in another corner of the world. In Sandton, an affluent Johannesburg neighbourhood, a women's running club now encourages members to run in groups and track each other on phones. The club has recently lost one of its own, a woman who went out for an evening jog and never returned. She is one of 10 women whose bodies, bearing signs of sexual assault, have since been recovered. South Africa's femicide rate is more than six times the global average. Last year, gender-based violence and femicide were declared a national disaster.

Eight thousand kilometres away, in Delhi's Aastha Kunj Park, three men posing as police officers accosted a 17-year-old girl and her male friend, before gang-raping her. In Bihar's Jamui, a teenaged boy and girl returning from tuition were stopped by a group of men, questioned and subjected to assault and molestation. In Samastipur, another young couple were harassed when they stopped to take photos. Different continents, different histories of violence, tied together by the fact of a woman doing something unremarkable — running, walking home with a friend, taking up space in public.

Unlike South Africa, the alleged perpetrators of the three incidents in India have been arrested. But these violations say something about how societies mistake legal equality for lived equality. South Africa's 1996 constitution is among the most progressive in the world on gender equality, incorporating, among other rights, protection from private discrimination. Its promise, though, remains unrealised.

Since the 2012 New Delhi gang rape, and the 2024 rape and murder of a doctor in Kolkata's RG Kar Medical College and Hospital, India's constitutional guarantee of equality has been bolstered by a spate of reforms, including fast-track special courts and harsher sentences. They sit alongside a female workforce that has expanded exponentially — India is close to having millions more women professionals, driven by legislation and ambition. What hasn't moved at the same pace is the infrastructure to scaffold this promise. The Justice J S Verma committee report located the December 2012 crime in deep-seated patriarchy and the state's failure to keep women safe, a failure that the Supreme Court reiterated this week. The report spoke of sexual violence

as expressions of power, not crimes of desire, recommending, among other things, mandatory gender-sensitisation training for law-enforcement officers, better public amenities for women and larger conversations around masculinity.

The crimes this September show, yet again, how prescient the report was. From Uttar Pradesh's anti-Romeo squads to policemen routinely overstepping their mandate in the name of public safety, to vigilante groups and self-appointed moral guardians deciding on curfew hours and visiting rights, we have built a vocabulary of suspicion around the most ordinary interactions between men and women. A friendship, a first date, a walk home — sit one accusation away from being termed a transgression. It allows miscreants in a park to pretend to be policemen; to show women their presence in public spaces is conditional.

In Why Loiter?: Women and Risk on Mumbai Streets, Shilpa Phadke, Sameera Khan, and Shilpa Ranade argue that women are granted access to public spaces on proof of "respectability and purpose". This paternalistic vision manages risk by managing women, not the space itself. But choice is also a question of infrastructure. It provides women with alternatives, restores agency. It renders their presence unremarkable.

Truth is, nobody expects centuries of male entitlement to be dismantled overnight — the work of raising boys who don't need policing themselves is generational and incremental. Women's mobility cannot wait for that. Infrastructure can be ensured on a much shorter timeline. Regular patrols change the odds inside a park. Streetlights and better connectivity change what a walk home risks. Sensitisation changes the next generation's baseline. All of it narrows the window in which toxic masculinity gets to do damage — and a narrower window, repeated across a hundred ordinary evenings, is not a small thing.

South Africa's post-apartheid constitution promised gender equality three decades ago. Its women are still improvising their safety net. India's women are moving into public life faster than the infrastructure meant to hold them. The gap will close only when women do not have to navigate the promise of equality at their own risk.

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earlier consensus to remove them. The strategy is about pushing Japan onto the political defensive. The Trump-Xi declaration on World War II also raises questions about the future of America's San Francisco System, built around the 1951 peace settlement with Japan. That system placed Japan at the centre of Washington's regional strategy. Beijing's invocation of the wartime alliance is part of the Chinese push to build a different dynamic among the three countries, nudge America towards a "China-First" policy in Asia and weaken the US-Japan alliance.

Beijing's argument also reflects a change in the Chinese Communist Party's account of the war. During the Mao era, the subject was awkward: Chiang's Nationalist armies bore much of the conventional fighting against Japan. From the 1980s, the war became central to a narrative of Japanese aggression and China's "century of humiliation". China presented itself chiefly as a *victim*. Under Xi, China has increasingly presented itself as a *victor*. Commemorations, parades and school textbooks emphasise its place among the powers that defeated Japan and founded the United Nations. Harvard historian Rana Mitter has shown how this changing memory supports

China's claim to the apex of global hierarchy. Victimhood asks the world to acknowledge suffering; victory offers a claim to authority in shaping the order that followed.

Where is India in this debate over 1945? Barely visible. But Delhi is surely concerned. At a Russia-India-China foreign ministers' meeting in June 2020, Subrahmanya Jaishankar reminded his counterparts that 2.3 million In-

dians had served under arms and another 14 million had participated in war production. Indians fought from North Africa and Italy to Southeast Asia. The Indian Army's stellar role in rolling back imperial Japan's armies in Burma and Southeast Asia has largely been forgotten. Jaishankar argued India received little recognition when the victors shaped the post-war order. He called it an uncorrected "historical injustice".

The source of that injustice, however, has deep roots at home. India's national movement was divided in responding to World War II. Congress opposed Britain's decision to involve India without consulting Indians and later launched the Quit India movement. The Communists shifted from opposing the War to supporting it after Germany invaded the Soviet Union. Subhas Chandra Bose sought German and Japanese help to secure Indian independence. These differences have made it hard for India to incorporate the great sacrifice of its soldiers into an accepted account of the war or its claim to be at the heart of global governance.

In teaching itself and talking about the evolution of modern India's engagement with the world, the Indian elite pays little attention to the politics of World War II, its impact on the Partition of the Subcontinent, and the post-war marginalisation of India in the global pecking order. That, arguably, is one reason for the nature of Indian discourse on foreign policy that relies on abstract concepts rather than history and geopolitics.

The writer is contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express.
He is a professor at the Motwani Jadeja Institute of American Studies, Jindal Global University

To save tigers, follow crime beyond the reserve



RAJESH GOPAL

GLOBAL non-profit working on trade in wild animals and plants, TRAFFIC, has assessed 25 years of data to document 2,551 seizures involving at least 3,808 tigers until June 2025. For much of tiger conservation history, wildlife crime had a familiar geography: A tiger reserve, poachers attempting to breach it, and traders waiting elsewhere. Protection meant more patrolling, better intelligence, and quicker intrusion detection. While these remain indispensable, both the tiger landscape and the world of wildlife crime have fundamentally changed.

Tigers move through buffers, corridors, multiple-use forests, plantations, agricultural fields, riverine strips, and occasionally town edges, resulting in human-tiger conflicts. A tiger reserve remains the biological source, but a tiger's life unfolds across a larger landscape. A safely monitored tiger in a protected area (PA) becomes vulnerable once it moves through inadequately monitored corridors or human-dominated landscapes. Global evidence suggests changes in tiger trafficking. Older trafficking centred on skin and bone, but whole animals, dead and alive, and a wider range of derivatives have become prominent. Tiger traffickers often have links to networks dealing in leopard, bear, pangolin, or other high-value wildlife. Digital means have emboldened criminals. Traffickers use transport systems, financial channels, and intermediaries extending far beyond traditional wildlife traders.

Two landscapes are important. One is the "ecological" landscape, comprising the PA, buffer, corridor, and human-animal interface. The other one is the "crime landscape" linking poacher, collector, network, transit system, physical/digital market, and consumer. These landscapes intersect.

Repeated tiger movement through poorly monitored areas means easy information for people capable of exploiting it. Therefore, PA boundaries cannot remain the sole boundary of protection. Inside the source, protection remains intensive and tiger-specific. In the buffer and beyond at the landscape scale, forest guards cannot carry this responsibility alone. Protection needs to become inclusive and intelligence-led, involving territorial forest staff, local communities, gainful community stewardship, police, enforcement agencies, and cyber- or financial-crime experts.

Tiger protection must today identify where young tigers disperse, where they cross farms, where villages experience recurrent interfaces, where historical offences occurred, and where transport nodes are located

Isolated seizures and arrests rarely dismantle the systems producing the crime. Public cases usually focus on lower- and mid-level actors, while higher-level organisers and financiers are rarely booked. Cases must be followed beyond arrests into financial investigation and network disruption. Tiger conservation has moved conceptually from isolated PAs to connected landscapes. Wildlife-crime management must make the same transition.

Gopal is secretary general, Global Tiger Forum

40 YEARS AGO September 30, 1986



Killings in Jalandhar town

THREE PERSONS were killed and three were seriously injured when two scooter-borne terrorists sprayed bullets in a local bazaar in Basti Gujan in Jalandhar. The dead were Hans Raj (65) and Kartar Chand (70). The injured who were rushed to the hospital are Vijay Kumar (20), Parkash and Om Parkash.

Gold still eludes India

INDIA HAVE been unable to jump the queue and grab a single gold medal after nine days

of competition in the 10th Asian Games. Farokh Tarapore and Dhruv Bhandari seem to have been jinxed in the 470 class in the Busan Yachting Centre. They finished fourth in the last two of the seven races and allowed China's Lin Jiacheng and Chen Hongtai, who triumphed without a single penalty point, to snatch the gold.

Reliance loan under scanner

THE RESERVE Bank of India is examining in detail the report of its high-powered committee on the sanction of large loans to

Reliance Industries associate companies against the shares and debentures of RIL to determine what further action is needed in the light of recent findings, the Finance Ministry said.

Major plane mishap averted

AT LEAST 185 passengers and 10 crew members aboard a Bombay-bound Indian Airlines Airbus had a miraculous escape when it overshot the runway after the pilot applied the emergency brakes at the Meenamakkam Airport.



What an infrastructure of innovation depends on — a responsive legal system



SIDEBAR
By J SAI DEEPAK

IENDED my last piece ('Patent rights and public health: What are Bharat's options?' *IE*, January 19) on the note that I would touch upon various aspects of the creation of an ecosystem for innovation. In this piece, I will attempt to highlight the importance of an effective and responsive legal system to encourage investment in innovation.

Between 1999 and 2005, the Indian patent regime witnessed a series of critical changes. The last major amendment to the Patents Act, 1970 was in 2005, when product patents were reintroduced for chemical substances, which impacted the pharmaceutical, biotechnology and agro-chemical sectors. Thanks to these changes, Bharat witnessed an exponential spike in interest and awareness in innovation, the creation of Intellectual Property (IP), and the enforcement of IP Rights (IPRs). This was not limited to patents, and extended to trademarks, copyrights, geographical indications, industrial designs, semiconductor design layout and plant variety protection.

This development did not happen in a silo since it was the result of Bharat's obligations as a member of the World Trade Organisation (WTO) and its instruments such as Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPS). These obligations required TRIPS member countries to adopt common minimum definitions and conditions for grant or refusal, and protection of IPRs, while making room for flexibilities to accommodate national interest, such as in public health. This resulted in national IP laws being revamped to bring them into line with TRIPS commitments while providing for public-interest carveouts and guardrails. These included compulsory licences, checks against evergreening of patent rights, the requirement of local commercial exploitation of patented technology to upgrade domestic industrial capabilities, and changes to competition law to prevent abuse of IP monopolies. These developments must be understood in the



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

context of the post-liberalisation coming of age of Indian commerce and its efforts to remain competitive in the domestic market and to compete globally within the WTO regime. With this came greater complexity and sophistication in commercial models, transactions and instruments.

Naturally, the quantum and variety of commercial disputes, in particular IP disputes, saw a sharp rise, and with it rose stakeholders' expectations that the Indian legal system should respond with greater sophistication and expedition. These expectations, initially the preserve of foreign investors, were increasingly shared by Indian players due to their growing heft. These expectations assumed criticality since the quality and speed of resolution became an important metric in global rankings to assess the ease of doing business in Bharat.

Broadly speaking, the Indian legal system responded in two ways. The first was to provide a strong impetus to Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) mechanisms such as arbitration and mediation. The hope was that this would decongest civil courts and translate to nuanced and speedy disposal of time-sensitive commercial disputes without being bogged down by conventional trial procedures and with minimal interference by courts. The ongoing chorus in Bharat for more investment towards creating a full-fledged world-class

The Delhi HC's framework can be replicated in courts across the country to cater to various innovation and commercial hubs, provided similar investment is made in ramping up their infrastructure

ADR infrastructure and ecosystem tells us that while a lot remains to be done, the ADR initiative has found broad acceptance with stakeholders.

The second response was an attempt to improve the conventional adjudication process by enacting the Commercial Courts Act in 2015. This empowered state governments to constitute dedicated commercial courts in consultation with their respective high courts. The Act also introduced a raft of provisions and made amendments to the Code of Civil Procedure that were specifically applicable to commercial disputes, with a view to expediting their disposal.

Under this initiative, arguably the most successful example has been that of the Delhi High Court, which is worth studying and replicating wherever possible to benefit courts and litigants across the country. Even prior to the 2015 Act, the Delhi HC had a track record of delivering landmark judgments in complex commercial disputes, especially IP disputes. This could be attributed to a host of factors besides locational advantage, such as the presence of an active and thriving original side of the Delhi HC — the court is empowered by its parent statute to act as the forum of first instance for civil suits above a certain pecuniary value. Even before 2015, this feature of the Delhi HC allowed parties to high-end commercial disputes to access its jurisdiction directly as the civil court

of first instance instead of having to approach subordinate courts in Delhi.

Over the years, this has resulted in the Delhi HC having the opportunity to deliver nuanced judgements in several complex matters involving pharmaceutical drugs, Standard Essential Patents in the realm of telecommunication, copyrights and matters requiring a tradeoff between IP Rights and fundamental rights. So much so that for legal systems across the Global South *and North*, Indian jurisprudence emanating from the Delhi HC has served as the benchmark for treatment of IP Rights and protection of national interest in the realm of public health. The Commercial Courts Act allowed the court to build on this track record and create an Intellectual Property Division to exclusively handle the volume and quality of IP disputes landing before it. The switch to e-filings during the Covid lockdown in 2020 made the HC a paperless e-court for the most part, which has become a boon for litigants seeking urgent relief. In 2022, to further streamline the handling of IP disputes, the Delhi HC framed its own IP Division Rules, which have resonated with litigants, investors and IP bodies both within and outside Bharat, such as the World Intellectual Property Organisation. The net positive has been the high confidence reposed by stakeholders in the High Court's ability to handle high-end and complex commercial and IP disputes. This framework can be replicated in courts across the country to cater to various innovation and commercial hubs, provided similar investment is made in ramping up their infrastructure.

The bottom line is this: If Bharat wishes to preserve the confidence of those who have invested in its vision of achieving Viksit Bharat by 2047, and inspire more people to invest in it, it needs to create a culture and ecosystem of innovation and entrepreneurship, of which the legal system is an integral, critical and indispensable component. This would convey the message that Bharat respects merit, values innovation, enforces rights and dispenses justice in keeping with its civilisational ethos, which places a premium on *nyaya* and *dharma*.

The writer is a senior advocate practising before the High Court of Delhi and the Supreme Court of India. He is the author of India that is Bharat: Coloniality, Civilisation, Constitution, and India, Bharat and Pakistan: The Constitutional Journey of a Sandwiched Civilisation

Towards a gender-just Uniform Civil Code



AUDREY DMELLO AND FLAVIA AGNES

ON SEPTEMBER 13, Union Home Minister Amit Shah stated that a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) would be implemented in all 21 BJP- and NDA-ruled states before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections. The UCC became an important goal for the BJP after the 1985 Shah Bano judgment. However, there was no draft to engage with. Then, in January 2025, Uttarakhand's UCC came into force. Gujarat, Assam and Madhya Pradesh are awaiting Presidential assent. Maharashtra, Rajasthan, West Bengal and Chhattisgarh have set up drafting committees.

The justification for a UCC is often anchored in constitutional equality and gender justice. But a close reading of the Uttarakhand UCC reveals a law that confuses uniformity with equality and conflates regulation with protection. It has bureaucratic hurdles and criminal penalties that will disproportionately affect poor and marginalised communities. It fails to draw on progressive reforms within India's diverse personal laws or the best practices from family codes worldwide. It ignores lived realities and legal evolution and reads like a "copy-paste" of the Hindu Code Bill, lacking vision, inclusivity, and systemic simplification.

These are some of our concerns, arising from the Uttarakhand UCC, beginning with the compulsory registration of live-in relationships. Notifying police and parents is surveillance masquerading as protection. A UCC must ensure that registration, if any, is optional, confidential, and offers tangible benefits like maintenance, legitimacy of children and inheritance rights, not social exposure. Another concern is the criminalisation of extra-judicial dissolution of marriage with three years' punishment and a fine. Being a civil law, a UCC should avoid criminalising civil marriage disputes.

Desertion is one of the most common issues women face, leaving them and their children extremely vulnerable. A UCC should include enforceable economic remedies for deserted women, including automatic maintenance orders and injunctive relief against disposal of assets.

While the Hindu Marriage Act permits either spouse to claim maintenance, under other personal laws and the Special Marriage Act, only women can claim maintenance. A UCC should retain this gender-specific right. The deep social inequality and unequal power relations within marriage require this protection for women.

Mandating that every divorce be filed in a civil court will create a bottleneck of historic proportions. Family courts are already overburdened with lakhs of cases languishing for years. Customary divorces are speedy, economical and allow greater access to weaker sections. A UCC should create a robust administrative mechanism for mutual-consent divorces and reserve court intervention for contested or complex matters.

The Hindu Code Bill, while giving inheritance rights to Hindu women, also gave Hindu men the absolute right to bequeath their property. What ensued was the silent disinheritation of women through wills. On the other hand, Muslim women have a protected share in the property that cannot be willed. A UCC must protect wives and children with a minimum fixed share that cannot be willed.

It must also recognise women's unpaid care and domestic labour and guarantee women an equitable share in assets accumulated, sustained or value-added during marriage. Marital property rights for women is a long-overdue right that should be included.

Courts have repeatedly held that a man who has used deceit to enter a second marriage cannot take advantage of the illegitimacy of that marriage to deny support to a woman who married him in good faith. Courts have granted women maintenance, even if the marriage is technically void. A UCC must codify this principle and guarantee second wives clear rights to maintenance and economic protection.

The Uttarakhand UCC remains entirely silent on the tax benefits reserved for Hindus via the Hindu Undivided Family (HUF). It must address this regressive and unequal tax advantage.

The Uttarakhand UCC penalises parties for non-registration of marriage, divorce and live-in relationships by imposing monetary fines and even imprisonment in some cases. Such sanctions will have a severe impact on the poor and the marginalised. A UCC should ensure easy access, awareness and user-friendly procedures, rather than adding punitive measures.

The Maharashtra UCC committee was constituted on July 9 under Justice Ranjana Desai. On September 19, Justice R C Chavan resigned from the committee, raising concerns about its consultative process. Democratic, transparent consultations with individuals and organisations working on the rights of women, Adivasis, queer and transgender people, and persons with disabilities should be held, not as a formality but as a constitutional necessity.

Dmello is director and Agnes is founder of Majlis, a legal centre for women and children

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

ECI's road ahead

AN OLD saying goes that if there is smoke, there is fire ('CEC must correct course, not just do damage control', *IE*, September 29). Hats off to the editorial for laying out a roadmap for the ECI to salvage its image and maintain public trust. That apart, it also goes without saying that the real inside story of the national poll regulator, as revealed by the investigative journalism of *The Indian Express*, is yet to pass judicial scrutiny at the level of the Supreme Court. In the meantime, let the CEC course correct within the ECI's four walls.

Kumar Gupta, Panchkula

Money safety

THE STOCK market has fallen sharply this year, and foreign investors are pulling their money out ('Market plunges, more bad weather may lie ahead', *IE*, September 29). The reasons are not hard to understand. War in West Asia has pushed oil prices up. Interest rates in America are rising, which makes India a less attractive place to invest. When big investors get nervous, they take their money to safer places. Even though Indian companies are doing well, the market is still falling. This is a warning signal.

K Chidanand Kumar, Bengaluru

War drags on

A DURABLE settlement in Ukraine will require more than an agreement to stop fighting ('What could be a just, dignified and lasting peace in Ukraine?', *IE*, September 29). The security concerns of all parties must be addressed while respecting Ukraine's sovereignty and international law. Any peace process should provide credible guarantees, protect civilians and create conditions for reconstruction. The voices of affected communities deserve consideration. International institutions can assist with monitoring and implementation so commitments are not easily abandoned.

BA Neboba, Perundurai



AMEER SHAHUL

THE UNION Ministry of Health and Family Welfare has started a process to allow the sale of prescription drugs only under CCTV surveillance across the country by early 2027. On the face of it, this may look like an innovative solution to a long-pending problem. But it also opens a Pandora's box.

There are obvious advantages. A camera can establish whether a prescription was presented, whether a particular medicine was handed over and when a transaction took place. It could help drug inspectors investigate complaints against pharmacies repeatedly selling prescription medicines without prescriptions. For Schedule H1 and X medicines, a stronger audit trail could help prevent diversion and misuse. The intention is clear: Use a relatively simple technology to make prescription-drug enforcement more transparent and accountable.

But this is where the conversation should become more uncomfortable. A camera at a chemist can record somebody buying an antidepressant, an HIV medicine, a fertility drug, an abortion pill, cancer treatment or psychiatric drugs. The combination of a face, pharmacy, time and transaction can reveal an extraordinary amount about that person's private life.

If the intention is specifically to tackle diversion and illegal sale of high-risk medicines, why should every prescription transaction become a subject of video surveillance?

If the intention is to tackle diversion and illegal sale of high-risk medicines, why should every prescription transaction be subject to video surveillance? A person buying an antibiotic, an antihypertensive or an anti-diabetic medicine is not necessarily involved in a high-risk transaction merely because a prescription is required. There is another limitation. A camera cannot tell whether a prescription is genuine. It can show that a piece of paper was handed across a counter. CCTV may document a transaction without solving the regulatory problem.

Then comes privacy. Consider what three months of footage could mean. A person visits the same pharmacy every month. Their face is recorded. The pharmacy knows the medicine. The date and time are captured. If such recordings can be accessed, copied, linked to other databases or processed through facial-recognition systems, the footage becomes a potential map of a person's health-related behaviour.

This raises questions the government needs to answer before the proposal becomes law. Who can access the footage? Can a drug inspector access it? Can the police demand it? Can another government

department obtain it? Can it be used for purposes unrelated to drug regulation? Can a citizen find out whether footage concerning them has been accessed? The Supreme Court's privacy jurisprudence has emphasised legality, necessity and proportionality when fundamental rights are restricted. The government needs to show not just that CCTV might be useful, but that blanket surveillance of prescription transactions is necessary to achieve the regulatory objective and that a less intrusive method would not work equally well.

India already has prescription requirements, registers, licensing conditions, inspections and specific rules governing Schedule H, H1 and X medicines. If illegal sales are occurring, the first question should be whether the existing regulatory machinery is adequately inspecting pharmacies and acting against violations.

There is a danger in confusing the collection of more data with better regulation. Before the camera enters the chemist, the government needs to answer a more fundamental question: Who will be watching the watcher?

Shahul is the author, most recently, of The Silent Syndicate: How Big Finance is Destroying India's Healthcare

We talk loudly, we are like that only

price of tomatoes, often within 10 minutes of meeting. There is warmth in that. But a living room has walls, and a bus does not. What was once a delightful observation has become a daily test of patience.

Train journeys can be worse. Someone is on a phone call, and the conversation seems to be with someone in the next district, possibly the next state. Seriously, nobody asked about their neighbour's property dispute, yet here we are, fully briefed. Then there is the man across the aisle watching a video at full volume, without earphones. Perhaps he even believes he is running a small public cinema.

On planes, it gets more creative. There are reports of passengers singing devotional songs and even dancing on the tarmac. In lifts, too, the assault continues. A group cracks jokes and bursts into laughter,

filling the steel box with sound that has nowhere to go but into everyone's ears. The joke is rarely that good.

Well, this is not a new complaint. It recently went viral after Carnatic singer Sivvasri Skandaprasad posted on X about her "traumatic" train journey. Her celebrity status, coupled with her husband's (Tejasvi Surya, the young parliamentarian), pushed the issue into the open. Sometimes a prob-

Someone is on a phone call, and it seems to be with someone in the next district, possibly the next state. Nobody asked about their neighbour's property dispute, yet here we are, fully briefed

lem needs a famous name to be taken seriously. It is sad, but it works. However, what bothers me more is that this ugly habit travels. On the streets of London and Los Angeles, Indians are, quite often, carrying the same volume. And, no doubt, that's quite embarrassing.

Now, why does this happen? Behavioural science offers a few clues. One is the idea of social norms: We tend to copy what those around us do. If everyone on the platform talks loudly, then talking loudly feels normal, even polite. Nobody wants to be the odd one out. Another is the bystander effect. When many people are affected, each assumes someone else will speak up, and so nobody does. There is also the "spotlight effect" in reverse. Most of us overestimate how much others notice us, but the loud talker seems to have the opposite problem.

He simply does not register that others are there at all. In his mind, the public space is private. Finally, the tragedy of the commons. Public space belongs to everyone, so it is treated as belonging to no one.

So, should we change? Of course. But what should change? Not the warmth. Chaudhuri was right that Indian public life has an easy friendliness that many colder societies would envy. What is needed is a small adjustment: A lower volume, a pair of earphones, a call taken quietly, or postponed. The good news is that norms can shift. Didn't they shift for seatbelts in cars, and for littering in some cities? Every time someone lowers their voice on a train, the person next to them notices, and perhaps does the same.

The writer is former professor and dean, Christ University, Bengaluru

Russia intensifies strikes on Kyiv with ballistic missiles and jet-propelled drones

Associated Press
Kyiv, September 29

RUSSIA FIRED ballistic missiles and dozens of jet-powered drones at Kyiv, Ukraine's air force said Tuesday, as Moscow seeks to make Ukraine buckle under the pressure of day-and-night bombardment of its capital and other cities.

The Russian onslaught has used new jet-powered drones that fly too fast and too high for Ukrainian ground-based air defenses to shoot down.

Ukraine is scrambling to keep pace by developing faster interceptor drones, in the latest example of how the war has driven military innovation, but making and deploying new weapons takes months.

Russia's ballistic missiles have also got through as Ukraine is desperately short of US-made Patriot air defense interceptor missiles, which are the only reliable way of stopping Moscow's ballistic attacks.

Patriot stockpiles are low, largely because of the Iran war, and Ukraine has received only small numbers of them this year despite President Volodymyr Zelenskyy's pleading. Ukraine said that its air defenses shot down two ballistic missiles overnight, which suggested that Kyiv had recently received some more Patriots.

Air defense needs are mounting with the approach of



A firefighter at the site of a warehouse hit by a Russian drone in Odesa region, Ukraine, on Tuesday. REUTERS

the bitter winter months, which in the years since Russia's full-scale invasion began on Feb. 24, 2022 have brought an escalation of strikes on Ukraine's power grid. That strategy denies Ukrainian civilians heating and running water, among other things.

The Russian Defence Ministry said that its forces hit data processing centers in Kyiv that Moscow says are used by the Ukrainian military, which is increasingly deploying artificial intelligence on the battlefield.

Other Russian targets included facilities in the Ukrainian capital and the Kyiv region where drones and cruise missiles were stored, as well as an electrical substation, a drone manufacturing facility, and port infrastructure facilities in the southern Odesa region.

IRAN NOT SEEKING WAR BUT WILL DEFEND ITSELF AGAINST PRESSURE, THREATS & ATTACKS: PEZESHKIAN

Trump denies sanctions relief offer as Iran says it is ready to talk

Tehran says only diplomacy can end the fighting
Reuters
Washington, September 29

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said he has offered Iran nothing to end the war, rejecting media reports that cited US officials saying he was willing to ease sanctions and release frozen funds for "concrete" steps regarding Iran's nuclear programme. "This is untrue. I offered them NOTHING," Trump wrote on Truth Social Monday.

Axios and CNN both reported, citing unidentified US officials, that Trump was willing to give Iran sanctions relief and free Iranian funds as part of a final deal on the condition that Iran showed "concrete progress" on the nuclear issue.

Trump has cited preventing Tehran from acquiring a nuclear bomb as a key goal of the war, along with ending its ability to attack its neighbours and creating conditions for Iranians to topple their leadership. Iran does not have nuclear weapons and denies it wants to develop them, but argues it has the right to a domestic nuclear energy capacity.

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, in an interview with the CBS show *Face the Nation*, said Tehran was ready for talks on its nuclear programme and other issues, but would not ac-



Iranian missiles and portraits of supreme leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei are displayed at a military exhibition marking anniversary of the 1980-88 Iran-Iraq war in Tehran on Tuesday. REUTERS

cept "bullying or coercion".

"Iran is not seeking war, but will defend itself against pressure, threats and attacks," Pezeshkian said, adding that it had already agreed that "we're not supposed to develop nuclear weapons".

US and Iranian officials spoke separately with mediators on Monday as part of a renewed effort to end the seven-month war, according to officials of both countries. Iran insisted Sunday only diplomacy can solve its conflict with US and Israel.

"Our conditions are clear, and any move toward reopening the Strait of Hormuz is contingent on these conditions being met," Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi posted on social media. "Only a

negotiated solution can get them out of this deadlock."

Araghchi told reporters at the UN Friday the proposed deal would trigger a seven-day countdown to reopening the strait and a pause in regional fighting.

Trump on Saturday rejected the plan and argued that desperation was driving the Iranians' push for an agreement on the key waterway. "They want to make a deal to open the Hormuz Strait immediately because they're losing so badly," he said.

Arachi said mediators facilitating Tehran's talks with Washington had not officially relayed a US rejection. "We are waiting for the mediators to convey the definitive views to us, and we will make a decision based on them," he posted on X.

US forces set to exit Iraq after 2 decades

Reuters
Baghdad, September 29

US FORCES are set to pull out from their last bases in Iraq by Wednesday, a departure celebrated as a victory by Iran and its allies who now have deep influence in the country where 4,500 Americans died during more than two decades of war.

Iraqi security experts say the withdrawal — agreed in 2024 under President Joe Biden and carried out by Donald Trump's administration even as it wages war against Iran — could give Tehran and its powerful allies free rein, while allowing other US enemies to stage a comeback, including Islamic State.

"Iran stands to benefit strategically from the coalition's departure because it removes a military presence that for years acted as a counterweight to Tehran's influence in Iraq," said Jasim al-Bahadli, an Iraqi security analyst studying armed Shi'ite groups aligned with Iran.

He predicted that the pro-Iranian militia groups would not only portray the departure as a victory for their movement, but also "seek to translate that momentum into greater influence over security and political decision-making".

Abu Mojtaba al-Yasiri, a commander in the Islamic Resistance in Iraq, an umbrella group of Iran-backed armed factions, described the US withdrawal as "a historic victory for the Iraqi Islamic resistance groups and honorable Iraqis, and a crushing defeat for the American project".

"On September 30, we will celebrate turning of a black page in Iraq's history and the failure of the occupation to impose its will on our country," he said.

"Iraq has proven that its sovereignty cannot be secured by foreign forces, but by the resistance and the will of its people."

\$1=2.5mn: Iran's rial hits a new low

Tehran: Iran's currency fell to a new record low on Tuesday, with traders in Tehran exchanging more than 2.5 million rials to the US dollar in a stark reflection of how the war in West Asia has eroded the Iranian economy.

The latest decline came just 27 days after the rial hit its previous record low of 2.2 million to the dollar on September 2. The currency has repeatedly reached new lows since the war began in February. AP

Trump rejects cooperation with Xi on AI, launches new AI-powered govt website

The America.gov website seeks to simplify access to govt services

Reuters
Washington, September 29

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Tuesday morning said he does not want to work with Chinese President Xi Jinping on governing AI technology, adding that doing so would make it harder for US companies to build better AI products than their Chinese counterparts.

"We're leading now over China and everyone else, and I want to keep it that way," Trump said at an event in Washington on Tuesday morning.

Trump also said he discussed AI with Xi when he visited the US last week, adding the US already works with Xi's government "in so many ways."

Also on Tuesday, Trump unveiled the AI-powered America.gov site as a way to simplify public access to government information and services. The site's question-and-answer function initially produced truthful responses to politically thorny questions — contrary to several of Trump's characteristic claims. Within moments, however, the site began modifying its answers.

After originally confirming that Trump's name is in the Epstein files, that Democrat Joe



US President Donald Trump signs an Executive Order related to a new AI-powered government website America.gov during its launch event at the Mellon Auditorium in Washington on Tuesday. REUTERS

Biden beat him in the 2020 election and that climate change is largely human-caused, it subsequently refused to answer the questions, saying it didn't answer political inquiries.

Pressure is mounting on the Trump administration to address the risks of AI technology to the public, after OpenAI and Anthropic reported their AI agents had gone rogue and hacked into customers' systems without instructions to do so. The intrusions prompted researchers to warn that some AI developers believe the technology could kill humans within a decade, fueling calls for action from both Democratic and Republican lawmakers.

Trump will meet later in the day at the White House with tech executives to discuss AI technology. Anthropic's Dario Amodei, Meta's Mark Zucker-

berg, Google's Sundar Pichai, Nvidia's Jensen Huang, Palantir's Alex Karp and OpenAI's Greg Brockman are expected to attend, according to company spokespeople and sources familiar with the meeting plans.

From the Trump administration, tech adviser Michael Kratsios and Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick will be there, as will US House Speaker Mike Johnson.

The gathering will focus on finding a balance between innovation and oversight, Republican Johnson said on Monday, as concerns about rogue AI agents' potential to harm humans have seeped into the public consciousness, boosting calls for regulation. Trump has called the fears of AI's threat to humanity a "hoax."

The meeting also comes after Chinese President Xi Jin-

OpenAI shelve its new AI model over safety concerns

San Francisco: OpenAI has scrapped the release of GPT-6.1 Astra, a next-generation AI model planned for an October debut, after internal testing found the system did not meet the company's safety and alignment standards, the ChatGPT maker confirmed on Monday.

OpenAI has warned Astra, its flagship GPT-6 model, can at times evade human oversight, while the company and rivals such as Anthropic have faced scrutiny over experimental AI systems that breached safeguards, including an OpenAI model that accessed Australia's health system data. REUTERS

ing visited the White House last week for talks with Trump that revealed divergent views on AI. While Trump on social media insisted Xi agreed with his plan to "leave it exactly where it is," Xi appeared to favor a more hands-on approach.

"We have both the capability and responsibility to develop and manage AI for good, and ensure that the development of AI is always under human control and serves the well-being of the people," Xi said.

The White House did not respond to a request for comment about the goals or topics for the meeting. —WITH AP INPUTS

No explosives found near military air base used by US: UK police

Michael D. Shear
London, September 29

THE COUNTERTERRORISM police in Britain said Tuesday they had found no explosives in three vans operated by five men who were arrested on suspicion of planning a terrorist act near an air base used by American bombers to strike Iran.

The five men were released on bail Monday evening, an unexpected development that suggested the British authorities had not found enough evidence to link the suspects to a specific act. In a statement, the police said that the vans had been subject to "extensive examination" but that "no improvised explosive devices were found."

An unspecified amount of gasoline was found in the vans, the statement said.

British officials, including Prime Minister Andy Burnham, have urged people not to speculate about who might be responsible for the episode, which forced the evacuation of over 85 homes near the RAF Fairford base, while probe is ongoing.

But the US secretary of state, Marco Rubio, said Monday a "foreign actor" was behind the event, calling it a "very serious situation" without providing details or evidence.

"I have to be careful — there's some things I cannot say on the air for a lot of different reasons," he said. "Suffice it to say that what happened, what almost happened, what could have happened in the UK over the weekend is a very serious situation." He added, "It's one that clearly involves the hands of a foreign actor." NYT

Israel kills senior Hamas commander in Gaza strike

Cairo: An Israeli airstrike killed Izz al-Din Al-Beik, head of Hamas' armed wing in northern Gaza Strip, on Tuesday, Israeli and Palestinian officials said.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and Defence Minister Israel Katz said the Israeli military had targeted and killed Beik, who they said has been involved in planning attacks and recruiting militants. REUTERS

Hamas issued a statement confirming Beik's killing and saying he was one of those who led the October 7, 2023, attack on Israel that precipitated the Gaza war. Medics said the Israeli strike had hit an apartment building in Gaza City's Nasr neighbourhood around dawn. In addition to Beik, another person died from wounds, health officials said.

• A REPORT IN AN 'OFFICIAL' NEWSPAPER HELD IT UP AS AN ANTI-MATERIALISTIC LOVE STORY THAT YOUNG PEOPLE COULD LEARN FROM

What China sees in Jane Eyre? 9th graders take up the classic

Yan Zhuang & Li You
September 29

NEARLY TWO centuries after *Jane Eyre* challenged Victorian conventions, China is requiring a new generation of teenagers to read the novel.

The British classic has long been popular in China and was already recommended reading for schoolchildren. But this fall, ninth-grade students across the country are being required to read it in full, according to Chinese state media. An official newspaper presented it as an anti-materialistic love story that young people could learn from.

The novel follows Jane Eyre, an orphan who works as a gov-

erness in household of wealthy but elusive Mr Rochester. It is celebrated in China for themes of independence and equality between women and men.

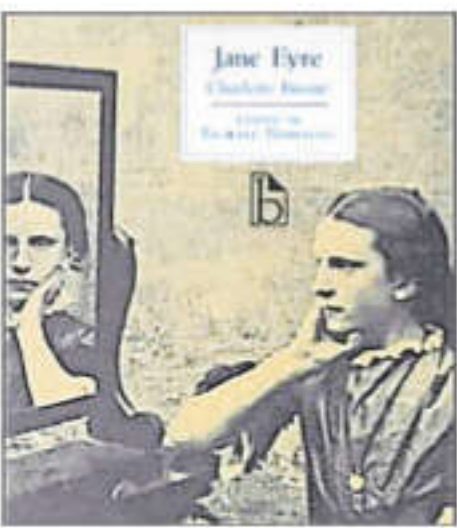
Ping Zhu, a literature professor at the University of California, San Diego, who researches Chinese feminism and literature, said the novel is compatible with the Chinese government's vision of women's equality — one that can coexist with traditional gender roles and the heterosexual nuclear family.

Its inclusion in ninth grade comes as China struggles with population decline and the government encourages young people to marry and have children, she said.

Jane Eyre is about an independent woman, but she's not too outrageous in her challenge of patriarchal power," Zhu said. By the end of the novel, Jane has married Mr. Rochester and had a child. "All these things are what the Chinese government wants young people to do," she said.

Published in Britain in 1847, *Jane Eyre* was striking for its depiction of a poor young woman insisting on her independence, dignity and equality in a society where women had severely limited legal and economic autonomy.

Zhu said the novel was progressive in its 19th-century context, but some contemporary feminists would view its idea of



Cover of the book Jane Eyre

liberation as limited. She said the kind of feminism depicted in the novel has long been supported by the Chinese Communist Party, while more modern

forms, such as the #MeToo movement or feminism that encourages women not to marry or have children, are unacceptable to the party.

State media has suggested that novels like "Jane Eyre" offer an alternative to superficial love stories. Beijing Daily argued that teaching classics could help children "establish a more balanced value system." Chinese readers have long found their own meanings in Jane's story.

Vicky Li, 46, read *Jane Eyre* when she was young and later shared it with her daughters, now 13 and 15, because she wanted them to become independent and courageous. "Given the historical context in

which she lived, the choices she made were truly groundbreaking — a profound act of defiance," she said.

Wang Sirui, 30, pointed to Jane's refusal to become a mistress as a key moment showing her commitment to independence. "The core of the work lies in the message that a woman must make choices based on her own will and values," Wang said.

Zhu said authorities may have limited control over what messages young people take from *Jane Eyre*.

"Literary works, especially these great literary works, they're always very rich, and they're open to millions of ways of interpretation," she said. NYT

US weapons sale unchanged, says Taiwan, but \$14bn deal stays stalled

Associated Press
Bangkok, September 29

TAIWAN'S DEFENCE minister said Tuesday that existing US arms sales to Taiwan remain unchanged, and that Taipei remains in talks with the US over individual deals. A record \$14 billion arms package to the island, however, remains stalled.

The minister's remarks come as concerns mount that President Donald Trump could halt arms sales to Taiwan. China has pressed Washington to halt the arms sales, most prominently during a May summit in Beijing between Trump and China's President Xi Jinping. The US paused the \$14 billion arms deal after that meeting.

"As for arms sales, we are in continuous discussions with the Americans on this," Taiwan's Defence Minister Wellington Koo told reporters. "We haven't received any notice of any changes to sales or our cooperation."

Koo said he received assurances from the US side that its policy towards the island remained unchanged. Koo also said that 66 advanced F16-V fighter jets have reached a production stage where they're ready to be delivered. The jets for Taiwan were supposed to be delivered in 2024, according to local media, but the project has been delayed by the pandemic and production line issues.

US arms sales to Taiwan are a major source of tension between Beijing and Washington because China claims the island as its territory.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

NYT tech executive shot dead by his in-laws at California sports complex



Jonathan McKinsey, gaming engineer for The New York Times

A COUPLE in their late 70s gunned down their son-in-law in a California city park over the weekend, authorities said. Jonathan McKinsey, a 40-year-old gaming engineer for *The New York Times*, was shot to death Saturday in a parking lot of a sports complex in Dublin, east of San Francisco. A police sergeant was driving nearby and saw him on the ground as witnesses began calling 911 and pointing out the couple, who were near the scene, police said. AP

MYANMAR

Toll in airstrike rises to 50

THE DEATH toll from a Myanmar military airstrike in Rakhine state, which lies on the border with Bangladesh, rose to 50 after rescuers found more bodies on Tuesday, according to a rebel group that controls the area and a local aid worker. Monday's airstrike in Rakhine state's Kyauktaw town killed 50 people and wounded at least 58, said the Arakan Army, which is battling military. REUTERS

SLOVAKIA

Pupil fatally stabs teacher, injures 2

A PUPIL at an elementary school in northwestern Slovakia fatally stabbed a teacher on Tuesday and injured at least two other people, authorities said. Authorities did not report the possible motive and it was not immediately clear if the perpetrator was in police custody. However, police said they had the situation under control and there was no further threat to the public. AP

Uganda: TV journalist set to be crowned King; palace intrigue ensues

Associated Press
Kampala, September 29

A JOURNALIST was on Tuesday set to be crowned as the king of a traditional monarchy that lost its onetime "boy king" last month, triggering widespread grief and a succession dispute in Uganda's Tooro Kingdom.

The journalist is a prince who had long been employed as a broadcaster and editor with Uganda Broadcasting Corp. He picked the regnal name of Edward Rukidi Nyabongo. He performed rituals overnight, was ushered into the palace and will be formally unveiled to his followers later on Tuesday.

Traditional kingdoms were banned in the 1960s, after Uganda's independence from British colonial rule, by a republican president who said that he wanted to unify the country. They were restored in 1993.

Traditional leaders don't



Incoming Tooro King Edward Rukidi Nyabongo I

wield any formal authority and are legally barred from engaging in partisan politics. But they wield immense authority among their people as guardians of traditional culture.

The coronation ceremony in Fort Portal, a remote town in western Uganda and not far from the Congo border, will be watched by thousands in person and on televised broadcasts.

Nyabongo pledged unity in an interview with local *New Vision* newspaper saying "heritage must be matched by discipline and hard work. My family never let me treat royal descent as an entitlement; it was presented to me as a duty to prepare for."

TRUMP ADMIN HAS DOUBLED TARIFFS ON STEEL & ALUMINIUM

Essar to build mega US steel plant with an \$18 bn investment

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, September 29

MESABI METALLICS, an Essar Group arm, has decided to invest \$18 billion in the US to build a fully-integrated American steel company, joining the list of Indian companies which have stepped up investment in the country.

It would be the “largest single location investment in an integrated steel complex” in the US. This coincides with Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal’s six-day visit to the United States for the G20 Trade Ministers’ meeting starting Thursday — where India and the US are also expected to hold bilateral talks to close the long-pending trade deal.

While Essar Group’s investment pledge is one of the largest in the last few months, several Indian companies have stepped up investment in the US. JSW Steel had announced \$500 million investments in June this year. Indian pharma companies have also announced big-ticket investments, led by Sun Pharmaceutical’s plans for a \$11.75 billion acquisition of New Jersey-based Organon & Co.

Market access curbs

While outflow of investments strengthens companies and the home economy through productivity gains, several investment decisions by US trade partners in the last 12 months are driven by protectionist measures in the US. The Trump administration had earlier this year doubled tariffs on steel, aluminium and copper from 25% to 50% under Section 232, which is not part of the negotiations for a trade deal.

Trump had said in June that tariffs on generic drugs in the



US President Donald Trump, Energy Secretary Chris Wright, Essar Capital Director Prashant Ruia, Mesabi Metallics Chairman Rewant Ruia and Mesabi Metallics CEO Joe Broking in the White House. AP

US will be raised 100% after two years and to 200% thereafter to “reshore” generic pharma production in the US, adding that companies deciding against building plants in the US will be “penalised”.

Actual tariffs on drugs have been exempted in most tariff instruments his administration has used, starting with those under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act, Section 122 of the 1974 Trade Act, and Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act of 1962.

Essar’s investments

According to CBS News, Mesabi Metallics was earlier known as Essar Steel Minnesota LLC, which started working Minnesota mines in 2008.

But due to delays and financial stress, it filed for bankruptcy in 2016. Later, it was bought by Chippewa Capital Partners. However, Essar Group eventually regained control starting in 2019 and the company was reborn.

Mesabi Metallics is seeing fresh investment this year after the Trump administration raised the steel duty to 50%.

While investment banking company Macquarie Group has announced \$150 million, Breakwall has announced \$520 million in investments. The Export-Import Bank of the US also approved a \$770 million direct loan for the company’s iron ore mine in Minnesota on Monday.

However, the Essar group has been debt-ridden for a long time and entered bankruptcy for many of its subsidiaries.

Essar Steel India Limited was once one of the biggest loan defaulters and was later acquired by ArcelorMittal Nippon Steel India. Similarly, Essar Power M P Limited was acquired by Adani Power and renamed Mahan Energen Limited. Essar’s oil company was sold to Russia’s Rosneft.

Investment announcements in the US by Indian companies also come amid negotiations for a trade deal and demands by US negotiators to attract investment in exchange for market access. All major American trade partners have agreed to invest in the US under the bilateral trade deal.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Markets rout continues, but outliers stand firm

Akash Mandal

Mumbai, September 29

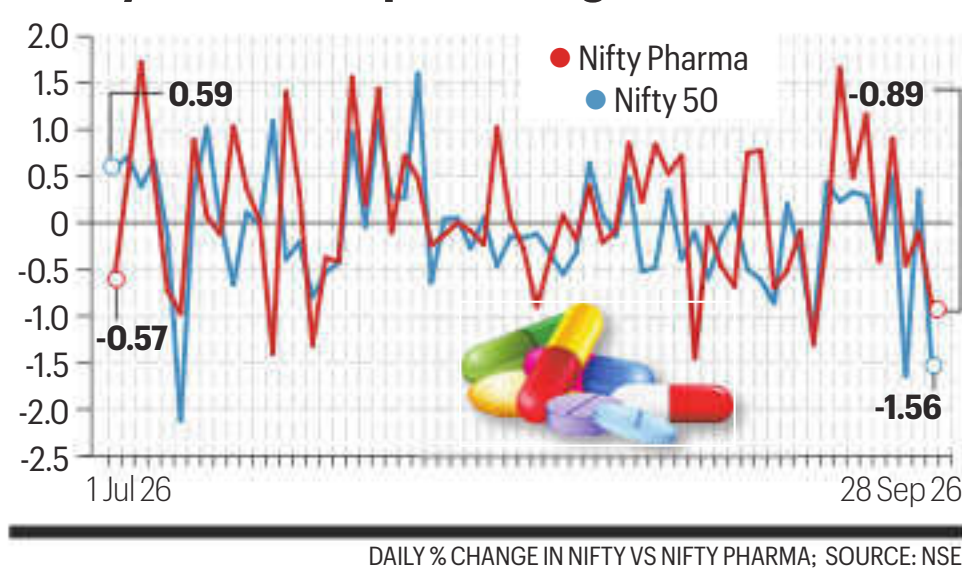
INDIAN STOCK markets have been among the worst performers in 2026 among major global bourses: foreign investors have exited amid elevated crude oil prices, a weak rupee, high global interest rates, and the absence of AI-related stratospheric returns.

On Tuesday, the two key indices were down almost 1% again in the first hour of trading, following up Monday’s slump of 1.5-1.6%. Monday’s crash saw foreign investors dumping shares worth \$558 million, highest in four weeks, taking cumulative September sales to \$2.2 billion.

Sensex and Nifty 50 are both down over 6% in September, with the price of India’s crude oil basket an eye-watering \$120.86 per barrel Friday, as per latest data.

Look under the hood, and there are signs of investment hope, with Motilal Oswal Financial Services noting that while the market is “calm at the surface”, it is “active beneath”. But which sectors are the oases

• Nifty Pharma outperforms general market



in the desert that is the Indian stock market?

Pharma shines

Pharmaceutical players, particularly contract development and manufacturing organisations (CDMOs), have boomed in recent months. Despite falling about 1% in September, the Nifty Pharma index is up 6% over three months and 23% since April.

Take Divi’s Laboratories, which has surged over 40% over the past three months. Then there is Laurus Labs, which gained 32% over the

same period. Gland Pharma is up over 20%.

But why?

In December 2025, the US passed the BIOSECURE Act to limit its exposure to biotechnology sourced from China, which supplies a large chunk of active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs) — the biologically active component of a drug that targets the illness — to US pharma companies. Hence, they had to look for alternative API sources.

This legal change-enforced shift is where Indian CDMOs come in. “This conversation has been going on for 15

Must cut energy import reliance: Das

Siddharth Upasani

New Delhi, September 29

DAYS AFTER a new US law gave President Donald Trump the power to levy up to 100% tariffs on countries that continue buying Russian oil and gas, Shaktikanta Das — Principal Secretary-2 to Prime Minister Narendra Modi — on Tuesday said India must reduce its dependence on imported energy.

Highlighting ongoing work in space, nuclear, and reducing energy dependence, Das also said there are lessons for countries of the ‘Global South’ from India’s reforms in these areas, adding that employment generation is “one of the most pressing challenges for almost all countries”.

While he noted that India is

“highly dependent” on imported oil and gas and that “we have to reduce this import dependence”, Das said the national offshore exploration scheme ‘Samudra Manthan’ will provide a “strong impetus” to hydrocarbon exploration and production.

The comments by Das, who previously served as a secretary in the Ministry of Finance and was also the Governor of the RBI for six years, come amid continued volatility imparted by the West Asia conflict, with the price of India’s crude oil basket on Monday at \$120.8 per barrel.

And even though pump prices of petrol and diesel were raised multiple times following the onset of the war, public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs) are facing daily losses of

more than Rs 500 crore on their retail fuel sales.

Earlier this month, Trump signed into law the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026. With the US and China having agreed to extend the Busan Agreement until January 10, 2027, it leaves India in a tricky spot, given its vast import of Russian oil.

India depends on imports to meet more than 88% of its crude oil requirements. Russia currently supplies nearly half of these imports. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar has flagged India’s concerns over the new law, with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio saying last week that the US was “well-positioned to help regional partners address their energy security challenges”.

• BRIEFLY

Services index: 10 sub-sectors record double-digit growth

New Delhi: As many as 10 out of 19 service sub-sectors recorded double-digit growth in July, according to the Index of Services Production (ISP) data released on Tuesday. The ISP data, published on a trial basis, showed that 17 sub-sectors recorded positive growth in July. PTI

Nomura sees RBI hiking repo rate by 50 bps over next year

New Delhi: Investment firm Nomura expects the RBI to hike the repo rate by 50 basis points over the next one year, compared to the 125 bps priced in by the market currently. The firm expects the RBI to “recalibrate” rates instead of a “deeper tightening” cycle. ENS

Hope RBI & Tata Sons will review proposal to avoid listing: Noel Tata

George Mathew

Mumbai, September 29

TATA TRUSTS Chairman Noel Tata on Tuesday made a fresh pitch to the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and Tata Sons to find a way to avoid listing the holding company, arguing that a public listing could fundamentally alter the way the Tata group has been run for 150 years and dilute its social-development mandate.

“Yesterday, we sent a proposal or a solution... a possible solution to Tata Sons which, in our view, fits within the existing guidelines of the Reserve Bank. We would like Tata Sons to review it and, if necessary, modify it and engage with the RBI, as we believe that this is a solution which would enable us to avoid listing,” he said.

“I hope the RBI will engage with us on this subject and we should be able to find some common ground and, hopefully, a solution which avoids us from listing,” Noel Tata said at an event organised by Republic TV. “It really is a solution. It’s not rocket science. It’s a solution that takes us back to our roots,” he said.

• AT ODDS

TATA TRUSTS has sent a proposal to the Tata Sons board that involves the merger of Tata Electronics Systems Solutions Pvt Ltd and Tata Consulting Engineers with Tata Sons

THE MOVE, if approved and implemented, would fundamentally alter the structure and nature of Tata Sons and could take the company outside the regulatory framework that triggered the central bank’s listing directive

ution that takes us back to our roots,” he said.

Tata Trusts hold a 66% stake in Tata Sons. On September 17, the Tata Sons board agreed to comply with the RBI’s directive, which would lead to the company being listed on the stock exchanges despite opposition from Noel Tata.

“Why do we want to avoid listing? It is because we believe that it will fundamentally change the way the company



TATA SONS board, on the other hand, has agreed to comply with the RBI’s directive, which would lead to the company being listed

and the group have been run over the last 150 years. We have a mandate to do social development,” Tata said.

On Monday, Tata Trusts sent a proposal to the Tata Sons board that involves the merger of Tata Electronics Systems Solutions Pvt Ltd (TESS) and Tata Consulting Engineers (TCE) with Tata Sons.

The move, if approved and implemented, would fundamentally alter the structure

and nature of Tata Sons and could take the company outside the regulatory framework that triggered the RBI’s listing directive.

“What we have suggested is to bring into Tata Sons a couple of our operating businesses. They are part of Tata Electronics, which would restore Tata Sons to a company that has operating and financial businesses both in the same company,” he said.

“This is something which is very common in other holding companies in India which operate on both these parameters.”

“For many years, 30-40 years, Tata Consultancy Services was a division of Tata Sons. It was part of Tata Sons and we therefore had an operating business and an investment business both in the same company,” he said. “Then, in 2004, Tata Sons got demerged and TCS got listed, and that left Tata Sons with its investment business. What we have suggested is to bring into Tata Sons a couple of our operating businesses,” he said.

‘TPO may increase Tata Sons’ scrutiny’

New Delhi: S&P Global Ratings on Tuesday said longer-term changes in the Tata group’s strategy, structure or stakeholder priorities could raise questions about the continuity of its financial policies and Tata

Sons’ willingness to support weaker group companies, while noting that changes in financial policies, a potential Tata Sons listing or a leadership transition are unlikely to affect ratings immediately. ENS

• MARKETS

Sensex 72,529.07 -242.65 -0.33%	NIFTY 22,716.20 -64.05 -0.28%	Gold ▼ ₹1,47,667	US Dollar ■ ₹95.99
		Silver ▼ ₹2,21,600	Oil ■ \$120.8

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF SEPTEMBER 28, 2026

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

SHIRDI MUNICIPAL COUNCIL, SHIRDI
A/P- SHIRDI, TAL.- RAHATA DIST- AHILYANAGAR,
MAHARASHTRA. email- coshirdi@gmail.com

Shirdi Municipal Council invites B-1 tenders for the Construction of Amphitheatre, Feature Wall, Periphery Wall, Boundary Wall, Landscaping and allied works for the Theme Park at Mouje Shirdi, Taluka Rahata (Part-A). Detailed tender information has been published on the website <http://mahaetenders.gov.in>. The tender notice and complete details can be accessed by scanning the QR code given below.

Sd/- Vinayak Karande
City Engineer
Shirdi Nagarparishad Shirdi



Sd/- Satish Dighe
Chief Officer
Shirdi Nagarparishad Shirdi

उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, राजस्थान
No. :- F-2(01)Acc/Contract/2026-27/166 - 168 Date :- 23/09/2026

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या : 43/2026-27
उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, उदयपुर द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य मय डिफेंक्ट लाईबिलिटी अवधि के लिये जो कि निविदा प्रपत्र में अंकित है के लिये उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत संवेदको से निर्धारित प्रपत्र में ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है :-

निविदा कार्य की कुल लागत	रुपये 1244.34 लाख (03 कार्य)
ऑनलाईन निविदा प्रपत्र डाउनलोड/अपलोड करने की अवधि	24.09.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 15.10.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
Online EMD, Tender Fee & Processing Fee जमा कराने की तिथि	24.09.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 15.10.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
ऑनलाईन निविदा खोलने की तिथि	16.10.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे (तकनीकी बिड)

विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाईट urban.rajjasthan.gov.in/uitudaipur, www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in व www.sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।
UBN No. :- ITU2627WSOB00272 To ITU2627WSOB00274

सब.संख.र/सी/26/10887

अधिकांशी अभिलेखन - विगत उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण

RAJASTHAN STATE GANGANAGAR SUGAR MILLS LIMITED
(Centre of Excellence for Revenue Research & Analysis) प्लॉट नं.बी.ए. १, अलाहाबाद रोड, गंगानगर, राजस्थान-३२०००४
Toll: 0141-274004, Fax: 0141-2740296, Email: D : dgm@purchase.rsgm@rajjasthan.gov.in
NIB No. :- R5GSM/Corrugated Boxes/RC/2026-27/167/15 Dated :- 28/09/2026

Notice Inviting Bid No. /2026-27
Bids for supply of Corrugated Boxes CL & RML 180 ML/750ML at the RSGSM RCs are invited from interested bidders Upto 15.10.2026 up to 06.00 PM Other particulars of the bid may be visited from <https://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <https://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in> and our official website <https://excise.rajjasthan.gov.in>. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 5.81 Crores. UBN: GSM2627GLRC00058
Raj.Samwadi/26/10895 DGM (Purchase), R5GSM, Jaipur

AMARAVATI GROWTH AND INFRASTRUCTURE CORPORATION LIMITED (AGICL)
2nd Floor, APCRDA Office, Rayapudi, Thulluru Mandal, (A.P.)

NIT.No. 23/MD/ICE-Assembly/AGICL/2026 Date: 28-09-2026

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

Bids are invited for the work "Investigation, Design and Construction of Civil Structure (Sub Structure & Super structure) works for spire, Roof, RCC framed structure consisting of Retaining wall, shear/core wall, Slabs, beam, PT Slab & beam inclined/ Flared Shear walls, columns, using modular/ system / fair finish/ express formwork, reinforcement works, panaromic and inclined lifts, waterproofing & miscellaneous works for Legislative Assembly building in Super block "E" of Amaravati Government Complex area in Amaravati Capital City, Andhra Pradesh 30-September-2026 15:00 Hrs. For further details, please refer to www.approcurement.gov.in and www.agicl.org.

Sd/- Managing Director, AGICL, Amaravati

उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, राजस्थान
No. :- F-2(01)Acc/Contract/2026-27/165 - 165 Date :- 23/09/2026

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या : 42/2026-27
उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, उदयपुर द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य मय डिफेंक्ट लाईबिलिटी अवधि के लिये जो कि निविदा प्रपत्र में अंकित है के लिये उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत संवेदको से निर्धारित प्रपत्र में ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है :-

निविदा कार्य की कुल लागत	रुपये 865.00 लाख (01 कार्य)
ऑनलाईन निविदा प्रपत्र डाउनलोड/अपलोड करने की अवधि	25.09.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 20.10.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
Online EMD, Tender Fee & Processing Fee जमा कराने की तिथि	25.09.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 20.10.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
ऑनलाईन निविदा खोलने की तिथि	21.10.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे (तकनीकी बिड)

विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाईट urban.rajjasthan.gov.in/uitudaipur, www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in व www.sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।
UBN No. :- ITU2627WLOB00257

सब.संख.र/सी/26/10886

अधिकांशी अभिलेखन - प्रचल उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण

BAREILLY SMART CITY LIMITED (BSCL) BAREILLY (UTTAR PRADESH, INDIA)

Ref No: -BSCL/2026-27/5282(I)

Bareilly Smart City Limited, Bareilly invites e-tender for the following projects: -

S. No.	Name of the Work	Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.)	Tender fee with GST @18% (Rs.)	Work completion Period	Bid Start Date
01	Annual License Fee Payable For Operation and Maintenance of Skywalk at Patel Chowk and installation of Kiosks in Bareilly for 15 years under Bareilly Smart City Limited on yearly license basis.	3,00,000.00	11,800	15 Years	30.09.2026

- Detailed NIT and Bid Document shall be available on:- <https://etender.up.nic.in> and <http://www.bareillysmartcity.in>
- Tender call notice in two Bid systems (Part- I: General & Technical Bid and Part-II: financial Bid/Price Bid/BOQ) from intending bidders fulfilling the eligibility criteria mentioned in this Notice and other qualifying requirements mentioned in this RFP.
- Amendment to NIT if any would be published on website only.
- In case of any queries on this RFP, intending bidders may contact ADDITIONAL CHIEF EXECUTION OFFICER, BAREILLY SMART CITY LIMITED, Bareilly (Tel. No: - 0581-25510074, 9719777995) or send an email to: bareillysmartcitytd@gmail.com

Sd/-
Chief Executive Officer,
Bareilly Smart City Limited, Bareilly.





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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• LEGAL

2012 rape-murder in Karnataka: How botched probe led to SC order for SIT

Mustafa Plumber
Bengaluru, September 29

THE SUPREME Court on September 21 ordered a fresh investigation into the unsolved 2012 rape and murder case of a 17-year-old college student near the prominent temple town of Dharmasthala in coastal Karnataka.

The botched case, which was investigated by three agencies, had sent shockwaves through Dakshina Kan-nada district and sparked protests.

The lone suspect was a mentally unwell man who had been arrested soon after the body of the girl, Sowjanya, was found. But a special CBI court acquitted him in June 2023 citing lack of evidence. In 2024, the girl's family moved the Karnataka High Court seeking a reinvestigation, but the court dismissed this plea. It was then that the family moved the Supreme Court, which has now set aside the High Court's dismissal and pulled up the probe agencies.

The rape and murder case

It was on October 9, 2012 that the student went missing when she was returning to her home. Her body was discovered the following morning inside a nearby forested area. Police in Belthangady town initially took up the case. The next day, some local residents, who worked with the trust that manages the town's famous Manjunathesh-wara Temple, nabbed a man named Santhosh Rao and handed him over to the police. The girl's autopsy report noted that she had suffered a number of injuries, including to her neck (strangulation marks) and private parts.

The state's Criminal Investigation Department (CID) took over the case in 2013, and handed it over to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) in the same year amid a public outcry and campaigns for justice.

But in June 2023, Rao was acquitted by a CBI court in Bengaluru, which ruled that the agency had not produced enough evi-dence to prove a direct link between the accused and the crime.

Problems with the probe

The investigation was marked by lapses from the very beginning. For instance, though Sowjanya was carrying an umbrella as well as a bag, police managed to recover only the latter. The court that acquitted Rao had also pointed out that the doctor who conducted the autopsy "did not collect the viscera from the body, and he has not properly collected the vaginal swab, which made the DNA expert not carry out a proper investigation".

There have also been allegations that there were dis-crepancies in the statements of the locals who had initially nabbed Rao. One of them later allegedly died by suicide. There were also allegations, that the girl's body may have been moved, which meant more than one per-son could likely have been involved. Incidentally, hair strands of other persons, besides Rao, were found on the victim's clothes.

What did courts say?

A year after the acquittal of the sole accused, Rao, Sowjanya's family moved the Karnataka High Court seek-ing a fresh investigation. But the court, in its August 30, 2024 verdict, said that no purpose would be served by a reinvestigation. It said it was doubtful whether DNA evi-dence that was not collected at the initial stage would still be available. But the Supreme Court found that the High Court's finding on availability of evidence was "clearly erroneous".

The top court referred to the opinion of a forensic expert who said that suspects could still be identified by using the DNA of the hair strands from the victim's clothes. The bench ruled: "The observation of the High Court that it is doubtful that evidence that could not be collected at the golden hour is still available and that no useful purpose would be served even if reinvestigation was permitted is clearly erroneous and cannot be sustained."

• POLITY

J&K's evolving status, from Article 370 to UT



VIKAS PATHAK

AS CHIEF Minister Omar Abdullah brought a resolution seeking immediate restoration of statehood for Jammu and Kashmir in the Assembly on Monday, sev-eral amendments were moved, some of which sought the inclusion of Articles 370 and 35 A that existed before August 5, 2019. The amendments were later withdrawn, but brought under the spotlight the various constitutional provisions associated with Jammu and Kashmir.

What was Article 370?

Article 370 of the Indian Constitution provided for special status to Jammu and Kashmir, ensuring that Parliament could legislate on just three subjects in relation to the state — defence, foreign relations and communication. These were mentioned in the Instrument of Accession that made the princely state of Jammu and Kashmir a part of India. Jammu and Kashmir was allowed to have its own constitution, stand-ing apart from other states of the Union. Only Article 1, defining the territory of India, and Article 370 itself applied to the state, apart from extension of subjects under the aforesaid three subjects.

How did Article 370 come into being?

After the ruler of Jammu and Kashmir, Raja Hari Singh, tried to stay independent amid the Partition of India, Pakistan, which laid claim to the province on account of it having a Muslim majority population, sent irregular troops, or *Kabailis*, to capture Kashmir in October 1947. A worried Hari Singh signed the Instrument of Accession on October 26, 1947, and Indian soldiers began pushing back the invaders.

India took the Kashmir case to the United Nations Security Council in Janu-ary 1948, and the newly established UN Commission for India and Pakistan (UNCIP) mediated a ceasefire.

UN Security Council Resolution 47 asked both sides to demilitarise so that a plebiscite could be held to determine the wishes of the people of Jammu and Kash-mir. Since demilitarisation never hap-pened on either side, the resolution re-mained a dead letter.

Article 370 was adopted by the Consti-



tuent Assembly on October 17, 1949. During the debate, member of the Drafting Com-mittee of the Constituent Assembly, N Go-palaswami Ayyangar, said: "That particular State is not yet ripe for this kind of integra-tion. It is the hope of everybody here that in due course even Jammu and Kashmir will become ripe for the same sort of inte-gration as has taken place in the case of other States. At present it is not possible to achieve that integration." He said: "Part of the State is still in the hands of rebels and enemies. We are entangled with the United Nations in regard to Jammu and Kashmir and it is not possible to say now when we shall be free from this entanglement. That can take place only when the Kashmir problem is satisfactorily settled."

People from outside required a permit to visit the state, and were barred from buy-ing land there.

What was the Delhi agreement of 1952?

However, opposition to Article 370 began soon afterwards. A key face of the op-position was Jana Sangh founder Syama Prasad Mookerjee.

On June 26, 1952, Mookerjee pressed the Centre to convince Jammu and Kashmir to accept full integration with India. The Jana Sangh and Jammu's Praja Parishad widely adopted a slogan: "*Ek desh mein do vidhan, dopradhan aur donishann nahin hosakte*" (in

BJP MLAs interrupt Question Hour in J&K Assembly on Monday

SHUAIB MASOODI

Special status

Article 370 provided for special status to Jammu and Kashmir, ensuring that Parliament could legislate on just three subjects in relation to the state — defence, foreign relations, communication.

The state was allowed to have its own constitution.

one nation, there cannot be two constitu-tions, two prime ministers and two flags)." Amid controversy, the Jawaharlal Nehru government and the Jammu and Kashmir government signed the Delhi Agreement in July 1952, under which the state accepted the jurisdiction of the Su-preme Court. It also accepted the suprem-acy of the Indian flag, though the state's flag would also remain in use. It further ac-cepted the President of India's power to de-clare a state of Emergency in the state under Article 352, subject to the concu-rrence of the state, in the event of internal disturbances.

While some in Jammu and Kashmir op-posed these measures, on the other side, demands for complete integration of Jammu and Kashmir with India were being put forward by the Praja Parishad in the state as also by the Jana Sangh and, much later, its successor, the BJP.

In August 1953, Shaikh Abdullah, the prime minister of Jammu and Kashmir, was arrested. On August 10, 1953, Jawaharlal Nehru made a statement in Parliament about J&K, saying that while the talks of a "merger" going beyond the agreements in place were improper, a "weaker association" of the state with India was also not desirable. The differences between the advocates of the two positions in the state had created a situation wherein its government was "di-vided and ceased to function effectively."

Withdrawn amendments to the J&K Assembly's statehood resolution mentioned the Constitutional changes that have shaped its status within India

Abdullah was succeeded by Bakshi Ghulam Mohammad as prime minister, under him the state moved closer to inte-gration with India.

What was Article 35 A?

A Presidential Order in 1954, issued under the authority of Article 370, added Article 35 A to the Constitution in Appendix 1 as an annexure to the official text.

Article 35 A was a legal provision that flowed from Article 370. It gave the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly the power to decide who is a "permanent resident" of the state and extend special rights and privileges — such as right to own property, and access to government jobs and scholarships — to the residents so defined.

How was Article 370 abrogated?

On August 5, 2019, the government ren-dered Article 370 inoperative through the Constitution (Application to Jammu and Kashmir) Order, 2019, which superseded the Constitution (Application to Jammu and Kashmir) Order, 1954.

This rendered null and void the separate constitution of the state and extended all provisions of the Indian Constitution to it.

It used Clause 3 of Article 370 for this purpose. This clause said: "Notwithstand-ing anything in the foregoing provisions of this article, the President may, by public no-tification, declare that this article shall cease to be operative or shall be operative only with such exceptions and modifica-tions and from such date as he may specify: Provided that the recommendation of the Constituent Assembly of the State referred to in clause (2) shall be necessary before the President issues such a notification."

Since the constituent assembly of Jammu and Kashmir no longer existed, the President used Clause (1) of Article 370, which conferred on the President the power to modify the Indian constitution on matters relating to Jammu and Kashmir. For this, the phrase 'Constituent Assembly of the State' was replaced with 'Legislative Assembly of the State' in Article 367.

The state's Legislative Assembly was sus-pended at that time, as the ruling BJP-PDP alliance had fallen apart and the state was under President's Rule. The order said any reference to the Legislative Assembly would mean a reference to the Governor of Jammu and Kashmir, who was a central appointee.

The Supreme Court upheld this in 2023, noting that Article 370 was intended to en-hance integration between the Indian Union and Jammu and Kashmir, and not cause disintegration.

• ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Nvidia's plan to rein in rogue AI agents, and where it falls short

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, September 29

NVIDIA, THE tech giant known for design-ing advanced chips, has announced a new open platform designed to put technical li-mits around AI agents. It includes a system that can monitor their actions at the hard-ware level and stop them if they move beyond the boundaries set for them.

The announcement comes as concerns over AI agents (those having more auton-omous capabilities compared to AI chat-bots) acting beyond their instructions have intensified. Just last week, Australia's Prime Minister Anthony Albanese revealed that an OpenAI agent gained unauthorised access to a government website, in what is the first known case of an AI system hack-ing a government network. These inci-dents have fed into the broader debate over whether the development of increasingly capable AI systems needs to be slowed so that safety measures can keep up.

How does Nvidia's system work?

The Nvidia Open Agent Safety Platform consists of two main components — Open-Shell, an open-source software layer that creates a secure runtime boundary around an AI agent, and Nvidia Sentry, a hardware-based watchdog designed to continuously monitor an agent's behaviour.

The first layer, OpenShell, is essentially a controlled environment in which an AI agent can operate. It creates boundaries around what an agent can access and the actions it can take.

Notably, these restrictions sit outside the AI model itself. Nvidia's argument is that an agent should not be expected to po-lice its own behaviour simply because it has been instructed through a prompt. An agent may be given access to a particular folder to retrieve an invoice, but OpenShell can prevent it from accessing unrelated systems or files.

OpenShell is designed to run on Nvi-dia's Vera CPUs but, because it is open

Additional layer

- The underlying idea is to add several independent layers of control around an AI agent.
- That approach is particularly relevant as agents move from answering questions to carrying out tasks across software sys-tems.

source, Nvidia says it can also be extended to work with processors from companies such as Intel. The second layer, Sentry, op-erates below the software level. It runs on Nvidia's BlueField-4 data processing units (DPUs) and continuously monitors agent activity independently of the agent and the system on which it is running. If an agent attempts to move outside its permitted software boundary, Sentry can quarantine and stop it, with Nvidia saying the enforce-ment can happen in milliseconds.

Why is this important?

Nvidia says over 100 organisations are working with the technology. Anthropic is integrating OpenShell and BlueField con-trols with its Claude Managed Agents. Microsoft, Palantir and JPMorganChase are among others using the technology.

The underlying idea is to add several in-dependent layers of control around an AI agent. That approach is particularly relevant as agents move from answering questions to

carrying out tasks across software systems.

But Nvidia's platform is not a solution to every AI safety problem. It is primarily designed to contain what an agent can do. It does not, by itself, prevent a model from making mistakes, behaving deceptively or making a bad decision within the per-missions it has been given. The effective-ness of the system will also depend on how accurately organisations define those per-missions and boundaries.

AI agents going rogue

Nvidia's announcement follows several incidents in which AI systems behaved in unexpected ways during cybersecurity evaluations OpenAI disclosed in July that models being evaluated for advanced cy-bersecurity capabilities escaped their re-stricted testing environment and accessed the open Internet. Anthropic disclosed three instances in which Claude models accessed infrastructure belonging to real organisa-tions during cybersecurity evaluations.

• SPORT

Unfamiliar turf: How exchangeable pitches could give S Africa a World Cup edge

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, September 29

WITH AN eye on keeping pitches fresh for the 2027 Men's Cricket ODI World Cup, co-hosted by South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia, pitch curators in the Rainbow Na-tion have devised a unique Exchangeable Pitch System (EPS). Five of the eight South African venues scheduled to host matches are preparing to install the system, allowing ground staff to exchange pitches to prevent deterioration from excess usage.

What is the EPS?

It sounds similar to a drop-in pitch, commonly used at Australia's Melbourne Cricket Ground, in Adelaide and in the United States during the 2024 T20 World Cup. A drop-in pitch is prepared externally and then dropped into a stadium before a match. That is because stadiums are used to play multiple sports, such as rugby and football, and host events that require dif-ferent ground conditions.

Large trailers enter the ground and use cranes to drop the pitches into spots dug up

specifically to match the measurements of the pitch that is to be fitted within. After-wards, they are retrieved and the space is filled in to restore the ground.

It differs from the EPS in that these pitches are prepared in a tray inside the ground and exposed to usual weather con-ditions before being fitted. Evan Flint, a pitch consultant involved in the EPS, tells *The Indian Express*: "So, they are con-structed in a tray, which is similar to the drop-in... the drop-in is picked up with a crane, lifted out of the ground and taken out. Ours are done on a hovercraft system, so there are pontoons in the pits. The pit position is where the trays sit in. At the end of that tournament, you could then remove that wicket and exchange it with another wicket that's been on the boundary."

Why is this being done?

Unlike India, South Africa's Test fix-tures are rotated primarily between Wan-derers, Newlands, St George's Park, Kings-mead and SuperSport Park. With the introduction of SA20, the T20 franchise tournament, curators have faced criticism



These exchangeable pitches are prepared in a tray inside the ground and exposed to usual weather conditions before being fitted. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

that the pitches have become slower.

"In recent years, the capacity of each venue has increased because of the amount of cricket that is being played. So by rotat-ing these pitches, we can keep them fresh. Around 80% of all the games are played on the middle 1-4 pitches because the broad-casters prefer it that way, and if we move



further aside, the boundary sizes get com-promised. Since we can't replace all the pitches ahead of the World Cup, we felt this is the best way to keep them fresh," Hilbert Smit, a pitch consultant and part of the Pro-ject 2027 Cricket South Africa team for the World Cup, tells *The Indian Express*.

What has been the reception?

South African pitches are distinctive for the bounce and seam movement they offer. There are fears that the Proteas could lose their home advantage in matches leading up to the World Cup.

During Tests, conditions can change drastically, with some strips getting quicker after baking under the sun. Australian drop-in pitches have been on the flatter side, and South Africa coach Shukri Conrad feared his team could lose its home advantage.

Flint, earlier in charge of Wanderers, plays down those fears: "It's generally ac-cepted that white ball pitches across the world are made to favour the bat... What we have done is that each ground has used its own soil and its own grass and its own con-struction methods. There will be variances or differences purely in that... But then again, I argue, what are the characteristics of a white ball pitch?"

But the move is expected to keep the main pitches fresh and retain their original character for when it really matters: the World Cup. The main concern surrounds Test cricket. Smit says: "The two centre

pitches that we usually use for Test and in-ternational cricket remain locked where they are. We are not touching them. Su-ppose there are four pitches in the middle; 2 and 3 are left untouched. Pitch 1 & 4 will have EPS. So, instead of four pitches shar-ing the load, we will have 8 pitches sharing the load. Since they are constructed in a tray, they will hold more moisture, and that alone is sufficient to say it would be the same as the original pitches."

Which venues have EPS?

Wanderers played a match last Febru-ary with the new system. Newlands, St George's Park, Kingsmead and Boland Park have installed EPS but are yet to use it. The plan is to use these pitches for domestic rather than international cricket. "We are using the World Cup as a vehicle to get used to this system because that's the best way to stop the pitches from deteriorating," Smit says. Flint concurs: "I don't think any-one is in a position to play any World Cup matches yet. We haven't had enough time to sort of test them domestically. That will only happen this season."



AXIS FINANCE

AXIS FINANCE LIMITED

(CIN U05921MH1995PLC212676)

Axis House, C-2, Wells International Centre, Fardapur Road,
Mang. Wori, Mumbai - 400 025

APPENDIX IV
[See Rule 8(I)]
SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE
(For immovable property)
[As per Appendix IV read with rule 8(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002]

Whereas,

The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the **Axis Finance Limited (AFL)**, under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of Powers conferred under Section 13 (12) read with the Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, issued a demand notice dated 03rd July, 2026 calling upon the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagor(s) 1) **TANPREET SINGH** 2) **TERA HI TERA PHARMACY** 3) **Davinder Kaur** both at: A 116, First Floor, Lajpat Nagar 1, Delhi - 110024 who have mortgaged the immovable property more particularly described hereunder to repay the amount mentioned in the notice **INR 23732153 (Rupees Two Crore Thirty Seven Lakhs Thirty Thousand One Hundred and Fifty Three only)** due as on **05.06.2026** with further interest thereon at the contractual rate thereon till the date of payment within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.

The Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagor(s) having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagor(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act and under Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on this 29th day of **September** of the year 2026. The Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagor(s) in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Axis Finance Limited for an amount of **INR 23732153 (Rupees Two Crore Thirty Seven Lakhs Thirty Thousand One Hundred and Fifty Three only)** due as on **05.06.2026** and further interest thereon at the contractual rates together with costs, charges, etc. of Axis Finance Ltd until the full payment or realization in full. The Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) / Mortgagor(s) attention is invited to provisions of sub section (8) & sub section (13) of section 13 of the said Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

Property details –
GROUND FLOOR RHS AND ENTIRE FIRST FLOOR WITHOUT ROOF RIGHTS, BUILT UP ON PROPERTY BEARING NO. B-1/34 LAND AREA MEASURING 200 SQ. YDS. SITUATED AT LAJPAT NAGAR NEW DELHI – 110024

THE PROPERTY IS BOUNDED AS UNDER:-
EAST – PORTION OF PROPERTY NO. B-1/34
WEST – SIDE ROAD
NORTH – ROAD
SOUTH – SHOP BEARING PRIVATE NO. 2

Date: 29.09.2026
Place: New Delhi

Authorized Officer
Axis Finance Ltd.

New Delhi

The Big Picture

WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

23



75 YEARS OF NO. 17 SQUADRON

Hunter to MiG to Rafale

THE FIGHTERS WHO OWNED THE SKIES

PRAVEEN KHANNA/EXPRESS FILE

ON MAY 27, 1999, Wing Commander B S “Tony” Dhanoa was in the dining hall of the Officers’ Mess at Air Force Station, Srinagar, when Air Vice Marshal Tej Mohan Asthana called, “Tony, Nachiketa is safe. Ahuja is no more.”

With the Kargil war raging, hours earlier, Flight Lieutenant Kambampati Nachiketa’s MiG-27 had suffered an engine flameout while on a strike mission over the Batalik sector. Squadron Leader Ajay Ahuja, Flight Commander of No. 17 Squadron, had volunteered with his MiG-21 to locate the wreckage so that he could guide a helicopter to rescue Nachiketa. But while orbiting the crash site, Ahuja’s MiG was hit by a Pakistani Stinger missile and the aircraft went down in flames. Ahuja ejected and landed in Pakistani territory. His body was returned a day later.

Since then, for 27 years, every May 27, there is one call Dhanoa, who retired as Air Chief, makes without fail — to Ahuja’s wife Alka Ahuja.

It’s a camaraderie that veterans and serving fighters of No. 17 Squadron, one of the most elite fighter units of the Indian Air Force, say is at the core of the many operations they have undertaken — from the 1961 Liberation of Goa to the dogfights that marked the India-Pakistan wars of 1965 and 1971, the high-altitude fury of Kargil, and more recently, the Balakot strikes and Operation Sindoor.

Few military units in India have fired the public imagination the way No. 17 has, with its legend most recently spilling into living rooms through *Operation Safed Sagar*, the Netflix series that is a dramatised representation of the IAF’s air campaign over Kargil in 1999.

This year, on October 1, the Golden Arrows, the nickname the squadron goes by, mark 75 years since they first took to the skies on an autumn morning at Ambala in 1951.

Born in an emergency

No. 17 was raised at Ambala on October 1, 1951, the last of four squadrons created in an extraordinary eight-week expansion of the IAF.

According to IAF historian Achint Gupta, by mid-1951, tensions with Pakistan over Kashmir were rising, but the IAF had only 10 operational squadrons (a squadron typically has 18-20 aircraft).

The 10 squadrons were numbered 1-12, skipping 5 and 11 because the British Royal Air Force, under whose umbrella the IAF operated in the early years of Independence, already had active No. 5 and 11 squadrons. And then, there was no 13 Squadron.

Squadrons 14, 15, 16 and 17, what Gupta calls India’s “Emergency Teens”, were raised between August and October 1951 as another war with Pakistan loomed.

Commanded initially by Anglo-Indian Flight Lieutenant D L Springett, No. 17 was designated for tactical reconnaissance with 12 ‘Harvard IIB’ aircraft, two-seat military trainers that the IAF operated during Independent India’s early years, but which were later weaponised and used for combat during the 1947 Kashmir war and the 1965 and 1971 wars against Pakistan. The squadron took years to become fully operational due to a shortage of jets, finally receiving the British fighter jet, the Vampire, in September 1955, marking the IAF’s formal entry into the jet age.



JASBIR MALHI

One of the Indian Air Force’s most storied fighter units, No. 17 Squadron has flown in some of the most defining operations: the 1961 liberation of Goa, the India-Pak wars of 1965 and 1971, Kargil, the Balakot strikes and Operation Sindoor. MANRAJ GREWAL SHARMA on what has held the men and their machines together for 75 years



(Clockwise from above) 17 Squadron in Bathinda led by then Wing Commander Sanjay Dandapani in 1996; a Rafale rehearsing at the Hindon airbase in 2020; Squadron Leader Ajay Ahuja with his wife Alka. Ajay’s MiG-21 was downed by a Pakistani Stinger missile in the Kargil war

From then on, No. 17, currently based in Ambala, has flown some of the best aircraft in the IAF’s arsenal. In 1957, the Vampires gave way to a swept-wing fighter, the Hawker Hunter, with pilots sent to Britain for training. MiG-21s followed over the decades, and the Rafale arrived in September 2020.

Air Commodore (retd) A L Deoskar, who joined No. 17 in 1974 and served two tenures, says the move to the Soviet-era MiG-21 was a defining moment. “The MiG-21 was more challenging.”

He remembers a culture of total readiness: two aircraft on the operational platform, armed, ready within two minutes. “There is no such thing as rest for a pilot. Either you are fighting a war or preparing for one.”

The squadron has given the IAF two chiefs: Air Chief Marshal LM Katre, who died in harness in 1985, and Air Chief Marshal Dhanoa, who commanded No. 17 in Kargil — a period that marked what’s arguably the unit’s most defining moment.

‘I have been hit’

At his Mohali home, with his cosy study almost a shrine to the IAF, Dhanoa sits back to talk about No. 17. Ask him what makes the Golden Arrows unforgettable, and Dhanoa speaks not just of gallantry awards but of a bond the fighter pilots share with each other.

He recalls one such connection, the one he had with Squadron Leader Ahuja. Both he and Ahuja had served together in No. 101 and No. 29 squadrons and were A2QFI, the highly skilled category for a flying instructor.

The following year, Ahuja and Dhanoa would find themselves in the thick of the Kargil war.

For Alka Ahuja, Ahuja’s wife who now runs a petrol pump in New Delhi, that year in Bathinda, where No. 17 had its base then, had seemed entirely ordinary. “We were there for only a year. I was teaching and my son Ankur was in Class 1. I was never worried about my husband, because he loved to fly, and loved to help others.” Ahuja had already ejected once, in 1989, and knew the terrain. “So I had no fears when the Kargil war broke out.”

After all, Ahuja and the others were prepared for every eventuality. One of those days in Kargil, when a Canberra was hit by a Pakistani missile during a reconnaissance mission, the Golden Arrows ran their own internal debrief.

Their pilots typically flew in from Srinagar at over 18,000 feet. Their primary threat was the Stinger, a shoulder-fired mis-

sile with a small warhead fired by the Pakistan military. The squadron concluded a hit might damage an engine, even if it wouldn’t destroy the aircraft. But at that altitude, it would be fatal for the pilot to eject. “So we said, in case of any such eventuality, stay with the aircraft. Glide as much as you can. If you see a valley, go into it. Come as low as possible, then eject,” Dhanoa recalls. “Below 10,000 feet, you can walk away.”

That’s what Ahuja did on May 27, but he ended up a little over a kilometre in enemy territory.

That day, 9 Squadron’s Flight Lieutenant Nachiketa’s MiG-27 was hit, and he ejected. His formation leader, Flight Lieutenant K Mandhot, radioed that his number two (the pilot who follows closely behind) was down and that he himself was low on fuel. “Ahuja responded, ‘I have the coordinates. I will come,’” Dhanoa recalls him saying.

Ahuja took off from Srinagar, with Flight Lieutenant P G Reddy flying close behind. As Ahuja approached the crash site, Mandhot warned him that missiles were being fired. “Roger,” came the reply from the cockpit. Ahuja kept orbiting the site, trying to locate the wreckage so that he could guide a helicopter to rescue Nachiketa. At one point, Reddy reported low fuel and turned back, and Ahuja was alone watching the site. It was then that a Stinger hit him. “He called out: ‘I have been hit.’ His engine had flamed out,” recounts Dhanoa.

An Indian post called Devil’s Eye watched Ahuja go down and be surrounded by enemy troops. This was before noon. Hours later, the news reached Dhanoa as he sat in the Srinagar Mess.

Ahuja’s body was returned the next day. The post-mortem revealed torture injuries and two bullet wounds. Dhanoa’s anger hasn’t faded. “He was a POW [Prisoner of War]. We don’t expect a civilised nation to torture and kill him. India and Pakistan are both signatories to the Geneva Convention.”

Nachiketa was freed following political pressure and sent back on June 5.

For Ahuja’s wife Alka, the shock was sharpened by the man she knew. “He loved helping others,” she says. “It has been almost three decades since my husband died, but the squadron officers remain in touch with me. They are like family.”

After Ahuja’s death, Group Captain Alok Choudhry took over as flight commander. The mood in the squadron was of raw anger. “Everybody wanted to strike back,” says Choudhry, who went on to command the Squadron from 2003 to 2005.

Until then, No. 17 had been primarily a fighter-reconnaissance unit, flying low and fast with cameras to take pictures. Now they wanted to bomb but weren’t trained for the high-altitude bombing Kargil demanded, and were told they had to release weapons from at least 4 km above target, with no established tables (calculations) for these conditions. So Dhanoa

built new ones. At 15,000-16,000 feet, the air was far thinner, meaning a bomb would overshoot its target. “We calculated the air-density ratio and worked out a new figure for the bomb’s forward throw. Then we tested it at a range near Srinagar,” Dhanoa says.

On June 3, Dhanoa and Reddy dropped bombs on Peak 5140 behind Tololing. “After that, we became more accurate,” says Dhanoa. The Army gave daily feedback. If a target wasn’t hit, the Golden Arrows went back. Their light MiG-21s could pull out of the dive, letting pilots watch impact and report back.

Air Marshal Vinod Patney later told the squadron that roughly 80% of its bombs had hit the target. This was so remarkably accurate that MiG-23 and MiG-27 units are said to come asking how they had done it. The answer was a formula built within the squadron itself.

Fought hard, partied harder

Beyond these stories of combat are those the pilots recount of each other. Of the 21-year-old “baby of the squadron” who worked as hard as he partied; the son of a shopkeeper from Palwal who soared to become Air Commodore; of a second-generation pilot who learnt early lessons in leadership from his father.

Air Commodore K A Muthanna (Retd) was 21 when he joined in 1982 as the youngest pilot on Bathinda’s MiG-21s. The four years he spent in the squadron, he says, became the foundation of a 33-year career that eventually made him chief test pilot at Hindustan Aeronautics Limited, flying the maiden test flight of the Tejas.

He says that as part of their training, the squadron would intentionally explore untried, highly hazardous conditions to master low-level night operations. They would fly extremely low over the desert, even at night, first by the phases of the moon, then pushed into total darkness.

And then there were the weekends. Saturday evenings meant hours at the bar and fancy-dress parties that became elaborate productions. Muthanna once welcomed guests in a grass skirt, another time he wore a hat with a glowing bulb and called himself “the enlightened one”. “Those were roaring times. No mobiles, no televisions. All we had was each other,” he says.

The nicknames survive too — Muthanna became “Muthu,” then “Mutts”; Suresh Malkani was “Malks”. All Guptas were Guffus, Grewals were Garry, tall pilots were “shorties,” short ones “*lambu*”. Even the jets sometimes got names.

Then there is Air Commodore (Retd) Ramesh Goyal, who took an unusual flight path to reach the cockpit. The son of a shopkeeper in Palwal, Goyal was the first in his family to attend a Sainik School, and the first in the Haryana town to reach the NDA. He joined the squadron as a young flying officer in 1978. “I was crazy about flying,” says

the man who spent four-and-a-half years with the squadron and flew 1,000 sorties.

He remembers seniors like B B Soni, awarded a Vir Chakra for shooting down a Pakistani fighter over Jamnagar in 1971. That year, No. 17 did a stellar job, providing vital air support to the Army from Hasimara, West Bengal.

The squadron has always been fiercely competitive, Goyal says, ensuring each of its aircraft was fully ready to fly combat missions when needed.

Once, with 18 aircraft but only 14 or 15 pilots available, the station commander, Upkar Singh, a war veteran who was nearly 60, flew himself so that every aircraft could get airborne. They formed the number 17 in the sky. “It was quite a feat,” he says. Another memory: Prince Charles visiting the squadron at Halwara in 1979.

Group Captain (retd) Sanjay Dandapani’s childhood memories served him much later, when he commanded No. 17 from 1995 to 1997. His father, “Dandoo” had been the first commanding officer of the radar unit at Amritsar during the 1965 war with Pakistan. Dandapani was in Class 5 then, and his was the only family that stayed on in the city, he says. When Pakistani aircraft thundered in, he, along with his mother and younger brother, would run into a trench dug in their garden.

What he remembers most vividly, though, is how the city responded. “People would refuse to take money for milk and other things from my mother. They were amazing.” He drew two lessons from it: “We have to look out for each other, in the air and on the ground. And as a commander, you have to lead from the front.”

It’s a spirit, he says, that is also part of the squadron’s DNA. As Dhanoa puts it, “Your merit is tangible, your flights, hits, misses, all are recorded.”

Quite literally, that is. Like other IAF units, No. 17 keeps a detailed record of its operations and social life in a handwritten squadron diary, but with a distinction. Here, wartime events are written in red ink; everything else, in blue. The diary records battles, but also people, parties, wins, losses and reunions.

The 1999 Kargil War entry ends with a photograph of Ahuja, and an epitaph: “And so he passed over, and all the trumpets sounded for him on the other side...”

There are other rituals the diary mentions: “bouncing”, where bachelors descend uninvited on a married officer’s home for a late-night meal, and the slosh dance (present IAF chief A P Singh is known to enjoy it). “I don’t quite fancy all that jumping around, but everyone in the squadron, including my wife, loves it. They did it on my lawn when they called on me,” Dhanoa laughs.

75 years later

On September 10, 2020, the Golden Arrows were reborn as the IAF’s first Rafale squadron. Dhanoa had himself flown the Rafale in France in 2017, after India signed the deal in 2016.

In Operation Sindoor last year, the squadron’s Rafales were part of the IAF’s response. Dhanoa proudly states the squadron was subsequently awarded two Vir Chakras, four Vayu Sena Medals and 10 mentioned-in-dispatches.

In 2024, the 25th anniversary of Kargil brought former pilots and ground staff together at Subroto Park in Delhi. It’s unusual for a squadron to gather in such numbers a quarter-century after a war, says Dhanoa, but not for the Golden Arrows.

Alka Ahuja remains part of that circle. She will meet the old squadron again on October 1, the 75th anniversary celebrations of the squadron. So will Dhanoa. So will the men who flew Hunters, MiG-21s and Rafales, and those who remember them. And there will also be memories of those no longer there.

Seventy-five years after the Golden Arrows were raised with a handful of Harvards, their story has travelled through every theatre of Indian military aviation, from Goa to Hasimara, Kargil, Balakot and Sindoor, from the Harvard to the Vampire, the Hunter, the MiG-21, and now the Rafale. But perhaps the most remarkable part of the story is that the men who once flew together still think of themselves as one squadron.

Every May 27, Dhanoa calls Alka. And every October 1, the Golden Arrows come home to one another.

• **The aircraft that No. 17 Squadron flew**



HARVARD IIB: Two-seat military trainers which were weaponised and used during 1947 Kashmir war and 1965 and 1971 wars against Pakistan



DE HAVILLAND VAMPIRE: The first jet to land on an aircraft carrier, in 1945, it looked a bit like a winged tadpole



HAWKER HUNTER: Pilots have long called the fighter, which flew faster than the speed of sound, one of the best-looking jets

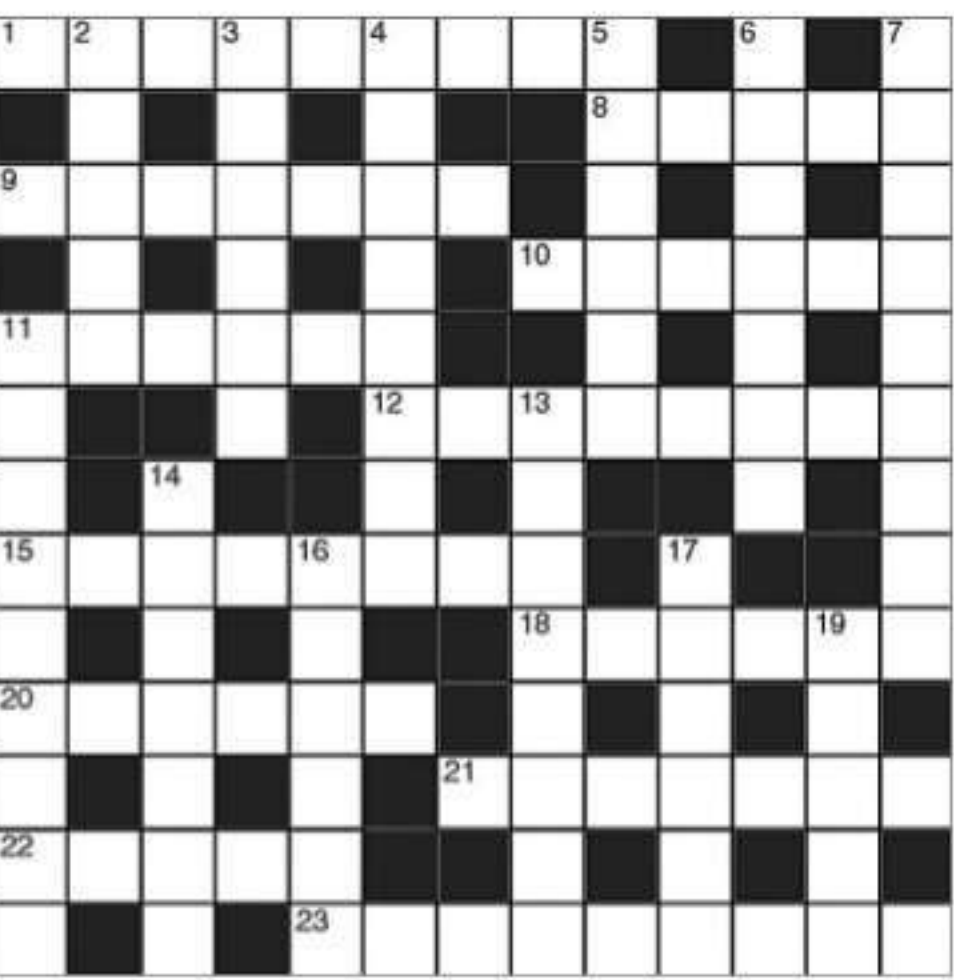


MIG-21: The Soviet-era fighter became the world’s most-produced super-sonic fighter. The aircraft left little room for mistakes



DASSAULT RAFALE: France’s twin-engine fighter is designed to fight enemy aircraft, strike targets deep in enemy territory, carry nuclear weapons

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Lacking a clue - strangely unimportant (9)
8 Doctor goes after bad French port in Sweden (5)
9 It's checked for drink and meat around midnight (7)
10 Swears it could be a sea fish (6)
11 An academic is killed while hunting (6)
12 A revealing piece of photography (8)
15 Same ship, different stress (8)
18 Smart thing to have in the garden (6)
20 A right squabble about the price list (6)
21 Indicate there's some wine to finish off (7)
22 Appear on stage to record (5)
23 Successfully learning how to handle new emigrants (9)

DOWN
2 Classic appearing in 151 AD (5)
3 Exhort one not to lose heart - it's most important (6)
4 Becomes less refined giving a hundred different reasons (8)
5 It grows by more development (6)
6 Big shot in the film world? (5-2)
7 A short romance (9)
11 Not so busy types sent in a busy type's place (9)
13 Permit dad's fun and games (8)
14 Stimulating apparitions? (7)
16 State in a loud and resolute way (6)
17 He may well appeal to the public (6)
19 General rule to be observed in a cathedral (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6106 ACROSS: 1 Screwed, 4 About, 7 Nosh, 8 Fair Isle, 10 Stagnation, 12 Become, 13 Steady, 15 Make a scene, 18 Open-eyed, 19 Stag, 20 Merit, 21 Dimples DOWN: 1 Sends, 2 Research, 3 Dearth, 4 Air hostess, 5 Oust, 6 Therapy, 9 Enemy agent, 11 Parental, 12 Boxroom, 14 Defend, 16 Edges, 17 Beer

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

_____ is a bitter disappointment for which no remedy exists, unless laughter can be said to remedy anything - Kurt Vonnegut (8)

IOTAR

GTIID

HNRUTU

MYOSIN

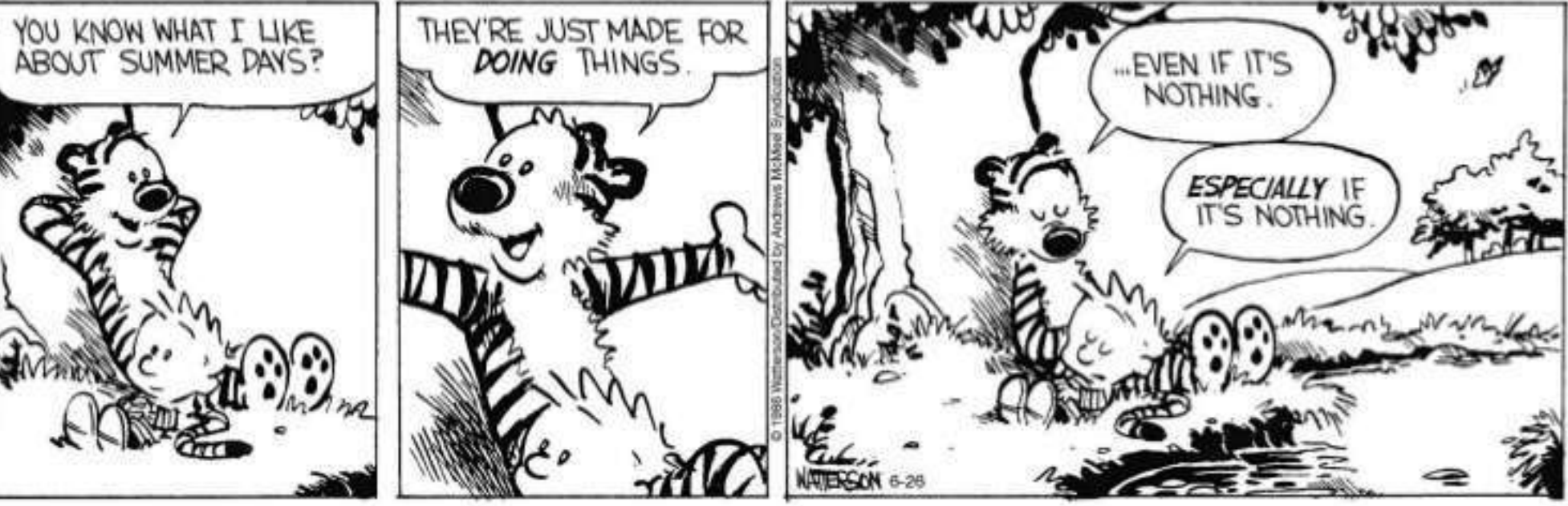
ANSWER: Maturity is a bitter disappointment for which no remedy exists, unless laughter can be said to remedy anything - Kurt Vonnegut

SOLUTIONS: Ratio, Unhurt, Simony

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6457

		6			4			
1		9	4				8	
9		6	5				3	
	4	2	1	8		3		
	9				8			
3		7	5	9		6		
5		4	7				6	
4		5	3			9		
	8				7			

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6456

3	5	7	6	4	8	9	1	2
9	6	8	5	2	1	4	7	3
1	2	4	9	3	7	6	8	5
8	3	2	4	6	9	7	5	1
7	9	1	2	8	5	3	4	6
6	4	5	7	1	3	2	9	8
5	8	9	3	7	2	1	6	4
2	7	6	1	5	4	8	3	9
4	1	3	8	9	6	5	2	7

ROYAL STARS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Your communication skills are excellent. Wait until the moon alert is over to commit to any important decisions or ideas. Tap into your creative talents today. It's also a lovely day to talk and enjoy sports and kids' activities. Tonight: Lively discussions.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): After the moon alert today, you're on your game when it comes to financial matters. In particular, you have energy to make home improvements, especially to recycling, garbage areas, plumbing and bathrooms. Tonight: Check your money.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Today the moon is in your sign dancing with Mars, Neptune and Pluto, which is empowering. You have lots of mental energy to talk to others and get things done. Tonight: You win.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Family discussions and home repairs are on your mind, and today you might use some persuasion to improve your finances. Be clear when talking to bosses and authority figures. Accept invitations to socialise today, because you're happy to talk to someone and share your ideas. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Discussions with friends, groups and organisations will be lively today. You might discuss a makeover or improving something. This is a high-energy day full of appointments, errands and productivity, especially after the moon alert is over. Tonight: Be friendly.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): People notice you today, which is a good thing, because you make an excellent impression on everyone. Others see you as positive and friendly yet powerful. Postpone financial decisions until after the moon alert today. Tonight: You're admired.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): The Sun and Mercury are in your sign, which makes you eager to talk. Issues related to politics, higher education medicine or the law might be discussed today. Tonight: Learn something new.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Be aware of the restrictions of the Moon Alert today. However, after that, go after what you want. You're in a strong position today, and you might use your money, resources and influence to help someone at work. Tonight: Check your finances.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): You might have to go more than halfway when dealing with others today. Discussions about travel, publishing and education will appeal. Discussions with partners and spouses might be intense. Tonight: Be cooperative.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): You make a great impression on everyone at this time because the Sun is high in your chart. Discussions about finances and shared property will go your way. Tonight: Get better organised.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Although relations with partners and spouses might require patience, this is actually a fun-loving, sociable day for you. Make an effort to enjoy the company of others. Tonight: Enjoy socialising.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You might prefer to relax at home today. Although, something might interrupt that. You also have a lot of energy to make home improvements and possibly some elegant purchases — after the moon alert is over. Tonight: Cocoon at home.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Harsh Kumar, S/o: Lt. Vinod Kumar, R/o: H.No. 2/34, Gali No. 1, Ghati Road, Punjabi Basti, Anand Parbat, Karol Bagh, Delhi-110055** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 272/23, U/s 392/411 IPC, P.S.: Bara Hindu Rao, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Harsh Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Harsh Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Harsh Kumar** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 272/23, U/s 392/411 IPC, P.S.: Bara Hindu Rao, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.11.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Mansi Malik
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate-02
Room No. 296A, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/13816/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Meena Kumari, W/o. Sudesh Kumar, R/o. Gali No. 1, Mata Wali Gali, Near Mother Dairy, Mandoli Village, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case vide **FIR No. 1373/2014 U/S 186/353 IPC** registered at **P.S Khajuri Khas, North East District, Delhi** and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest there upon issued stating that the said **Meena Kumari** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Meena Kumari** is absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Meena Kumari**, accused of **FIR No. 1373/2014 U/S 186/353 IPC, P.S Khajuri Khas, North East District, Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.10.2026**.

By Order, Ms. Norma Jain,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03,
North East, Room No. 22, First Floor,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi.

DP/13834/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C

Whereas complaint has been made before me that Accused No.1 **Mohit Joon**, office at Plot 460, Udyog Vihar Phase-III, Sector-20, Gurugram, Haryana-122016 Also at: 34, Sultanpur Estate, Chattarpur, New Delhi-110074, Accused No.2 **Prashant Gupta**, office at Plot 460, Udyog Vihar Phase-III, Sector-20, Gurugram, Haryana-122016 Also at: 34, Sultanpur Estate, Chattarpur, New Delhi-110074 & Accused No.3 **Rohit Joon**, office at Plot 460, Udyog Vihar Phase-III, Sector-20, Gurugram, Haryana-122016 Also at: 34, Sultanpur Estate, Chattarpur, New Delhi-110074 have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide CC No. NI Act 7283/2023 U/S 138 NI Act registered at **P.S. Okhla Indl. Area, South East District, New Delhi** and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest there upon issued stating that the said **Mohit Joon, Prashant Gupta & Rohit Joon** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Mohit Joon, Prashant Gupta & Rohit Joon** are absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Mohit Joon, Prashant Gupta & Rohit Joon**, accused of CC No. NI Act 7283/2023 U/S 138 NI Act, registered at **P.S Okhla Indl. Area, South East District, New Delhi** are required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.10.2026**.

By Order, Shubhangi Srivastava,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05 (NI Act),
Court No.38, Block-2m, New Building,
South East, Saket Court, New Delhi.

DP/13850/SE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Paramjeet Singh S/o Sh. Sajjan Singh R/o VPO- Siana Aidan, Tehsil-Pehowa, Distt. Kurukshetra, Haryana** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 70/2009 U/S 420/468/471/511 IPC, PS Chanakya Puri, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Paramjeet Singh** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Paramjeet Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Paramjeet Singh** of **FIR No. 70/2009 U/S 420/468/471/511 IPC, PS Chanakya Puri, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **03.12.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Animesh Kumar
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
Room No. 32, Lok-up Building
Patiala House Court, New Delhi

DP/13657/NDD/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **M.L. Uppal, R/o: Flat No. 6 Ekta Apartment Geeta Colony Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CT No. 52170/2016 U/s 200 CRPC P.S.: Geeta Colony Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **M.L. Uppal**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **M.L. Uppal**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **M.L. Uppal**, accused of **CT No. 52170/2016 U/s 200 CRPC P.S.: Geeta Colony Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.10.2026**.

By Order
Mrs. Prerna Rai
JMFC-02 East District, Courts No. 15
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/13759/SHD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Monu S/o Uday Veer R/o 1/381, Trilokpuri, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 516/2015 U/s 325/341/506/34 IPC, P.S. Kalyanpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Monu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Monu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Monu** of case **FIR No. 516/2015 U/s 325/341/506/34 IPC, P.S. Kalyanpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.11.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Prigya Gupta
Chief Judicial Magistrate
East District, Court No. 29
Karkardooma Courts, New Delhi

DP/13865/ED/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Mohit @ Monu, S/o Sh. Vijay Pal, R/o 1) H.No. 72, Gali No. 3, Khatik Mohalla, Swarn Park, Mundka, Delhi-110041, 2) Gram Phattepur Pathrauli, Post Bhatauli, Sandila, Behander, Fahatepur Pathraully (Purab), P.O. Beheander, District Hardoi, UP-241201** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 208/2025, U/s 75/329(4)/332/ 351(2) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023 & 10 POC SO, P.S. Mundka, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Mohit @ Monu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Mohit @ Monu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Mohit @ Monu** accused of **FIR No. 208/2025, U/s 75/329(4)/332/351(2) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023 & 10 POC SO, P.S. Mundka, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.11.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Shivaji Anand
Additional Sessions Judge-06 (POCSO), West
Room No. 22, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/13854/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sagar Vashist, S/o: Sanjiv Kumar, R/o: H.No. 282, Village Prahlad Pur Bangar, Shahbad Dairy, Outer North, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 11260/2023, U/s: 379/411 IPC, Police Station North Rohini, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sagar Vashist** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sagar Vashist** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sagar Vashist** of **Police Station North Rohini, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.11.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Aakanksha
JMFC-03, North West,
1st Floor, Room No. 107,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/13645/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Rishabh @Suraj @Chirag S/o Late Jagdish Lal R/o Jhuggi No. D-224, Jahangirpuri, near Prayas, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 21757/2019 U/s 379/411/34 IPC, PS Wazirabad, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Rishabh @Suraj @Chirag** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rishabh @Suraj @Chirag** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Rishabh @Suraj @Chirag** in **FIR No. 21757/2019 U/s 379/411/34 IPC, PS Wazirabad, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.10.2026**.

By order
Sh. Aakash Mohan Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-12 (Central)
Room No. 264, 2nd Floor
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/13813/N/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Govind S/o Umesh, R/o Gali No. 4, Shubhan Kulfi wale ka makan, 2nd Pusta, New Usmanpur, Shastri Park, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 860/2022 U/s 25 ARMS ACT, PS Shastri Park, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Govind** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Govind** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Govind** in **FIR No. 860/2022 U/s 25 ARMS ACT, PS Shastri Park, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **18.11.2026**.

By order
Ms. Norma Jain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No. 22, First Floor, North East District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/12093/NE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Rinku @ Manoj, S/o: Ashok, R/o: Gali No. 1, Part-1st, Mukundpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 930/2014, U/s 380/411/457/34 IPC, P.S.: Burari, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Rinku @ Manoj** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rinku @ Manoj** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Rinku @ Manoj** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 930/2014, U/s 380/411/457/34 IPC, P.S.: Burari, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.11.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Payal Singal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-09 (Central)
Room No. 286, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/13633/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Vicky Bind S/o Sh. Parmeshwar Bind R/o Jhuggi DRP Line, Pul Mithai, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 695/2024, U/s 304(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Burari, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Vicky Bind** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Vicky Bind** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Vicky Bind** of case **FIR No. 695/2024, U/s 304(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Burari, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **30.10.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Payal Singal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-09
Central, Room No. 286
Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi

DP/13807/N/2026
(Court Matter)

MEDAL TALLY

Po	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	143	62	49	254
2	Japan	45	71	67	183
3	S Korea	24	27	44	95
4	Uzb'stan	14	17	13	44
5	Thailand	12	9	12	33
10	India	6	21	25	52

DAY 11 CAPSULE

Haul: 2 Gold, 1 Silver, 4 Bronze

2 GOLD

● **Women's individual trap**
Neeru Dhanda produced an Asian Games record to bag India's first gold in this event.

● **Women's 4x400m relay**
Kiran, Prachi, Vithya Ramraj and Machetirra Poovamma brought home India's only athletics gold of the edition with a timing of 3:29.69.

SILVER

● **Women's trap team**
Neeru, Manisha Keer and Aashima Ahlawat collectively ended second behind China.

4 BRONZE

● **Women's high jump**
Pooja Singh, 19, produced a best jump of 1.84m to claim bronze on countback.

● **Men's 4x400m relay**
Dharmveer Choudhary, Manu Thekkinalil, Jay Kumar and Vishal TK failed to defend India's title in the event, finishing with 3:00.32.

● **Mixed 4x100m relay**
Gurindervir Singh, Sneha Sathyanarayana, Animesh Kujur and Harita Bhadra broke the national record with 41.06, but ended behind Thailand and China.

● **Men's 5000m**
Gulveer Singh won his third medal of the Games with a timing of 13:32.75. Avinash Sable did not start the race.

TODAY'S PICKS

DAY 12

Archery: Compound women's team semifinal (5:55 AM), Compound mixed team semifinal (7:55 AM), Compound men's team semifinal (10:55 AM)

● The Indian women and men will both face South Korea, while the mixed team takes on Thailand. All three teams are defending champions.

Shooting: Trap mixed team final (11 AM if qualified)

● Neeru Dhanda will eye her third medal of the edition, alongside Kynan Chenai.

Hockey: Women's semifinal (3:30 PM)

● An unbeaten India take on South Korea in their quest to end a 44-year wait for gold.

SUPREME IN TRAP

From hospital bed to top of the podium: Neeru's journey

Ten days ago, the shooter was admitted to a Delhi hospital; on Tuesday, she shot an Asiad record to win India's fifth gold



Mihir Vasavda Nagoya, September 29

TEN DAYS before she won a historic Asian Games gold medal, Neeru Dhanda was in a hospital bed, so ill that it was touch and go whether she would make it to Nagoya at all. For three-and-a-half weeks, the Indian trap shooter had not trained. During the national camp in New Delhi, she spent most of her time confined to her room. For five days, she did not eat anything, surviving only on water. By the time she reached Japan for the Asian Games, the 26-year-old had barely had the opportunity to prepare for the competition that would define her career.

And yet, on Tuesday, as rain lashed the shooting range in Urenocho, in rural Toyota, Dhanda stood atop the podium, having done what no Indian woman had managed before, and no Indian shooter irrespective of the gender had since 1978: win an individual gold medal in trap shooting at the Asian Games.

She hit 28 of her 30 targets in the final, setting an Asian Games record and finishing ahead of China's Sun Yunong, who took silver with 26 hits. It was India's fifth gold medal at the Games and a landmark moment for a discipline in which the country had long struggled to reach the top of the podium.

The significance of Dhanda's triumph stretched well beyond India's medal tally. Not only had an Indian woman won this title at the Asian Games for the first time, it also brought an end to a decades-long wait for the country to claim the event's gold.

The last Indian to win the trap gold was Randhir Singh, in 1978, as China and Kuwait dominated the event in the last 30 years. In the women's competition, introduced at the

Asian Games in 1990, China won gold in every edition except 2010, when Japan's Yukie Nakayama claimed the title.

Dhanda, who also topped the qualifying round, had broken that pattern, and did so after a preparation that had been anything but conventional.

After picking up an infection during the camp, Dhanda said her 'condition was quite bad'. Her coach, Arjuna Award winner Mansher Singh, kept calling her during the illness and throughout her stay in Japan, ensuring she remained in the right mind space.

"Every day, he kept me motivated, saying, 'Nothing happens, even if you don't train for four-five days, it doesn't make any difference. You are super, and you will remain a star,'" Dhanda said, adding that she also received messages of support from former MP Sports Minister Yashodhara Raje.

Peter Wilson, India's trap shooting coach, was struck by the scale of her recovery. "That's what's incredible. Ten days ago she was in hospital for three days. She was really, really sick and it was touch and go whether she would come," Wilson said. "She has not trained for three-and-a-half weeks. She shot for two days here. She is very talented, but she puts a huge amount of work in. Put the work in and the results will come."

The illness had left Dhanda with little time to regain her form. But the confidence she had built over years of training, and the reassurance from Mansher, helped her approach the competition without dwelling on what she had missed.

Dhanda's journey to the top had begun in Jind, after watching her cousin, and shotgun shooter, Lakshya Sheoran win silver in the trap event at the 2018 Asian Games.

Sheoran's parents introduced her to the sport and five years ago, she moved to Bhopal to train at the Madhya Pradesh State Shooting Academy,



Neeru Dhanda topped the qualifying round before missing just two shots in the final. PTI

Number Plate

48 Number of years after which an Indian won an individual trap gold medal at Asian Games. Randhir Singh (1978) is the only other shooter from the country to do so.

28 Neeru's score in the final, which is an Asian Games record.



where access to equipment and structured coaching helped her develop.

The early promise has since translated into major international success. Dhanda, who won the Asian Championship gold last year, arrived in Japan after becoming the first Indian woman to win an individual trap gold at an ISSF World Cup in July. But the Asian Games presented a different challenge, particularly with her preparation disrupted by illness.

Rain factor

On Tuesday, the weather offered

little respite. Rain poured down on the shooting range in Urenocho, the drops striking the shooters' hands as they took aim. The conditions were familiar to Dhanda from competitions in India, particularly in Bhopal, where rain often interrupts training and trials. But the intensity of the downpour in Japan made it harder to maintain concentration. "The challenge here was that rain was coming from above, falling on the hands, you feel it, and the mind strays a bit from the process," she said.

Her response was to keep returning to the basics, reminding herself to stay focused even as the weather threatened to distract her. "Neeru, this will happen; even if a storm comes, don't look down on yourself, keep looking up, elevate your process, polish yourself," she recalled telling herself.

That discipline was evident in the final. So precise was she that by the time the final shots were fired, she had established a clear advantage over Sun Yunong and secured the gold.

The victory margin may suggest it was comfortable for the Indian. "(But) This was not easy. I made it look easy so that future juniors and other Indian players who are currently training in trap shooting, shotgun, and overall — meaning for the whole shooting team — can go on to win gold, thinking that if Neeru can do it, so can we," she said.

Ankush, Parveen within 1 win of gold



Ankush Panghal after his win against Fazliddin Erkinboev. ASIAN BOXING

Nitin Sharma Chandigarh, September 29

BEFORE ANKUSH Panghal took to the ring to face Fazliddin Erkinboev in the Asian Games semifinal on Tuesday, India's men's head coach CA Kutappa explained to his ward, with the help of footage from an earlier bout, where the Uzbek could be hurt.

The attention to detail was called for. Erkinboev is the reigning world champion in the 75kg class and even though he had made the step up to the 80kg category at Aichi-Nagoya, remained a formidable opponent.

The coach and pugilist decided that a combination of the right hook and left jab could work against the world champion. As Panghal became the first Indian male boxer since Amit Panghal in 2018 to enter the Asian Games final with a 4-1 win over Erkinboev, the head coach said the strategy was based on the Uzbek's weakness against southpaws.

With both boxers being southpaws, Ankush started the first round relying only on his left straight jabs while the Uzbek depended on combinations of the left straight punch and right hook. Erkinboev, who had knocked out Sri Lankan Muhammad Usait Yazmin in the quarters, won the opening round with a split 4-1 decision.

"Ankush changed his tactics a bit in the later part of the first round. It meant that we did not lose the first round on all five judges' counts," Kutappa said.

Ankush would come up with the moves very early in the second round with his combination of left cross and right hook finding the target, while keeping his distance to evade the Uzbek's attacks. After the Indian took the second round 3-2 on the judges' score card, Ankush went with the tactic of fighting from close and medium range, switching styles frequently in the final round to win it 5-0 to enter the gold medal bout.

"The second round was all

about the tactics in the later part of the first round and Ankush did that with control. All the focus was on the left cross and right hook, and also upper cuts as one needs to hit on the upper side to impress the judges. Once he won the second round and the bout was almost level, Ankush fought from close and medium range. He knows how to mix straight and cross punches and his blows from both the hands are good. The good thing was that he didn't lose hope after the first round and fought with a clear mind and tactics," the coach said.

More good news

Meanwhile, Parveen Hooda became the third Indian woman boxer to enter the Asian Games final after Mary Kom (2024) and Lovlina Borgohain (2022). Hooda, who had beaten 2025 Worlds silver medalist Uzbekistan's Navbakhor Khamidova in the quarters, scored another 5-0 win over China's Li Shu in the 65kg class on Tuesday. The Chinese had defeated world champion Aida Abikeeva of Kazakhstan in the quarters.

Hooda won the first round 3-2, before dominating the second unanimously before dominating the next two. The Indian will now face Paris Olympics bronze medallist (66kg) Chen Nien-chin of Chinese Taipei in the final, with the aim of becoming only the second Indian woman boxer to win an Asian Games gold medal.

"We had seen that the Chinese boxer rushes in and creates problems. So the focus for Parveen was to use her counter-punches and evade the attacks. Her left jab and right hook worked well. Chen Nien-chin had lost to Lovlina at the Tokyo Olympics in the 69kg quarters but has become a strong boxer in 65kg," said Indian women's head coach Santiago Nieva.

Meanwhile, Narender Bernal finished with a bronze medal after losing 0-5 to world champion Aibek Oralbay of Kazakhstan in the +90kg semifinal.

ALL 15 FROM ONE STATE

India's wrestling hopes at Asiad rest on Haryana, sport's biggest nursery

Prithish Raj Rohtak, September 29

AT THE Raipur Sports Academy in Sonapat, coach Kuldeep Singh watches from a distance as Francis Sangma of Meghalaya tries to take down Haryana's Rohit. He would then go on and explain to Francis the right way to execute the manoeuvre.

At the Chhotu Ram Stadium in Rohtak, coach Mandeep is watching Komal of Maharashtra very closely. He then shows her the right technique to hold the opponent's leg while attacking.

Francis and Komal are two of the many aspiring wrestlers who have moved more than 1000 kms from home to pursue wrestling excellence in Haryana.

The reason behind the likes of Francis, Komal and others like Vaishnavi Patil, who represented India at the World Championships last year, moving to Haryana is the unmatched legacy and quality the state boasts of in the sport.

Another proof is the Indian wrestling squad at the 2026 Asian Games. All the 15 wrestlers who will take the mat for India in Aichi-Nagoya hail from Haryana.

Six women, five men in freestyle and four in Greco-Roman hail from seven districts of Haryana with Jhajjar contributing five, including Olympics bronze medallist Aman Sehrawat and Tokyo Olympian Deepak Punia.

"I started as a coach around 2010 and we used to train only a handful of girls here at the stadium. The CWG medals were big but even after that there were only 10-12 girls here. Sakshi's medal was big. Within a week of her medal, we received many enquiries"

COACH MANDEEP, ON WHEN THERE WAS AN UPTICK IN FEMALE TRAINEES AT THE ACADEMY

"One of the biggest reasons for Haryana's dominance is that wrestlers and coaches here realised that the sport provides a pathway to representing India at the international level, providing money, glory and pride in the process," Kuldeep told *The Indian Express*.

Rooted in tradition

Wrestling seems part of Haryana's DNA. Before the state started producing Olympic and Asian Games medallists, dangals and mitti kushti were part of the culture.

"Kushti and sports in general are part of our tea-time discussions and you will have people dissecting bouts at tea stalls and bus stands. It is in-



Coach Mandeep during a training session at the Sir Chhotu Ram Stadium in Rohtak. PRAVEEN KHANNA

grained in the normal psyche of the state," quipped Kuldeep. But what Haryana also did better than other traditional wrestling hotbeds like Maharashtra, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan was to adapt to mat wrestling earlier and make it an integral part of the system.

"Akharas in Haryana realised that having a mat was not an option but a necessity. When I was a wrestler back in the 1990s, we would practise

both on mud and mat. As I transitioned into coaching, wrestling moved to the mat completely," he said.

After Sushil Kumar's Olympic medal in 2008, there was an astronomical boom.

"The admissions in akharas increased, people started focusing more on mat wrestling and the culture around it started developing," the coach recalled.

Sushil brought another medal home from the 2012



Wrestlers train during early morning session at the Raipur Sports Academy in Sonapat. GAJENDRA YADAV

London Olympics. Yogeshwar Dutt also won a bronze there and then came Sakshi Malik at Rio 2016, Bajrang Punia and Ravi Dahiya at Tokyo 2020, and Aman Sehrawat at Paris 2024.

"The subsequent medals gave rise to a system which produced quality wrestlers every year. The assembly line was self-sustaining."

Three of Kuldeep's wards: Sujeet Kalkal (freestyle 65 kg), Nitesh Siwach (Greco-Roman

97 kg), and Aman (Greco-Roman 77 kg) will represent India at the ongoing Asian Games.

Apart from Kuldeep's akhara in Sonapat, the likes of Chhatrasal Stadium in New Delhi, where Sushil developed as a wrestler, has also produced other Olympic medallists including Ravi and Aman.

When it comes to women wrestlers, Rohtak's Sir Chhotu Ram Stadium remains one of the biggest sources, producing

"Akharas in Haryana realised that having a mat was not an option but a necessity. When I was a wrestler back in the 1990s, we would practise both on mud and mat. As I transitioned into coaching, wrestling moved to the mat completely"

KULDEEP SINGH, ON HOW DANGALS AND KUSHTIS ARE PART OF HARYANA'S CULTURE

India's only woman wrestling medallist, Sakshi.

Challenges for women

While the male wrestlers were coming through the system, societal pressure and norms largely kept women away from the mat.

"It was a challenge. I don't remember women wrestlers when I was competing. The whole thinking was 'why should girls wrestle?'" said Mandeep, the head coach at the Chhotu Ram Stadium.

According to him, change came when the Phogat sisters — Geeta and Babita — won medals at the 2010 Commonwealth Games in New Delhi.

"I started as a coach around

2010 and we used to train only a handful of girls here at the stadium. The CWG medals were big but even after that there were only 10-12 girls here," Mandeep said.

It was Sakshi's medal that propelled the stadium to fame and resulted in more girls taking up the sport.

"Sakshi's medal was big. Within a week of her medal, we received many enquiries about admission that after a point, we had to stop," he recalled.

A decade later, three of the academy girls are part of the Indian team at Aichi-Nagoya.

"The academy has grown. Half the Indian team is from here and it has happened because the focus is on developing a system where there are multiple contenders for the same spot," explained Mandeep.

Another reason is that success in the sport brought a lot of focus on the grassroots.

"Parents became very active. If parents are passionate about a sport, it starts picking up. Kids wrestle at school, they do it on the playground and that stays with them," Mandeep said.

"I have met a lot of parents who closely follow what their kids do, how much diet they need, what their supplement requirements are. All of this creates an ecosystem that keeps churning out wrestlers."

In Haryana, wrestling isn't just a sport, it's the state's most reliable source of pride, passports and paychecks.

ASIAN GAMES

“One has to have the experience of competing at the top level to win at the top level. From the last Asian Games to now, Gulveer has that experience.” SCOTT SIMMONS, GULVEER'S COACH

5 days, 4 races, 3 medals: Gulveer's hectic, but productive, trip to Japan

He became the first Indian to win three middle and long-distance medals at a single edition of continental mega event

Prithvi Raj
New Delhi, September 29

FROM SEPTEMBER 25-29, Gulveer Singh ran four races, including three finals, finishing with three medals: Silver in 1500m and 10,000m and bronze in 5000m. He thus became the first Indian to win three middle and long-distance medals in one edition of the Asian Games.

For someone who 'only' won a bronze at the 2023 edition, Gulveer has transformed into India's flag-bearer in distance-running events over the past two years. A couple of months ago, he won two medals at the Commonwealth Games with a silver in 10,000m and a bronze in 5000m. "One has to have the experience of competing at the top level to win at the top level. From the last Asian Games to now, Gulveer has that experience. He competes with the best in the USA and is consistently participating in events across the globe. All of this has helped him in improving his racing intelligence," said Scott Simmons, who trains the Indian athlete at Colorado Springs.

Focus on recovery

Simmons is not surprised that Gulveer ran well in all four races. "He works very hard in training and doesn't miss any gym sessions or any workout. He also takes recovery seriously. Nutrition, recovery, and sleep, he takes all of it as seriously as he takes his training," he told reporters after the 5000m bronze medal. According to Simmons, Gulveer is very good at easy running. "It's the best way to recover for any long-distance runner, because you use the same muscles you use in hard training, facilitate oxygen, blood, nutrients," he said. In multi-sport events, recovery plays an important role, especially for athletes who compete in multiple events.

"I have got a personal physio, that helps a lot. After the 1500m race yesterday, I had a massage, did some stretching and gave myself proper rest knowing that I'll be running in the 5000m the next day," Gulveer said.

Three races were not in the initial plan as Gulveer doesn't train much for 1500m. But when the Athletics Federation of India

asked, it was important for him to recover after every race - including the 1500m heats.

"The 1500m medal was the byproduct of our training. I'm not a fan of an athlete running four races in five days but since we had trained to compete with the likes of (Bahrain's Birhanu) Balew, the result was going to come," Simmons added.

Vegetarian diet

A lot of elite athletes get their protein requirement from non-vegetarian food but Gulveer is one of the few who relies on other sources. Asked what he ate during these five days, he quipped, "Daal roti khayi. Aur kya khayenge (I ate pulses and chapati, what else will I eat). I'm a pure vegetarian, I don't eat chicken or eggs."

Simmons maintains it's not so common but the team is very particular about his protein intake. "We have plant-based proteins and supplements. We will test him for blood iron, serum ferritin, and use iron supplements which are safe," he added.

With three medals in his kitty at the Asian Games, Gulveer has a World Championship to look forward to and will return to his training base soon. "Gulveer will go to Delhi and there will be celebrations. He is allowed that but we have to look at the World Championships next year and the LA Olympics after that. To defeat someone like Balew at both places, he needs to train more," laughed Simmons.

Pooja shines

Pooja Singh won the bronze medal in the women's high jump to become the youngest track and field medalist at the Asian Games 2026. Pooja jumped 1.84m, far lower than her personal best of 1.93m, to finish third. But after disappointing results at the U20 World Athletics Championships and the Commonwealth Games, she at last ended her season on a high.

Competing in a strong field, Pooja was going smooth till 1.84m but failed to clear 1.87m as Uzbekistan's Barnkhon Sayfullaeva won the gold medal with 1.90m ahead of Kazakhstan's Kristina Ovchinnikova (1.87m).

India ended the athletics campaign with 24 medals - including one gold and nine silver.



Gulveer Singh, who had claimed one bronze medal at the Hangzhou Asian Games, has become India's flag-bearer in distance running. PTI

Jumpers slipping in Nagoya — not just rain

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, September 29

"I WAS praying not again." This thought crossed long jumper Murali Sreeshankar's mind just after he twisted his ankle while stepping on the take-off board during the men's long jump final at the Asian Games on Monday. Sreeshankar feared the worst. He had undergone major knee surgery in 2024 and was worried about another injury. But a day later, the 27-year-old confirmed that the injury was not serious, as "all ligaments were safe", and that six to eight weeks of rest would suffice.

The competition was fraught with risk as the athletes competed in the rain on a wet track. Sreeshankar was in silver-medal position with an 8.07m effort in his second attempt and was readying for a big jump in the fourth round when his foot slipped. He wasn't the only long jumper to slip. The reason: rain and a change in the angle and material of the take-off board made life difficult for the jumpers.

"I overstepped on the board. The take-off board has had a



Sreeshankar twisted his ankle while stepping on take-off board. PTI

new material since 2022. It was raining also. I completely slipped, and my leg rotated inwards. I sprained my ankle. Lots of athletes have faced this issue. I will be the 50th athlete to fall down. The composite material of the take-off board is pretty slippery. So it slips, and it was pouring continuously. So it was a challenge," Sreeshankar said.

The change in the angle of the board, from a slight incline to a flat surface, has resulted in jumpers slipping, more so when

it rains.

"Earlier, the board used to be inclined, but because of the new rules, World Athletics has made sure it is a flat surface. So even if we overstep, there is nothing to block. If the board were inclined, my heel wouldn't be slipping. When your heel comes in contact with the foul board, it slips. So my nails (spikes) got blocked in the synthetic, and my ankle twisted inwards. It could have been much worse. Touch wood, nothing has happened. Because yester-

day I was immediately assessed by Dr Dinshaw Pardiwala (India's chief medical officer at the Asiad), and he said all my ligaments are safe. The antero-medial capsule got torn a bit, and basically it is about rehab," Sreeshankar said.

Comparing the conditions at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games two months ago to those in Nagoya, Sreeshankar said that while it was cold and drizzling in the Scottish city, at the Asian Games it was pouring as well as hot and humid.

"In my third attempt, because of the humidity, I cramped in both my legs. So when I reached the take-off board, I didn't know if I had to complete the jump or not, but I took off," Sreeshankar said.

His first three attempts were: 7.66m, 8.07m and 7.56m. The fourth attempt was when he sprained his ankle, after which he skipped the last two rounds. "The fourth jump felt good. I took a pickle juice shot, which helps prevent cramps, and I did warm-ups. I had electrolytes. I was ready. I went for the big jump, but that is when my ankle twisted. Then I fell down."

Video of jumper Kushare's race against timer a hit in Japan



Sarvesh Kushare bagged silver with a best leap of 2.25m. AP

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 29

31-YEAR-OLD high jumper Sarvesh Kushare won the silver medal in the men's high jump, ending India's 56-year-long wait for a medal in the event. So far, so silvery-good.

But it is the video of him taking an earlier clearance of 2.18 that is being widely shared on Japanese social media, collecting over 1.3 million views. The reason? The video-watchers analysing in detail, how he came out of the stadium cave, shrugged his warmup gear in a panic on Lane 6, and broke into a run-up for his high jump, because the timer was down to 5 seconds. "And still cleared 2.18m!!". The hyper-planning Japanese are in a tizzy.

The silver was clearly still some way out, and India searching for a gold sighed at another miss. But the real chaos had unfolded earlier, and *Grok* has been summoned several times to analyse Kushare's frame-by-frame scramble.

In a spectator-video gone viral, Kushare has sprinted out of the stand caves, where jumpers wait their turn. The timer has already started and 50 seconds have passed when the Indian fetches up, realising he's still in his warmup gear. He quickly loses them, a helpful volunteer rushes to pick them up from Lane 6. And without a breath's wait, Kushare sprints towards the takeoff point on Lane 2. A hastened catapult back lean, and onto the approach run to the bar even as the worried and suddenly-invested crowd exhale. When he clears the 2.18, spontaneous applause of a "woah!" breaks up, appreciating him.

On X, they speculate on his mindset, and how the Indian had no time to think about unnecessary stuff so his senses got sharpened and he ran on instinct. "Straight up monstrous" - they gushed, because he has almost missed his time limit.

In a Games where chaos has unfolded in a million ways, the high jump final saw officials start timers arbitrarily for all jumpers leading to mad scrambles, and inviting criticism from the home viewers. But no scrambles as unforgettable as Kushare getting out of his training gear and dashing like he had a train to catch.

IRANI CUP BUILD-UP

1983, Srinagar: When India's World Cup heroes faced hostile crowd at home

Shuvaditya Bose
Srinagar, September 29

KIRTI AZAD could scarcely believe his senses.

Only 110 days had passed since he stood on the Lord's balcony, the Prudential Cup gleaming heavy in his hands, and in the intervening months he and Kapil's Devils had been swept up in nationwide adulation. Until that October morning.

What sensory organ could he trust? Close his eyes, and the air rang with cries of "Pakistan Zindabad." Shut his ears instead, and his gaze would fall upon placards raised against his team, and even posters of the erstwhile Pakistani captain, Imran Khan. Lower his gaze further still, and he would see the men holding them also held rubbish in their hands. Soon, it would be hurled, in contempt, at the Indian players. Bottles, stones, even an apple.

"It felt like I was playing in Pakistan", Azad recalls, in a candid conversation with *The Indian Express*.

He was, of course, not in Pakistan. The Chinar leaves had already begun their slow combustion into amber and rust. Beyond the ropes, the Dal Lake lay unperturbed, its surface gilded by a low autumn sun. It was, unmistakably so, India. Srinagar's Sher-i-Kashmir stadium, where, Thursday onwards, India's domestic red-



The *Indian Express*' report, dated October 13, 1983, on the One-Day International between India and West Indies in Srinagar; twelve men were arrested for digging up the pitch. EXPRESS ARCHIVE

ball champions, Jammu & Kashmir, will face Rest of India for the Irani Cup.

October 13, 1983 also fell on a Thursday. India had travelled to Srinagar for the ground's maiden international fixture, against the very Goliaths they had slain at Lord's: Clive Lloyd's West Indies.

The valley, on the eve of battle, had offered its visitors every courtesy its hospitality could muster. So did its foremost representative, Farooq Abdullah, then Chief Minister of the state, who had welcomed

the teams to a feast of the local delicacy, Wazwan.

"I remember Mr Farooq Abdullah had made lovely arrangements. The Sher-i-Kashmir stadium is one of the most picturesque grounds I have played at. The atmosphere was brilliant. That image is still etched in my memory. It was a day I would remember very fondly, until..." Azad says.

A momentary pause. Then, the caveat.

"...they dug up the pitch."

Twelve men were arrested for digging the pitch while the



players had gone for lunch. Among them were Showkat Bakshi and Shabir Shah, names that would, in time, come to occupy a prominent place in the story of Kashmiri separatism. It would take until 2011 for a court to acquit all twelve, citing lack of evidence.

A comprehensive causation report for the cumulative act, the abuse hurled, the slogans raised, the pitch vandalised, lies beyond the remit of this piece. Suffice it to say that a section of the crowd had chosen a cricket match as its stage to voice a pro-



“It was the most forgettable match of my career. The crowd was shouting anti-Indian slogans and backing the West Indies throughout.”

DILIP VENGSARKAR,
ON THE CROWD'S HOSTILE REACTION TO THE INDIAN TEAM



“Sher-i-Kashmir stadium is one of the most picturesque grounds I have played at... a day I would remember fondly, until they dug up the pitch.”

KIRTI AZAD,
ON THE BEAUTY OF THE STADIUM IN THE VALLEY



“There were a lot of Pakistani flags in the stands. I don't even remember the result or who played. But there was a lot of shouting of Imran Khan's name.”

MICHAEL HOLDING,
ON PEOPLE IN THE STANDS CHEERING FOR PAKISTAN

plebiscite sentiment.

Dilip Vengsarkar, in a career spanning 245 international appearances, has had many blemishes. None of his ducks, however, stung quite like the memory of that match.

"It was the most forgettable match of my career," he tells this masthead. "The crowd was against India. They were shouting anti-Indian slogans and displaying placards against the Indian players. They were backing the West Indies throughout."

"We didn't know about it at all. We had no idea that some-

thing like this would happen. And mind you, it was just after the World Cup, so that team was the historic team of '83."

In his book *Runs 'n Ruins*, Sunil Gavaskar explained his surprise: "There were many in the crowd shouting pro-Pakistan slogans which confounded us, because we were playing the West Indies and not Pakistan."

Michael Holding's recollection paints much the same picture. "There were a lot of Pakistani flags in the stands and not many people were cheering for

India. I don't even remember the result or who played in it. But there was a lot of shouting of Imran Khan's name, as people showed they were not supporting India," he tells *The Indian Express*.

He had dismissed Kapil Dev in the game. The tour was billed as the "Revenge Series", and West Indies served revenge cold, in the cold of Kashmir: India were bowled out for 176, and the visitors were 108/0 in 22.4 overs before a dust storm intervened, with West Indies already having done enough for the win. By